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1 John 1:1–4

1 John

1 John 1:1–4

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 1:1–4 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:1–4 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This is the beginning of John's sermon. And here at the beginning of the sermon, John already says some very important things about Jesus!

John begins by saying that he wants to tell his listeners about someone that he has heard with his own ears, seen with his own eyes, and touched with his own hands. This person John calls "the Word of life."

We know that John is talking about Jesus, even though John does not yet use Jesus' name.

And so, right away at the beginning of his sermon, John stresses that Jesus was a human being, with a body that John himself could see and touch!

Sam and Sally, the false teachers that we imagined in the introduction, would not have liked this. They liked it better to think about Jesus as a spiritual being. Sam and Sally might have thought, "Well, it might be true that the Son of God became a human, but there is no need to talk about that very much! We do not like to think very much about the Son of God as a human being. Being a human is rather dirty work. We like the spiritual Jesus better!"

The people who were listening to John's sermon knew what people like Sam and Sally were thinking. And right at the beginning of the sermon, they learn: "Jesus, the Son of God, really was a human being! John himself has seen him and has touched him. The Son of God did not just pretend to become a human, but he really was a human! Yes, even with all the bodily things like eating and body liquids and blood! We should not ignore the fact that Jesus became a human being. It really is important!"

But John continues. John says that he is writing about the "Word of life," which already existed from the beginning. Again, John is talking about Jesus.

Why does John call Jesus "the Word of life"? Well, we get to know God because of everything that God does and says. So by calling Jesus "the Word," John is telling the people that God is speaking and acting through Jesus. When we listen to what Jesus says, we are in fact listening to God. And when we see what Jesus is doing, we are in fact seeing what God is doing. And when we listen to God speaking through Jesus, and obey him, then God will give us life.

And so, John is showing us that Jesus is God. Yes, Jesus was a human being, but he was also God! Jesus is the Son of God who already existed from the beginning. Because even before Jesus became a human being, the Son of God already existed. Like God the Father, the Son of God has always been and will always be.

1 John 1:1–4

Stop here and do this activity: Ask someone to represent Jesus. Act out that "Jesus" is with God the Father. Then act out that Jesus comes to earth. Act out that Jesus' disciples see Jesus, talk with Jesus, listen to what he says, and touch him. Then, act out that one of the disciples, who is John, goes and tells other people that he has seen Jesus, that he has heard Jesus speaking, and has touched Jesus. Pause this audio here.

John says that he is writing all this so that he may be glad. John wants his listeners to believe the right things. If the people will continue to listen to John, and keep believing the right things about Jesus, then the people will have a good relationship with John. John himself has a good relationship with God the Father and with God's Son, Jesus Christ. And if the people keep listening to John, they will also have a good relationship with God and with Jesus. John does not want his listeners to be like Sam and Sally, who stopped listening to John. Because people like Sam and Sally stopped believing the right things about Jesus, they lost their good relationship with John—but also with God himself!

Stop here and do this activity: Make a circle of three people. These people represent God the Father, Jesus, and John. Let these people hold hands. Now, let the person who represents John invite other people to join the circle. John holds out his hand. Let other people take hold of John's hand. Then, John pulls those people into the circle. Everybody now holds hands with John, and with God and Jesus. All of these people have a good relationship with each other! Act out how much joy they will all have! Pause this audio here.

If John's listeners join in this good relationship with God the Father and Jesus Christ, God's Son, then John will be very glad. John is already glad because he has a good relationship with God. But John will be even more glad if the others will also join in this good relationship!

Stop here and do this activity: Maybe you can dance together in your circle to celebrate the good relationship that you have with each other, and with God!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one part.

In this part, John explains why he is writing this sermon. John wants to tell his listeners the right things about Jesus.

In the introduction, we said that John's sermon is a bit like a walk through a garden. In this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he says that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

Stop here and do this activity: Before we continue, please be sure you have the pictures or objects that you used in the introduction to create a "garden" in your room. Please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents the garden where John says that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus. Of course, this person will still participate in all the discussions and activities. Also, take one of the small rocks or objects that you had prepared in the introduction and place this in this part of the garden. This way, you will be able to see later that you have already been in this part of the garden before. Or, if you have your drawings hanging on the wall, use a pen or marker to make a sign to show that you have been there. Pause this audio here.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- "The Word of life," which is another way to speak about Jesus Christ, the Son of God
- And God the Father

John tells his listeners about someone whom he has seen himself. John says that "We have heard, seen, and touched him." When John says "we," he means John himself and the other apostles.

1 John 1:1–4

John's listeners have not seen Jesus themselves. But John tells his listeners what John and the other apostles have seen and heard, so that the believers can also know Jesus and have a good relationship with Jesus. John's listeners can trust that everything that John says is true because John has seen Jesus himself and has heard Jesus speak himself. John was part of the special group of people who lived very closely with Jesus!

John wants to proclaim to his listeners what John and the other apostles have seen and heard. If you proclaim something, you are telling something important that you want people to know. You are telling this openly because you want everybody to hear.

Stop here and do this activity: One person walks up to another person and tells the person something—for instance, that the food is ready or that there will be a party tomorrow.

Then, have the first person stand in the middle of the room and tell everybody loudly the same thing. Pause this audio here.

Now discuss: in your language, how would you explain what the person did the first time? And how would you explain what the person did the second time? Would you use different words? Pause this audio here.

Now, stop here and discuss how you will say that John proclaims what he has seen and heard. Pause this audio here now.

When John begins his sermon, John does not at first explain that he talks about Jesus. John talks about "the one who existed from the beginning," and "the Word of life," and "the life," and "the eternal life." All this refers to Jesus. But only at the end of this part does John give the name Jesus Christ. If your listeners might be confused by this, you could make it clear that John is talking about Jesus from the beginning.

Jesus is the one who "existed from the beginning," because the Son of God has always been, and will always be. Even before the creation of the world!

Jesus is the "Word of life," because God speaks through Jesus, and God gives us life through Jesus.

Jesus is the "life" because God gives us life through Jesus.

And Jesus is "the eternal life which was with the Father." This could mean that Jesus, who was with God the Father, has eternal life, or it could mean that Jesus gives eternal life. Both are true! Eternal life is the best possible kind of life that someone could have. Eternal life means that not just your body, but also your spirit, is alive. Death cannot destroy this kind of life!

Stop here and do this activity: Think of four actions or gestures that can help you to remember that Jesus is "the one who existed from the beginning," "the word of life," "the life," and "the eternal life." And yes, all these are very similar! Pause this audio here.

John is telling his listeners about Jesus, who is eternal life. But at the same time, through this sermon, John will tell his listeners how they can have eternal life.

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you may have made some flowers or plants that represented eternal life. Take one of these flowers or plants, and place them in the part of your room that represents the part of the garden where John now is, which is the part of the garden where John says that children of God believe the right things about Jesus. If you decided not to make these flowers in the introduction, you can skip this step. Pause this audio here.

John says that God "revealed" this life to us. We people could not see the Son of God when he was still with God. But when the Son of God became a human, then we could see him! God showed us the Son of God. Jesus is the son of God!

Stop here and do this activity: Select two people who will represent God and the Son of God. Make these people stand somewhere where other people cannot see them, such as behind a door or behind a sheet that some people hold up as a curtain. The other people cannot see God or the Son of God. But then, God makes the Son of God go to the other side of the door or curtain. Then, the people are able to see the Son of God! God revealed the Son of God! Pause this audio here.

1 John 1:1–4

When Jesus was born, the Son of God became a human whom we can see and touch. And in Jesus, God has revealed his Son to us.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one part.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- "The Word of life," which is another way to speak about Jesus Christ, the Son of God
- And God the Father

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out that John is speaking to his listeners. Of course, John is far away from his listeners, and the listeners cannot see John as he writes, but when you act this out as if John is speaking directly to his listeners, it will help us to understand the sermon better.

John says something like this:

"We want to tell you clearly about the person that we call 'The Word that gives life.' This person already existed from the very beginning. With our own eyes we have seen him, with our own ears we have heard his voice, and with our own hands we have touched his body! We have seen this person who is life himself, and who gives us life. We have seen him because God showed him to us. This person is the one who gives us eternal life—the best possible life!" Pause the drama. Ask the person acting as John, "What are you thinking?" The person may say something like:

- I really want my listeners to understand that I know what I am talking about! I have seen Jesus myself! And therefore I have authority to speak to the other believers; or
- I want the people to know that Jesus is the one who gives us life.

Resume the drama. John says something like this:

"And this person is Jesus Christ, the Son of God. We are telling you everything that we have seen and heard, so that you will believe what we say and have a good relationship with us. Then you will also have the same good relationship with God the Father and with his Son, Jesus Christ, as we have! That is why we are writing to you, because if you join us in this relationship, I will be even more glad than I am now!" Pause the drama. Ask the person acting as John: "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I want the people to believe the right things about Jesus; or

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- I am so glad that I have a good relationship with God the Father and with his Son, Jesus Christ. If the other believers will believe me, then they can also join in this good relationship!

Ask the people acting as John's listeners, "What are you thinking or feeling?" People may say things like:

- We really should believe everything that John says, because John has seen Jesus himself! We can trust that everything that John says is true; or
- We want to have a good relationship with John, and with God the Father, and with Jesus!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:1–4 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John writes to the believers about the **Word of life**. God speaks to his people through his actions and through his words. Therefore, people often call the Bible the "Word of God," because through the Bible we can know what God has done and said. John calls Jesus the "Word," or the "Word of life," because God speaks to us through Jesus. Jesus is the most important message that God has given to us. And when we listen to this message and believe that it is true, we will become truly alive. John calls Jesus the "Word of life," because Jesus is the one who gives us life. If we do not know Jesus, our body might be alive, but our spirit is dead. We only have real, complete, spiritual life if we belong to Jesus. Use the same word for "Word" that you used in phrases like "the word of God."

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for "Word of life." You can listen to "Word" in the Master Glossary, but remember that John is using a slightly different meaning here. Pause this audio here.

John says that this "life," meaning Jesus, was **revealed**, or became visible. When you reveal something, you show people something that they could not see before. God revealed Jesus to the people. The people did not know who Jesus was, but God showed the people that Jesus was the one who gave life.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that "this life was revealed" or that "God revealed this life." Pause this audio here.

John has seen "the life." This means John has seen the life which is Jesus. John **testifies** about "the life." If you testify about something, you are saying that you have seen it yourself and know it is really true.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that John tells, or testifies, about "the life." Use the same word or phrase for testifying as you have used in other books of the Bible. The word testify is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John tells the people what he himself and the other apostles have seen and heard. John proclaims to the other people what John has seen and heard. When you are proclaiming something, you are telling something important that you want people to know. You are telling this openly because you want everybody to hear.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that John **proclaims** what he has seen and heard. Pause this audio here.

John is telling the believers openly about the eternal life that was with the Father. The "eternal life" is again a way to talk about Jesus. Earlier, John said that this "life" was "revealed," or became visible. Now John says that the "eternal life" was with the Father. The Father means God the Father. The "life" and the "eternal life" mean the same. Jesus is the one who has the perfect quality of life, with a perfect relationship with the Father. And Jesus can give this same perfect quality of life to the believers. John calls this perfect quality of life "eternal life."

Eternal life is a much better and richer life than ordinary life. Without this gift of eternal life, we may live and breathe, but this is only physical life, and it will end as soon as we die. But the eternal life that God gives us will continue! Eternal life begins now, changing us and making it possible for us to live in a close relationship with God. When Jesus will come back and establish his kingdom forever, we will also live with him. That is the gift from God: life in the future, and real life already now! Death cannot destroy this kind of life. This is the best possible kind of life!

1 John 1:1–4

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Jesus is telling the believers about the **eternal life**, which was with the Father. The word eternal life is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John tells the believers everything that he has seen and heard. This means everything that John has seen Jesus do, and everything that John has heard Jesus say. John tells these things to his listeners so that they may have fellowship with John. People who have fellowship with each other have a very good relationship with each other. These people love each other. They trust each other. They talk with each other. They enjoy spending time together.

John wants his listeners to have this good relationship with him. John has fellowship with God the Father and with God's Son, Jesus Christ. If the believers listen to John and have good fellowship with John, they will also have this good fellowship with God the Father and with God's Son Jesus Christ, just as John has. The word fellowship is in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that John has **fellowship** with the Father and with his Son, Jesus Christ. John wants his listeners to have fellowship with him, John, so that his listeners will also have fellowship with the Father and with his Son, Jesus Christ. Pause this audio here.

Christ means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. Christ is the same as "Messiah." Messiah is the Hebrew word, and Christ is the Greek translation of this word.

When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means that Jesus is the Son of God. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word as you have used in other passages.

When John's listeners will join the fellowship that John has with the Father and with Jesus, John's joy will be complete, perfect. Someone who has joy has a deep feeling of being glad and content. Joy is different from being happy. Someone can have joy even if their situation is difficult. This kind of joy is a gift that the Holy Spirit gives to us.

Stop here and discuss what word you will use for **joy**, and how you will say that John's joy will be complete, or perfect. Use the same word for joy that you have used in other passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 1:1–4

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (697 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1008 KB)

1 John 1:5–2:2

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 1:5–2:2 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:5–2:2 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:5–2:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the beginning of his sermon, John said he wanted to tell his listeners about Jesus. John explained that Jesus is the “Word of life,” which means that Jesus is God. But John also explained that Jesus had a real body and so was a real human being. And John could know this because John had touched Jesus himself!

John wanted to tell these things to his listeners because he wanted them to have a good relationship with him, John. When the people would have a good relationship with John, and believed what John said, they also would have a good relationship with God the Father and with Jesus.

John is now going to say more about what he has heard Jesus say. Jesus gave John and the other apostles a message. John is now passing on this message to his listeners. The message is that God is light. This is another way to say that God is completely good and completely true. John says there is no darkness in God at all. That means there is no evil at all in God, and God never lies.

Because God is “light,” or good, God will immediately see if something is “dirty,” or evil. Let’s say that you have been working inside your house, and your clothes have become dirty. As long as you are inside a dark room, nobody would notice it. But as soon as you go outside, in the sunshine, people will see that your clothes are dirty. In the same way, people may not notice themselves that they are sinful, or that they are doing or thinking wrong things. But God always sees the wrong things we do, because God is light.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about light and darkness? Maybe about something that happened in the dark, that would not have happened if it had been light. Or a story from your community in which light and darkness are important. Pause this audio here.

Now, in the introduction, we imagined some people, Sam and Sally, who believed the wrong things about Jesus. Sam and Sally do not exist, but we use them as an example to explain what the wrong teaching in John’s time

1 John 1:5–2:2

might have been. Well, Sam and Sally were more interested in Jesus as a spiritual being than in Jesus as a human being. And because Sam and Sally were so interested in Jesus as a spiritual being, they were also very interested in having spiritual experiences themselves. Sam and Sally even said that people needed to have some spiritual experiences that would give them special, secret knowledge about God. Sam and Sally thought that they themselves had this special, secret knowledge. And because they thought they had this special, secret knowledge, Sam and Sally said that they had a good relationship with God. And Sam and Sally did not think that it was important to behave in the right way, and not to sin. But John says that this is not true at all! John says that people who say they have a good relationship with God but who keep doing sin are lying. These people are "walking" or living in darkness. If you walk in darkness, you are behaving in the wrong way. You are not doing what God wants you to do.

John says that people who do what God wants are living in the light. When we live in the light, we have a good relationship with other people who live in the light. And so, people who do what God wants have a good relationship with other believers.

Stop here and do this activity: One person will represent God. Give this person a light—a torch or a lamp. If you are outside, you can instead have this person stand in the sunlight. Some other people will stand near the person who represents God. These people are standing in the light. Act out that these people have a good relationship with God, and with each other. Pause this audio here.

It was important for John to say this because people like Sam and Sally had quarreled with the other believers and looked down on them. Sam and Sally thought they were better than the other people because they said they had special, secret knowledge about God. But John makes clear that if you really have a good relationship with God, you would also have a good relationship with other believers!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about believers who had trouble getting along with each other? What was the effect of this on the church? Pause this audio here.

People like Sam and Sally were not very interested in Jesus as a human being. Therefore, these people also did not think that we should behave in the way that Jesus behaved. But John says that we should walk in the light, just as Jesus himself is in the light. Someone who walks in the light does the things that God wants us to do. Jesus did what God wanted him to do. And we should be just like Jesus! And if we behave like Jesus and walk in the light, then we will have a good relationship with each other. And God will forgive us our sins!

Because people like Sam and Sally were not very interested in Jesus as a human being, they were also not very interested in Jesus' death. These people did not think that God saved us by sending his Son to die for us. These people thought, "God saved us because we know him and because we have special, spiritual experiences." Sam and Sally did not think that sin was a big problem for God. Sam and Sally did not think that the Son of God needed to die so that God could forgive our sins.

But John tells his listeners that this is wrong. God forgives us because his son Jesus died! In the Old Testament, we hear that God could only forgive people if those people killed an animal and sacrificed this to God. The animal died in place of the person who had sinned. In difficult language, we say the animal sacrifice "atoned" for the person's sins. This means that God could now forgive that person's sins. In some ceremonies, the priests took the blood of the animal that died and sprinkled this blood on the people. The blood made the people ritually clean. God had forgiven the people's sins, and now it was possible for the people again to have a relationship with God. Well, Jesus died, and he bled! And when people believe that Jesus died in their place, God forgives them their sins. It is as if someone has sprinkled the blood of Jesus on us. We are now clean: God has forgiven us, and we can have a relationship with God again. So, Jesus' death is VERY important!

Everybody does sin. If people say they do not do sin, then they are lying. And they make God look like a liar, too, because God says that everybody sins. But if we admit that we sin and tell God that we are sorry, then God forgives us. God forgives us because Jesus has died for us.

John writes this to his listeners because he wants them not to sin. John's listeners should not think, as people like Sam and Sally did, that God does not care about sin. No, we really have to do our best not to do anything that God says is wrong. But, even when we do our best, we still do sin. When this happens, we do not have to be

1 John 1:5–2:2

afraid. Jesus Christ himself is asking God the Father to forgive us! Jesus can ask this because Jesus has taken the punishment for our sins already.

Stop here, and if you do not mind getting a little bit dirty, do this activity: Take some mud, clay, flour, or paint, and have fun smearing this on your face and arms! Two people should stay clean. These people will represent God the Father and Jesus. Give the person who represents Jesus some water and a cleaning cloth. The other people go to Jesus. These people tell Jesus they are sorry. Jesus makes them clean and brings them before the person representing God the Father. Jesus asks God to forgive the people. Jesus can show God the holes in his hands from his crucifixion to show God that he has already taken the punishment for the people. God the Father then welcomes the people. Maybe God can give them a hug, if this is appropriate in your culture! Maybe one or two people can choose NOT to go to Jesus. These people say to the others, "We are not dirty! We have not sinned!" And so, these people STAY dirty. Pause this audio here.

So, in this passage, John says that God is light, which means that God is completely good and completely true. There is absolutely nothing "dark" or evil in God. God always speaks the truth and never lies.

Only people who believe the right things about God and do the good things that God wants us to do will have a good relationship with God. And when we have a good relationship with God, we will also have a good relationship with the other believers!

When we have a good relationship with God, we will confess our sins to God. Then God will forgive us, because Jesus took the punishment for our sins.

We should not do sin, but if we do, then Jesus will ask God to forgive us.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:5–2:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: John tells his listeners that God is light. Because God is light, we should not sin. We should not lie and say that we have not sinned, but we should confess our sins.

In the second part: John says that he is writing to the listeners so that they will not sin. If the listeners do sin, then Jesus will ask God to forgive them.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- Jesus
- God the Father
- People who disobey God, who "walk in darkness"
- And people who confess their sins, and God forgives them

Stop here and do this activity: In this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God do not keep sinning. Please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Also, take a small rock or object and place this in this part of the garden. This way, you will be able to see later that you have already been in this part of the garden before. Pause this audio here.

John talks about the message that "we have heard from him." "We" means John and the other people who have met Jesus when Jesus was still on earth. John and the others have learned something about God from Jesus, and John is now telling his listeners what John and the others have learned. The message is that God is light! Light in the Bible has to do with truth and with goodness. God is completely true and completely good.

1 John 1:5–2:2

John talks in this passage about people who “walk in darkness” and people who “walk in the light.” John uses the word “walking” in a special way. When John talks about people who walk in the light, John means people who believe the true message about God and who obey this. These people want to do the things that God wants.

People who walk in darkness do not know the truth. These people do not believe the right things about God. These people do the wrong things, things that God does not want. John uses the word walking to show that people are continuously doing these things. Some translations talk about people who “live in darkness” and people who “live in light,” and do not use the word walking.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that people are walking in the light, or are walking in the darkness. Pause this audio here.

In the introduction, we said that John often likes to say things in groups of three. In this passage, we hear such a group of three. Three times in this passage, John says, “If we say that….” Probably, these were three things that false teachers like Sam and Sally were saying about themselves.

Stop here and listen to an audio recording of 1 John 1:5–2:2 again. Listen if you can hear the three things that people like Sam and Sally might have said! Pause this audio here.

So, we will talk about three things that false teachers like Sam and Sally said about themselves. John will point out what is wrong, and then John will say what the believers should do instead.

First, the false teachers say that they have a good relationship with God. But John says that these people are lying. These people are, in fact, walking in darkness, which means that they do not know the truth, and they are continuously disobeying God and doing wrong things.

John tells the believers what they should do instead. Because God is light, people who really have a relationship with God would walk in the light. This means these people would do the things that God wants. And therefore, these people would also have a good relationship with the other believers. When the believers walk in the light and have a good relationship with the other believers, God forgives them their sins. God forgives the believers because Jesus died for them. When Jesus died, it was as if God sprinkled the blood of Jesus on us, just as priests in the Old Testament would sprinkle the blood of animals that they sacrificed on people who had sinned. The blood made the people ritually clean: God had forgiven the people’s sins, and now it was possible for people again to have a relationship with God.

Stop here and act out what the false teachers are saying or doing, and what the believers should do instead. Act out what God will do. Pause this audio here.

The next thing that the false teachers say about themselves is that they are not people who do sin. The false teachers think that God does not mind what people do. The false teachers don’t really believe that sin is a problem. But John says that these people are deceiving themselves. These people are telling themselves something that is not true. John says that the truth of God is not in these people. This is another way to say that these people are lying. Everything that God does and says is true. But this is not so for these people.

Instead, what the believers should do is to confess their sins to God. Then God will forgive the believers, and God will make them completely clean. God does this because God is faithful and righteous. God is faithful because God always does what he has promised. You can trust God completely. God does not change. God will forgive us if we tell God about our sins, because God has promised to forgive us.

God is “righteous.” This means that God always does what is right. God is the one who decides what is right and what is wrong. And God has decided that it is right to forgive us. Therefore, God will do it; God will forgive us.

Stop here and act out what the fake believers are saying or doing, and what the believers should do instead. Act out what God will do. Pause this audio here.

Lastly, the false teachers say that they have not sinned. This sounds almost the same as the previous thing. It could be that John is saying the same thing but with some different words, as John is doing often. But it could also be that John means it to be a bit different. It could be that the first time these people just said that they did not think that sin was a problem, and now, this second time, they say, even if some people would maybe do something wrong at times, not them!

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John had already said that these people were lying to themselves, and now John says that the people are even making God look like a liar. God says that everybody sins, but if these people say that they have not sinned, then they are in fact saying that God is lying.

John also says that God's word is not in people who lie like this. That means that everything that God has said has had no effect on them. God's word has not changed these people.

Stop here and do this activity: Collect one good container, jar, or bowl. Collect one leaky container or any other object that will not hold water, like a sieve, a leaky vessel, or a cloth bag. Fill both with water and see what happens. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, the good container that you filled with water remained full. But the other object lost the water right away. The people like Sam and Sally that John is talking about are like the leaky vessel or cloth bag that could not hold water. God's word does not work in their lives. These people do not obey God's word. They do not change and grow.

So, the false teachers are telling lies. They say they have never sinned. John's listeners should not be like these fake believers. John's listeners have to be careful not to sin. But John knows that people may still sin occasionally, even if they do not want to do so. The believers should not be afraid of God when they do sin. The believers should go to God and tell God what they have done. We do not have to be afraid to go to God, because Jesus will go with us. Jesus will stand next to us before God. Jesus will ask God to forgive us. And we know that God will do whatever Jesus asks him to do!

Stop here and act out someone going to God to tell God they have sinned. Act out that Jesus goes with this person, stands next to them, and asks God to forgive them. Act out that God does forgive the person. Pause this audio here.

Jesus Christ has not ever done anything wrong. Jesus is completely good in God's eyes. But still, God punished Jesus. God punished Jesus instead of God punishing us. This is why God can now forgive our sins, because the punishment for our sins has already happened. Jesus took the punishment for the sins of all the people in the world. John uses a difficult statement here and says that Jesus was the "atoning" sacrifice for our sins. To atone means to restore a relationship. In the Old Testament, God gave laws about how people could restore the relationship with God after they sinned, through the killing and sacrificing of an animal. The animal died in place of the person who had sinned. Jesus died in our place. Because Jesus died in our place, we can have a good relationship with God.

So, in this passage, John mentioned three untrue things that the false teachers say about themselves:

- The false teachers say they have a good relationship with God, even though they are not doing what God wants, and therefore, they walk in darkness
- The false teachers say they are not sinful.
- And the false teachers say that they have not sinned.

Stop here and act out these three different things that the fake believers say about themselves. Pause this audio here.

John calls his listeners "little children" or "dear children." When John calls his listeners children, John is showing them that he loves them. "Little child" was an affectionate way to speak to someone. Also, John is a very old man by now, so everybody else might seem like a young child to John! It could also be that John calls the believers his children because John is their spiritual father. John's listeners have learned about Jesus from John.

Stop here and discuss: In your language, how do elderly people address younger people outside their own family if they want to show that they love them? Pause this audio here.

When John talked about the wrong things that the false teachers said about themselves, John said, "If we say that we have fellowship with him," or "If we say that we are not sinful." John did not say, "If these people say." Everybody has to be careful not to say these wrong things. Even John himself should not be saying any of these wrong things.

John used the same phrase "if we say that…" three times. We will see in later passages that John will more often repeat the same thing three times.

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Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:5–2:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- Jesus
- God the Father
- People who disobey God, who "walk in darkness"
- And people who confess their sins, and God forgives them

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John says something like this:

"I want to tell you what we—the others and I who have seen Jesus—have learned from Jesus. I want you to know that God is light. There is not even a speck of darkness in God. God is completely good and He never lies." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- It is so important that people do not keep sinning! God is so good. I want these dear believers to do the things that God wants. Then the believers will be walking in the light of God.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"If we say, 'We have a good relationship with God,' but at the same time we are walking in darkness instead of in the light of God, we are lying! Everything we do and say is a lie. But if we walk in the light of God, just as Jesus is in the light, then we will have a good relationship with God, and also with each other! And God will forgive us our sins. God does this because Jesus has died to make us clean from sin." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am so glad that God will forgive our sin! I want to live in God's light and do the right thing. I want to have a good fellowship with the other believers, too.

Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- There are some people who say that they have fellowship with God, but it is not true. These people still keep sinning. You cannot have fellowship with God if you still keep sinning!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"If we say that we do not sin, we are also lying. We are fooling ourselves. Instead of this, we should confess our sins to God! If we will tell God about our sins, then God will forgive us. God will remove anything in us that is

1 John 1:5–2:2

bad and evil. God does that because God has promised this. God always does what he has promised, and God always does what is right.

"God tells us that we do sin. So if we say that we have not sinned, we are in fact saying that God is lying!" Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- John is right. We are doing sin, even though we do not want it. I am so glad that God wants to forgive us! or
- God speaks the truth always. I would be very foolish to think that I know better than God, and to think that I never sin!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"My dear children, I am writing this to tell you that you should not sin. But if you do sin, then Jesus Christ will ask God the Father to forgive us. Jesus Christ has never done any sin himself. Jesus is completely good. Jesus died in our place so that God could forgive our sins. And not just our sins, but the sins of all the people everywhere!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I know that it is difficult not to sin. I do not want these dear believers to be afraid of God. Whenever the believers sin, they can ask God to forgive them.

Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- We are so glad that God has punished Jesus in our place! We are so grateful to Jesus; or
- We are so glad that we do not have to be afraid of God anymore; or
- I do not want to keep sinning, because Jesus has died for me!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:5–2:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John **proclaims** to his listeners what he has seen or heard. If you proclaim something, you are telling something openly. Use the same word that you have used in the previous passage.

In the previous passage, John said that he wanted the believers to have **fellowship** with John, so that they could also have fellowship with God the Father and with God's Son, Jesus Christ. In this passage, John says that we do not have fellowship with God if we are walking in darkness, if we are doing the things that God says are wrong. People who have fellowship with each other have a very good relationship with each other. These people love each other. They trust each other. They talk with each other. They enjoy spending time together. Use the same word for fellowship as you have used in a previous passage. The word fellowship is in the Master Glossary.

Christ means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. Christ is the same as "Messiah." Messiah is the Hebrew word, and Christ is the Greek translation of this word. When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means that Jesus is the Son of God. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages.

John talks about people who walk in darkness and people who walk in the light. When John talks about people who walk in the light, John means people who believe the true message about God and who obey this. These people always want to do the things that God wants. People who walk in darkness do not know the truth. These people do not believe the right things about God. These people always want to do the wrong things, things that God does not want. Some translations talk about people who live in darkness and people who live in light, and do not use the word walking.

Stop here and discuss again how you could say in your language that people are **walking in the light** or are **walking in the darkness**. Pause this audio here.

John says that God will forgive us if we confess our sins. If you confess your sins, you tell God what wrong things you have done. You can also confess your sins to other people. Then you tell other people what wrong things you have done, and you hope that those people will forgive you.

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Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that God will forgive us if we **confess** our sins. Use the same word that you have used in other books that you have already translated. Pause this audio here.

When God forgives us, he stops being angry with us for something that we have done wrong. God will not think about it anymore. It is as if we have never even done the wrong thing.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that God will **forgive** our sins if we confess our sins. The word forgiveness is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages. Pause this audio here.

John says that the blood of Jesus, God's Son, purifies us from every sin. Someone sins when they rebel against God. Anytime that a person disobeys God's laws, they sin.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate **sin** in your language. The word sin is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages. Pause this audio here.

When a person sins, they become unclean or impure. The words "clean" and "unclean" in the Bible are not talking about whether someone is clean or dirty from the outside. In the Bible, a "clean" person means a person who is fit for service to God—someone who is acceptable to participate in worship to God. A person who is unclean is unfit for service to God. Someone can become unclean, or impure, when they sin against God. Someone else then needs to clean, or "purify," that person. In the Old Testament, a priest purified a person by sacrificing an animal. The animal died, and the person who had sinned could live. The blood of the animal made the person who sinned pure, or clean again. God forgave that person.

Because Jesus died, people no longer need to sacrifice animals. Jesus died so that God can forgive the people who have sinned. The blood of Jesus makes people pure, or clean, again. Of course, the blood of Jesus does not really touch our bodies. But "the blood of Jesus" means the death of Jesus. Because Jesus died, God forgives us. We are clean again.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the **blood** of Jesus **purifies** us from every sin. The words blood and purify are in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

God forgives us because he is faithful and righteous. God is faithful, because God always does what he has promised. You can trust God completely. God does not change. God will forgive us if we tell God about our sins, because God has promised to forgive us.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that God is **faithful**. Pause this audio here.

God is righteous. This means that God always does what is right in God's eyes. God is the one who decides what is right and what is wrong. And God has decided that it is right to forgive us. Therefore, God will do it. God will forgive us.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that God is **righteous**. The word righteousness is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages. Pause this audio here.

Because God is faithful and righteous, God will forgive us our sins and make us clean, or purify us, from all unrighteousness. Unrighteousness means everything that is wrong in the eyes of God. It is the opposite of righteousness. God always does what is right; God is righteous. We are sinning; we are doing what is wrong in God's eyes. We are unrighteous. The sins we are doing are making us unclean. But God will make us clean again. This is the same as saying that God purifies us.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that God will **make us clean**, or **purify us**, from all **unrighteousness**. Remember that the words for purify and righteousness are in the Master Glossary. Use the same words as you have used earlier. Pause this audio here.

John says that if we say that we have not sinned, God's **word**, or message, is not in us. In other words, we do not live as God tells us to live in his message to us. Use the same word or phrase for "word" as you did in the previous passage, and refer to word in the Master Glossary for more information.

John addresses his listeners as "little children" or "**dear children**." John is using this word to show the people that John loves them. "Little child" was an affectionate way to speak to someone, even if they were not your

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own children. It could also be that John calls the believers his children because John is their spiritual father. John's listeners have learned about Jesus from John.

Stop here and remind yourself what word or phrase you will use for how John addresses his listeners. Pause this audio here.

We have to do our very best not to sin, but if we do sin, then Jesus Christ defends us before God the Father. Jesus asks God to forgive us. In a court case, there is often someone we call an advocate. This is the person who tries to convince the judge that some other person has not committed a crime, or that the judge should not give any punishment to that person. Jesus is like such an advocate. Jesus asks God not to punish us for our sin.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Jesus Christ defends us before God the Father, or that Jesus Christ is our **advocate** with God the Father. The word advocate is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Jesus Christ is the **righteous** one. That means that everything that Jesus does is right in the eyes of God. This word "righteous" is the same word that John used earlier when he said that God forgives our sins because God is faithful and righteous. Use the same word for righteous as you have used there. Remember that the word righteous is in the Master Glossary.

Jesus is the atoning sacrifice for our sins. When people sin, they break the good relationship they have with God. In the Old Testament, God gave laws about how people could restore the relationship with God after they sinned through the killing and sacrificing of an animal. Jesus became the final sacrifice that restored the relationship between God and humans. Jesus atoned for the sins that we have done. Because Jesus died in our place, our relationship with God is restored.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Jesus is the **atoning sacrifice** for our sins. The words atonement and sacrifice are in the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases as you have used in other books.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 1:5–2:2 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 1:5–2:2

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (733 KB)
- Setting the Stage (7.2 MB)

- Defining the Scenes (8.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (6.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1017 KB)

1 John 2:3–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 2:3–11 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:3–11 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:3–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John talked about three wrong things that people can say about themselves:

- It is wrong to say that we have a good relationship with God if we are not doing what God wants.
- It is wrong to say we are not sinful and that God does not care about sin.
- It is wrong to say that we have not sinned even though some other people might have sinned.

John said that only people who believe the right things about God and who do the good things that God wants us to do can have a good relationship with God. And when we have a good relationship with God, we will also have a good relationship with the other believers! John also said that we should not do sin, but if we do, then Jesus will ask God to forgive us.

In this passage, John continues to talk about people who are saying things about themselves that are not true. Again, John will mention three things that these people say. Then, John will tell us three things we can do to see whether what these people are saying is true.

Stop here and discuss: When you buy some fruits or vegetables at the market, how do you know that the fruit is good? Do you always believe the fruit seller, or do you do something to find out if the fruit is good? Pause this audio here.

Just as there are things that you can do to know whether the fruit seller is speaking the truth, John tells us that there are things that we can do to know whether people are speaking true things about themselves.

We will again use the example of Sam and Sally to help us understand what kind of wrong teaching was going on. Remember that Sam and Sally do not exist, but we use Sam and Sally as an example of the kind of things some people in that time believed.

The first untrue thing that people like Sam and Sally said is that they know God. Remember that they wrongly thought that they had some special, secret knowledge about God. But John says, “You think that you know God? Then, you should do what God wants and obey him!”

This is similar to what John said in the previous passage. There, John said that people who say they have fellowship with God but who are not obeying God are lying. To know God and to have fellowship with God is almost the same thing. They both mean you have a good relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a time that you did something that a friend or a family member did not want you to do? What happened to your relationship because of that? Pause this audio here.

So, John was teaching the people that knowing God has nothing to do with secret knowledge! Knowing God just has to do with doing what God wants.

The second untrue thing that people like Sam and Sally said is that they remain in Jesus, or in God.

When John talks about being "in Jesus," or "in God," this means almost the same as knowing God. If you are in God, then you have a good relationship with God. You do what God wants. And if you are remaining in God, then you are continuously keeping your relationship with God, you are continuously doing the things that God wants. So saying that someone is in God, or is remaining in God, is again another way to say that someone has a good relationship with God.

In the introduction, we explained that to understand what it means to remain in God, you could think of a baby chicken that is safe as long as it stays in the nest, near the mother bird. You can also think of a beautiful and strong house. Imagine that you are staying in this house. The owner of the house loves you and promises to keep you safe in his house. Every day, you eat and talk with the owner. You are glad to be with the owner, and he is glad to be with you. Outside, there are storms and dangers. When you look out through your window, you see other people. Those people want you to come outside and do wrong things. But you trust the owner of the house, and you know that if you go outside, you will get hurt. When you stay in the house and are always spending time with the owner of the house, then you will begin to behave more and more just like the owner.

Like this, people who remain in God will begin to behave more and more like Jesus. And so, we can find out if people really have a good relationship with God if they really remain in God. Only people who are behaving more and more like Jesus are remaining in God.

We have already seen that people like Sam and Sally did not think it was important to behave like Jesus. These people were more interested in spiritual experiences, like having special dreams, getting into a trance, or feeling very excited, rather than in behaving in the right way. But John tells us that this is wrong. We very much should behave like Jesus!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who behaved like Jesus? Pause this audio here.

John then says that he is giving his listeners a command. John does not actually say what this command is, but from the rest of the passage, we understand that this is a command to love the other believers. John says this is not a new command. It is something that the believers already know from the time that they became believers. At the same time, it is a new command. This would remind John's listeners of something that Jesus had said a short time before his death. Jesus had said to his disciples: "I am giving you a new commandment. Love each other! You should love each other as much as I have loved you. When other people see that you love each other, then they will know that you really are my disciples." You can hear this in the Gospel of John, chapter 13:34.

So, this command to love each other is old, because the believers already know this. But at the same time, this commandment is new. When Jesus gave this command, it was a new command, and it is still new and fresh for us today. This command never gets old or outdated!

The command is also new because it brings new things. When people love each other, the darkness will go away. The "darkness" is John's way of speaking about everything that is evil and bad, and every wrong thing that people believe. When people will love each other, good things will happen! It will be as if God's light will shine. People will be able to see how good God is.

Stop here and, if you like, do this activity: Make your room as dark as possible, or go to a place where you can make it dark. You should still be able to see a little bit, so that you can see each other's actions. Everybody needs to have a torch or a candle, but these should be off. Then, act out that people are doing good things for each other or are saying things to each other that show that they care about each other. Every time someone does

or says something loving, the other person will light their candle or torch. Do this until everybody's light is on! Then, you can praise God that God's light is shining! Pause this audio here.

The third untrue thing that people like Sam and Sally say is that they are in the light. John had already said that God is light. This meant that God is completely good and true. If someone says they are in the light, that person says that they are believing and doing the things that God wants.

To see whether these people are indeed in the light, John tells us to look at whether they love the other believers. John does not mean that believers should love each other romantically or have nice feelings about each other. John means that believers should care about each other, help each other, be kind to each other, and respect each other.

Stop here and discuss: Tell a story about a time that you noticed one believer really showing love to someone else. What did this believer do? Can you give some other examples of believers loving each other? Pause this audio here.

If a person does not love the other believers, then this person is not in the light at all! The person is still living in spiritual darkness. This person does not know God at all. If you are walking in the dark, you can very easily trip and fall. So, people who are in spiritual darkness will very easily sin. But people who live in the light of God will not sin easily.

And so, in this passage, John is teaching the believers how very important it is that they have a good relationship with each other and love each other. It is impossible to have a good relationship with God if we do not love the other believers!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:3–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: John tells us about two things that will show us whether someone really knows God or not. A person who really knows God will obey God and will behave like Jesus. John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that children of God obey God's commandments.

In the second part: John talks about God's commandment that we should love each other. John will also tell us a third thing that will show us whether someone really knows God. A person who really knows God will love the other believers. John moves here to the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God should love each other.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus, though John does not use Jesus' name
- People who do not obey God's commandments, even though they say that they know God
- People who obey God and love the other believers
- And people who hate the other believers, even though they say that they are in the light

When we begin this passage, John is in the part of the garden where John tells us that children of God obey God's commandments.

Stop here and do this activity: Please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Also, take a small rock or object and place this in this part of the garden. This way, you will be able to see later that you have already been in this part of the garden earlier. Pause this audio here.

The people in John's time who said that they had some secret knowledge about God looked down on other believers. But John tells the believers they can be sure that they know God if they obey God's commandments. The believers do not need to have any secret knowledge! To know God is different from knowing about God. You can know about a person even when you have never met this person. But if you just know about a person, you do not have a relationship with this person.

But when you know a good friend, you do not just know about your friend. You have a relationship with your friend. You talk with your friend often. You know what your friend likes and does not like. And you do the things that your friend likes.

Stop here and discuss: Share with each other an example of some people that you know about, and some other people that you know personally, or have a relationship with*.* Pause this audio here.

When John talks about knowing God, John talks about knowing God in the way that you know a good friend.

John tells the believers they can be sure that they know God if they obey God's commandments. God's commandments mean all the good rules that God has given. A person who says that they know God but does not obey God's commandments is lying. John says there is no truth in this person. In the previous passage, John had said almost the same thing, that the truth of God was not in these people. John means the same thing here. Everything that God does and says is true. But this is not so for these people. These people are lying. We cannot trust these people.

And so, John told about a way to find out whether someone really knows God. If people obey God's commandments, then they know God*!*

A person who does obey God's word, meaning they obey God's commandments, this person really knows God. John says that in this person, the love of God has become perfect. John could mean that when we obey God's commandments and love each other, we are doing what God wants. God loves us and wants us to love each other. Let's say that you are planting a fruit tree. You love this tree very much. You give the tree water and fertilizer, and if needed, you cut off some branches that grow the wrong way. When the tree begins to bear fruit, all the work that you have done for the tree is worth the trouble. John would say that the work you have done for the tree has become perfect, because the tree now bears fruit. The tree produces fruit, and so the tree does what you wanted it to do. In the same way, when we obey God's commandments, the love that God has for us has become perfect. We are doing what God, by loving us, wanted us to do. It is also possible that John means that when a person obeys God's commandments, this shows that this person loves God perfectly.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that if someone obeys God, God's love has become perfect in that person. Pause this audio here.

The second way to know whether a person really knows God is to see if the person behaves like Jesus. This time, John does not say this is a test to see if someone knows God, but a test to see if someone remains in God. If you are remaining in God, then you are continuously keeping your relationship with God; you are continuously doing the things that God wants. So to say that someone is remaining in God is another way to say that someone has a good relationship with God.

John likes to use different words to say the same thing. To be in God and to remain in God mean almost the same thing. And these meanings are also very similar to having fellowship with God, and to knowing God.

Stop here and discuss how you would say in your language that someone is in God, or in Jesus. Also, discuss how you would say that someone remains in God or Jesus. Pause this audio here.

So, people who say they are "in God," who say they have a relationship with God, should show this by their behavior. John says, people should "walk" like "he" walked. John means here that people should walk, or act like Jesus. The Bible often uses the word "walking" as special language for the way we live and behave. Remember that in the previous passage, John also talked about walking in the light or walking in the darkness.

Stop here and play this game: Make a line of people. The person at the front is the leader. The leader makes gestures or walks around the room in a certain way. Everybody follows the leader and does whatever the leader does. And the followers call out, "We follow the leader!" Stop here and do this activity.

Now, do the same thing again, but this time, the people will not do whatever the leader does. But the people will say, “We follow the leader!” Pause this audio here.

In this activity, you saw that it did not mean anything at all whether people said they followed the leader or not! The only thing that mattered was whether the people actually did what the leader said! In the same way, what a person says about their relationship with God does not mean much at all. It is what the person does and how they behave that tells us whether people have a relationship with God or not.

In the second part of the passage, John is in the part of the garden where he says that the children of God love each other.

Stop here and let the person who represents John move to this part of the garden. Also, leave an object behind in this part of the garden, for later. Pause this audio here.

John begins this part by calling his listeners “beloved.” This means that John loves the people to whom John is writing. It can also mean that God loves the people. Both would be true! In your translation, you want to use a word that a respected, senior leader could use when addressing other people very kindly.

Stop here and discuss how you would like John to address his listeners here. Pause this audio here.

John then gives the people a commandment that is both new and old at the same time. It is old because the believers already know it. But it is also new because it will never get outdated.

John says that this new commandment is true in “him,” which means in Jesus. John means that Jesus did what this commandment says. Jesus made the commandment true. Jesus did love the people!

John also says that this commandment is true in “you,” meaning John’s listeners. The believers who are listening to John are also doing what this commandment says. These believers love each other.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that John gives the people a new commandment that is true in Jesus and in the believers. Pause this audio here.

John says that the darkness is passing away, and the true light is already shining. It is as if we are at the beginning of a new day. When the sun comes up, slowly the darkness of the night will go away. Like this, there is still evil and sin in the world, but we can already see that God’s goodness and love will take it all away! A new day is beginning! This is happening because the believers are loving each other. It could also mean that because God’s light is shining, the believers are loving each other.

John calls this light “true” because it is real, not fake. Just like in the introduction, we said that a bridge that was just made from paper was not a true bridge. You could not safely cross the bridge! But something that is true is real, and you can trust it. Like that, God’s light is true. It is real, and we can trust it.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that the darkness is passing away, and that the true light is shining. Pause this audio here.

After this, John tells us of another way we can see if a person really knows God. The person who really knows God is the person who keeps the commandment to love other believers.

If we love our fellow believers, we remain in the light. A person who remains in the light is someone who believes the true message from God and who obeys it. This person continuously does what God wants. This person has a good relationship with God.

A person who remains in the light can see where they are going. This person will not easily trip over something and fall. John is using the word “falling” as a special language for sinning. John probably means that a person who loves their fellow believers will not easily sin. Or, John could mean that a person who loves their fellow believers will not make other people sin.

But people who hate another believer are in the darkness. These people are not doing what God wants. If you hate someone, you are not doing good things for someone. Just like loving someone does not necessarily mean that you have good feelings for someone, like that, hating someone does not necessarily mean that you have bad feelings about someone. If you love someone, you do good things for that person, even if it is inconvenient to you. If you hate a person, you are not doing good things for a person, even though you could!

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that someone who hates a fellow believer is still in the darkness. Pause this audio here.

John says people who hate other believers—who do not do good things for those people—are walking in the darkness. People who walk in darkness do not know the truth. Those people do not believe the right things about God. Those people continuously do the wrong things, things that God does not want.

If you are walking in the darkness, you cannot see where you are going. It is the same as if you were blind. And because you cannot see where you are going, you are going to run into all kinds of problems!

Like that, people who hate another believer are doing sin. They are like people who are stumbling in the dark and falling.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that whoever hates a fellow believer walks in the darkness like a blind man, and they do not know where to go. Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John mentioned three untrue things that the false teachers—people like Sam and Sally—said about themselves. This time, John mentions three other untrue things:

- The false believers say they know God.
- The false believers say they remain in God.
- The false believers say that they remain in the light.

Stop here and act out these three different things that the fake believers say about themselves. Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John repeated three times the phrase, “If we say that….” In this passage, John uses different words and repeats three times, “Whoever says…,” to talk about the three untrue things false believers say about themselves. As we mentioned in the introduction, John likes groups of three! And John also likes to say the same thing in different words.

John uses the phrase, “We can be sure,” twice in this passage. We can be sure that if we obey God’s commands, we know God. And, we can be sure that we are in God if we live like Jesus did.

Near the end of this passage, John uses a few positive-negative pairs, or sentences that mean almost the same thing, but one is positive, and one is negative or the other way around. When you are going to listen to the translation again, see if you can recognize these!

John probably uses repetition and pairs so that people can remember John’s message better.

Stop here and listen to a translation of this passage once more. Listen for the repetition and pairs. But be aware that the translation that you are listening to might not clearly show the repetition or the pairs. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:3–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John’s sermon
- God
- Jesus, though John does not use Jesus’ name
- People who do not obey God’s commandments, even though they say that they know God
- People who obey God and love the other believers
- And people who hate the other believers, even though they say that they are in the light

1 John 2:3–11

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John says something like this:

"We can be sure that we know God if we obey God's good rules. So how do you know whether someone really knows God? You can look at this person's behavior! If someone obeys God's good rules, then this person really knows God! God's love has become perfect in this person. But anyone who says they know God but does not obey what God says is lying. It is not true that they have a relationship with God! We can be sure that we are in God if we behave just like Jesus. So, anyone who says that he remains with God should also behave just like Jesus." Pause the drama. Ask the person acting out John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:** Continue the drama.

- **Some people say they know God, but it is not true! I want the believers to know how they can recognize whether someone really knows God.**

Ask the people acting out John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- **We are glad that we can learn how to recognize whether people really know God or not; or**
- **I am glad that I am learning that I have to obey God! I did not know that it was important to do what God wants.**

John says something like this:

"Dear friends, you should love each other. This is not something that you do not know yet. It is an old commandment. But it is also a new commandment! Jesus did what this commandment tells us to do. You are also doing what this commandment tells us to do. Because of this, we can see that the darkness of evil is already beginning to go away! We can already see the true light of God beginning to shine." Pause the drama. Ask the person acting out John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I am sad that some believers have left the church, and that they did not love the other believers. The most important thing for the believers is to love each other! That is what Jesus told us to do! or
- I am glad that many believers still do love each other. God's light is shining!

Ask the people acting out John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am glad that John says that we are already obeying this commandment; or
- Jesus loved us so much, and now I know that I really should love my brothers and sisters in the church as well.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"But if you do not love each other, then you are still walking in darkness. Anyone who says that they are walking in the light of God, but at the same time they hate another believer, is like people just stumbling around blindly in the darkness. They do not know where they are going! But if you love each other, then you are walking in the light of God. Then, you will not stumble in the darkness, and you will not sin easily."

Ask the people acting out John's listeners: "What are you thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- **I want to walk in the light of God! I want to do my best to love my fellow believers. I do not want to sin; or**

pFilling the Gaps (1 John 2:3–11)

- **There are some people in my church that I do not love. I have learned now that this is not what God wants. I do not want to walk in the darkness and sin! I want to have a relationship with God and walk in the light, and love the other believers.**

Filling the Gaps

pFilling the Gaps (1 John 2:3–11)

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:3–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John says that we can be sure that we know God if we obey his commandments. If you know God, you have a relationship with God. You do not just know about God, but have a close relationship with him.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **knowing** God. Pause this audio here.

We show that we know God if we obey his commandments. God's commandments mean all the good rules and instructions that God has given.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for God's **commandments**. Use the same word that you have used in other passages. The word commandment is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Someone who is in God or Jesus is having a good relationship with God. Someone who "remains in Jesus" continuously keeps the relationship and does what God says. John uses the word "remain" quite often in his sermon.

Stop here and remind yourself how to say that someone is **in God**, and how to say that someone **remains** in God. Pause this audio here.

If someone obeys what God says, or obeys God's word, then God's love has become perfect in this person. Or, it could mean that this person loves God perfectly.

Stop here and remind yourselves how you will say in your language that if someone obeys God, **God's love has become perfect** in them. If you use "God's **word**," or God's message, here, use the same words or phrase for God's Word as you used in the previous passage. "Word" is in the Master Glossary. See the Master Glossary for more information about perfect. Pause this audio here.

A person who says they remain in Jesus should walk like Jesus walked. To walk like Jesus means to do the things that Jesus does and to behave as Jesus would.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that people should **walk like Jesus walked**. Pause this audio here.

John calls his listeners beloved. This means that John loves the people to whom he is writing. It can also mean that God loves the people, or both. John means that his listeners are John's dear friends. John speaks very kindly to his listeners.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that John calls the people **beloved**. Pause this audio here.

John is not writing or giving a new commandment. John is giving the believers a commandment they already know. The believers already know this commandment from the beginning. This means that the believers know this commandment from the time that they became followers of Jesus.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the believers know, or have, this commandment **from the beginning**. Pause this audio here.

Someone who hates his brother is walking in the darkness. A brother means another person who is a believer, both male and female. Believers belong to the family of God. God is the father of all the believers. Therefore, believers call each other brother and sister.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **brother** in this passage. Make sure that women as well as men will understand that this word is about them. Pause this audio here.

The person who loves his brother or sister remains in the light. When you love someone, you want what is best for that person. You care deeply about that person. You will do anything you can not to hurt this person. You want to keep a good relationship with this person. This is different from liking a person. You can even love a person even if you do not like that person very much. If you remain in the light, you keep your good relationship with God.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that a person who **loves** his brother or sister remains in the light. Pause this audio here.

If you hate someone, you do not care for that person. You do not want to do what is best for that person. You do not care if someone hurts that person. You do not want to stay in a relationship with that person.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **hating** another believer.

Pause this audio here.

A person who hates a fellow believer **walks in darkness**. To say that someone walks in darkness is another way to say that a person does not know God. This person does not have a good relationship with God. Some translations say that this person lives in darkness. Use the same words or phrases as you have used in the previous passage for “walks in darkness.”

Someone who loves a fellow believer is in the light and will not stumble. Some translations say this person will not cause others to stumble. To say that someone stumbles is another way to say that someone sins.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that someone will not **stumble**.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:3–11 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 2:3–11

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (682 KB)
- Setting the Stage (6.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (10.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.5 MB)

- Filling the Gaps (3.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1000 KB)

1 John 2:12–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 2:12–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:12–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:12–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John told us how we can see whether a person truly knows God, has a relationship with God. If someone really knows God, then they love the other believers, just as Jesus did. John was talking about people who pretended to know God, but were lying about this.

Now, John changes his tone. John now speaks very lovingly to the believers. It is as if John says to the believers, “Even though I had to say all these negative things about some people, I know that you are not like those people! You really do know God!”

In this passage, John talks to the believers in different groups. John addresses little children, fathers, and young people. These are different ways to talk about the believers. We will talk more about this in the next step. For now, it is important to know that everything that John says to one group of believers is true for all the believers.

We will again use the example of Sam and Sally to help us understand why John says these things. Remember that Sam and Sally do not exist, but we use them as examples of the kind of things some people in that time believed. People like Sam and Sally wrongly said that they had special, secret knowledge about God. Because they thought they had this secret knowledge about God, people like Sam and Sally looked down on other believers.

But John tells the believers, “You already know God!” John’s listeners must have been quite encouraged when they heard this. John’s listeners did not need to have any special, secret knowledge about God—they already knew God!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about people in your community who think they have some secret knowledge? Or about people who do not like to share something they know with other people? Or maybe people who look down on other people because they think that they know more? Pause this audio here.

John also encourages the believers that God has forgiven their sins. And John says that the believers have defeated “the evil one,” which is John’s way of speaking about Satan, or the devil.

And so, the believers are quite different from people like Sam and Sally, who only pretended to know God. The believers really do have a relationship with God and are doing the things that God wants.

Another way in which the believers are different from people like Sam and Sally is that God has forgiven the believers’ sins. Sam and Sally said that they had not done sin. But the believers have confessed their sins, and God has forgiven the believers.

1 John 2:12–17

The believers are spiritually strong. Satan, who is evil, wants the believers to sin and disobey God. But every time that the believers are doing what God wants, instead of doing the evil things that Satan wants them to do, the believers are defeating Satan. The believers are strong enough to defeat Satan because the word of God lives in them. This is another way in which these believers are different from the fake believers! John had said about people like Sam and Sally that the word of God did not live in them. Do you remember the activity that we did with a leaking vessel? The water ran out of that vessel right away. John said that Sam and Sally were like that. The word of God had no effect on these people. The word of God did not change these people. But John's listeners are different! The word of God does have an effect on John's listeners. It does change them. The word of God stays in John's listeners.

In the previous passage, John had said that the believers should love each other. Now, John tells the believers something that they should NOT love. The believers should not love the world! Of course, John does not mean that the believers should not love the people of the world, or nature, or anything good in the world.

But John means that people should not love the bad things that people who do not know God love. John calls these bad things "the world" and the "things that belong to the world." People cannot love God and love the things that are against God's will at the same time. Just as much as you cannot be in the light and in the darkness at the same time, you cannot love God and the things that God hates at the same time!

Stop here and do this activity: Ask someone to touch a wall, tree, or any other object you have nearby. Ask some other people to stand near another wall or tree that is some distance away. These people will call out to the first person and try to make him come to their side. Will the person be able to go to them while still touching his own wall or tree? Try it out! Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, the person who was touching the wall or the tree could not touch this and, at the same time, go over to the other side. In the same way, we cannot love God and the evil things of this world at the same time. If we will begin loving the evil things of this world, we will stop loving God.

The sinful world, and everything that the people who belong to this sinful world want, will disappear. People like to have money and possessions, or fame and honor, but these are only temporary. These things belong to the sinful world and will not last.

God is going to make everything new again. Then everything that is evil, and all these things that people now think are so very important, will no longer be there! But the people who do what God wants will continue to live with God. Then, nobody will ever want to do anything sinful ever again!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who loved the things that belong to this world and stopped loving God? What happened?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:12–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: John reminds his listeners that God has forgiven them, that they do know God, and that they have conquered Satan. John is in the part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God have overcome the sinful world.

In the second part: John tells his listeners that they should not love the bad things that belong to the world, meaning the things that are against God's will. John is in the part of the garden where he says that the children of God do not keep sinning.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon

- Little children, meaning all John's listeners
- Fathers and mothers, or it could mean mature believers
- Young people, or it could mean new believers
- God
- People who love the bad things that belong to the world
- And people who do what God wants

In the first part of this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God have overcome the sinful world.

Stop here and do this activity: Please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Leave behind an object for later. Pause this audio here.

In this first part of this passage, John says three things to the people, and three times John uses the phrase, "I am writing to you." Then, John again says three things to the same people, and he uses three times the phrase, "I have written to you." Scholars think that John does not mean anything different this second time around. John often likes to repeat something with slightly different words. Some translations, therefore, just say, "I am writing to you," or "I write to you" each of these six times.

The things that John says in the second round of three things are not very different from what he said in the first round of three things. Again, we see that John likes to say the same thing twice, with slightly different words.

You will remember that in the previous passage, John talked about three untrue things that false teachers—people like Sam and Sally—said about themselves. And in the passage before that, John also said three untrue things that the false teachers said about themselves. So, John talked two times about three untrue things that the false teachers said about themselves. And now, John will talk two times about three things that are true for the believers!

John says he is writing to "little" or "dear" children, to fathers, and to young people. Earlier in this sermon, John called the people to whom he was writing little children as well. John called the people "little children" in order to show that John loved them. We know that John was not really writing to little children. And so, when John says here that he is writing to "you, little children," John probably means that he is writing to all the believers. All the believers together are like John's dear children. John loves the believers as much as parents love their children. Or, John calls them children because all the believers are the children of God.

After talking to all the believers together, John then talks to two different groups of believers. One group of believers he calls "fathers." We do not know whether John is addressing real fathers and mothers in the church or whether John is thinking about people who have been believers for a long time—people who are "grown up" in their faith.

The other believers John calls "young people." John might be thinking about people who are young in age, or John might be thinking about new believers, people who have not yet been believers for a long time.

Even though John uses words that refer to male groups, John's listeners would know that John was writing to the women as much as to the men.

Stop here and discuss how you will say "fathers" and "young people" in your translation. Make sure that people who listen to the translation will know that John is writing to both men and women. Pause this audio here.

John says he is writing to the dear children, meaning all the believers together, because God has forgiven their sins. Some translations say that John is writing to them that God has forgiven the sins of the believers. The believers already knew that God had forgiven their sins. John does not write to tell them a new thing, but John reminds them about something they already knew. God has forgiven the believers' sins because of Jesus' name. Jesus' name is another way to talk about Jesus himself. God has forgiven the people's sins because Jesus made this possible.

After talking to all the believers together as "little children," John then talks to the "fathers." John says that the fathers know him who existed from the beginning. John is talking about Jesus. When John began his sermon,

1 John 2:12–17

John called Jesus “the one who existed from the beginning.” The “fathers,” whether these are the older people in the church or whether these are the mature believers, know Jesus! We know by now how important “knowing God” is in this sermon of John. The fathers really know God, unlike the fake believers who only said they know God. The fathers have a relationship with God, and they are doing the things that God wants.

Stop here and act out that the “fathers” and “mothers,” or the mature believers, have a relationship with God and are doing the things that God wants. Pause this audio here.

Then John talks to the young people. Even though these people are young or do not yet have much experience as believers, they have already won their fight with Satan! These people believe the right things, instead of the wrong things that Satan wants them to believe. These people are doing their best not to sin. They are doing the things that God wants.

Stop here and act out that the young people are doing their best not to sin. These believers are not believing the false teaching. They are defeating Satan. Pause this audio here.

After talking to these groups one time, John then addresses them again.

This time, John uses a different word to talk about all the believers together. John does not use the same word “little children,” but another word that means “children.” But the meaning of these words is very similar. This is another example where we see that John likes to use different words that mean almost the same.

John says that he is writing to the children to remind them that they know God the Father. Notice the important phrase “knowing God” again!

Then John says again that he is writing to the fathers, because they know “him who is from the beginning,” Jesus. This is the same as what John said the first time. “Fathers” can mean mature believers in the church, or it can mean the real fathers and mothers in the church.

Then John says that he is writing to the young people, because they are strong. The word of God remains in these people. This means that the young people are obeying what God is telling them to do. Then John says again that the young people have won their fight with Satan. Again, the young people can mean people who are young in age, or it could mean the people who have not been believers for a long time.

Even though John is addressing different groups of people, everything that John says to one group is true for the other group as well. God has forgiven the sins of all these people, and all of them have won their fight with Satan.

Stop here and do this activity. Make three groups of people: dear children, meaning all the believers together, fathers and mothers, and young people. If needed, listen to this part of the passage again. Then decide on an action or gesture for each thing that John writes to the different groups the first time, and then what John writes to them the second time. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss: Now that you have come up with some actions or gestures, go through this part of the passage a few times while adding words. This part of the passage has a lot of repetition. Can you find a rhythm? Could you sing this? Or dance it? Pause this audio here.

In the second part of this passage, John tells his listeners that they should not love the bad things that belong to the world, meaning the things that are against God’s will.

Stop here and do this activity: John now moves to the part of the garden where he says that the children of God should not sin. Ask the person who represents John to move to this part of your garden. Also leave behind an object for later. Pause this audio here.

Sometimes when the Bible talks about the world, it refers to the people of the world, or to everything that God has created. But sometimes, like here, the “world” means a negative thing. It refers to everything in this world that is not according to God’s will, that still belongs to Satan. Everyone who rebels against God and who sins belongs to this world, and does not belong to God.

John gives some examples of the behavior and feelings of people who belong to the world.

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People who belong to the world just do whatever they want to do, without thinking about whether it is good or bad. Everything that comes into these people's thoughts, they just do it. Everything these people see, they want to have. These people are boasting about the things they have. So, these people are greedy, selfish, and arrogant. These people do not know which things are truly important. These kinds of behaviors and feelings are not how God wants us to behave and feel.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out what it looks like if people love the world and the things of this world. Pause this audio here.

John talks about the desires of the flesh. The flesh in the Bible has more than one meaning. Our body is made up of flesh, and so the flesh is sometimes just another word for a body. But the word flesh also has a different meaning. The flesh is also a way to talk about the part inside us that wants to do things that are against God's will. It is a little bit as if we have two persons inside us: one part of us wants to obey God, and one part is always rebelling against God. The Bible calls the part that wants to obey God, "the spirit." The part that wants to rebel against God, the Bible calls "the flesh." A person who listens to what his flesh wants to do will do all kinds of sin. This person belongs to the world and does not belong to God.

John tells the believers not to love the world. This means that the believers should not have these wrong behaviors and feelings that people who belong to the world have. If we love these wrong things, then we will stop loving God.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out this part of the passage. Act out people who love God and who do the things that God wants. Then, act out that some people begin to love the things in the world and stop loving God. Act out that the world and all these bad things in it will disappear, but that the people who do what God wants will live with God. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:12–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- Little children, meaning all John's listeners
- Fathers and mothers, or mature believers
- Young people, or new believers
- God
- People who love the bad things that belong to the world
- And people who do what God wants

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out that John is reading to, or speaking to, his listeners. John might be saying something like this:

"My dear children, I am writing to you because God has forgiven you your sins. God has done that because of Jesus. Adults, I am writing to you because you know Jesus, who existed from the beginning. Young people, I am writing to you because you have won your fight with the evil one! Children, I am writing to you because you know God the Father. Adults, I am writing to you because you know Jesus, who existed from the beginning. Young people, I am writing to you because you are spiritually strong, you are doing what God's word says, and you have won your fight with the evil one!" Pause the drama. Ask the person acting out John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I want to remind the believers that God has forgiven their sins. The believers know God— they really have a relationship with God! or
- I am proud of the believers because they have won their fight with Satan; or
- I want to say these things two times because I want the believers not to forget this!

Ask the people acting out the believers, "What are you thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- I feel so happy! John has encouraged me so much; or
- I am so glad that God has forgiven my sins; or
- I am so glad that John tells us that we know God already. Sam and Sally were wrong to say that we need some special, secret knowledge! or
- I am so surprised that John calls us strong! It makes me want even more not to do or say or think anything that God does not like.

Continue the drama. John continues speaking something like this:

"Do not love the way people live in this sinful world. You cannot love God and sinful things at the same time. If you love the things of this sinful world, you will stop loving God! People who love this sinful world do whatever bad thing they want to do. If these people see something, they want to have it right away. These people are arrogant about the things they have. This is not the behavior that God wants." Pause the drama. Ask the person acting out John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I do not want the believers to be selfish and greedy, and to only think about things that are not important at all. If we love God, we should not love these wrong things.

Continue the drama. John continues speaking something like this:

"The evil things in this world and all these evil things that people really want to have are going away. But the people who do the things that God wants will live forever." Pause the drama. Ask the person acting out John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- The people who belong to the world are wanting things that are not important and that are sinful. It is much more important to live with God forever.

Ask the people acting out the believers, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I do not have to be jealous of people who seem to have everything. The things that they have will not last! or
- I am so glad that we can live forever with God! That is much more important than being rich!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:12–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John addresses his listeners as "little children" or "**dear children**." John is using this word to show the people that John loves them. "Little child" was an affectionate way to speak to someone. Also, John is a very old man

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by now, so everybody else might seem like a young child to John! Use the same word or phrase as you have used in the earlier passage in this book.

John also writes to "fathers" and to "young people." John could be thinking about the older people in the church, and about the young people in the church. But John could also be thinking about people who have been believers for a long time, and people who have been believers for only a short time.

Stop here and remind yourselves how you will say "**fathers**" and "**young people**" in your translation. Make sure that women know that John is also speaking to them. Pause this audio here.

John writes to the believers to remind them that God has forgiven their sins. **Sin** is an act of rebellion against God. Anytime that a person disobeys God's laws, they sin. Use the same word that you have used in other passages. The word sin is in the Master Glossary.

When God **forgives** our sins, God stops being angry with us for the wrong things that we have done. God will not think about it anymore. It is as if we have never even done the wrong thing. The word forgiveness is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages.

God has forgiven our sins because of Jesus' name. This means that God has forgiven our sins because of what Jesus has done. Jesus took the punishment for our sins, and therefore, Jesus made it possible for God to forgive us.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that God has forgiven our sins because of **Jesus' name**. Pause this audio here.

John reminds the "fathers" that they **know** the one who is from the beginning. This means that the fathers know Jesus. Remember that "knowing God" is very important in this letter. If you know God, you do not just know about God, but you have a close relationship with God. Use the same word for knowing Jesus, or God, as you have used in the previous passages.

John says that the young people have won the fight from the evil one. The evil one is John's way to talk about the devil, or Satan. Satan tempts people to disobey God. Satan tries to make people turn away from God by deceiving them. When the believers do not sin, they defeat Satan. The word "evil" is in the Master Glossary. Although John does not use the word "devil" here, you may refer to devil in the Master Glossary for more information about the "evil one."

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the young people have defeated the **evil one**. Pause this audio here.

After John has said something to the three different groups, John again will say something to each of these groups of people. Now, John calls the believers just "children," not "dear children." But this does not change the meaning. John is still talking to the believers very lovingly.

Stop here and discuss what word you will use for "**children**" when John addresses them the second time. Pause this audio here.

John says that the children know the **Father**. Use the same word for knowing as you have used earlier. The "Father" here means God the Father.

John writes to the young people because they are strong, or to remind them that they are strong. John is not talking about physical strength, but about spiritual strength. The young people are able to defeat Satan. The young people can do this because the word of God remains in them. In an earlier passage, John talked about people who did not have the word of God in them. The word of God had no effect on these people. It did not change them. But these believers are different! The word of God does have an effect on them. It does change them. The word of God remains in them. Remember that "Word" is in the Master Glossary, and you can translate "word" in the same way you have in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that John writes to the young people, because they are **strong**, and the word of God remains in them. Pause this audio here.

John tells the believers not to love this world or anything in the world. Here, the "world" refers to the rebellious world, the sinful world, the world where Satan still has power. This sinful world is full of evil things that are against God's will. People who belong to this world are selfish, greedy, and often do sexual sins. The people who

belong to this sinful world hate Jesus and his followers. Everyone who rebels against God and who sins belongs to the world, and does not belong to God.

When John says the believers should not love anything in the world, John means that people should not have the same behaviors and feelings as the people who belong to the world have.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that John tells us not to love the **world** or anything in the world.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 2:12–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (686 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1020 KB)

1 John 2:18–28

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 2:18–28 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:18–28 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:18–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

John ended the previous passage by saying that people should not love the sinful world and the bad things that belong to the sinful world. These things will go away. John's listeners knew that Jesus would come back one day and judge the whole world. The believers called the day on which these things would happen the "last day." John tells the believers that it is now the "last hour," which means that the time that Jesus is going to come back will happen very soon now!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about something that the people in your community believe is going to happen in the future? Pause this audio here.

It seems that the believers had heard about a certain enemy of Jesus who would come just before Jesus would come back. People called this enemy the "antichrist." But John says that right now there are many antichrists! There is not just one enemy of Jesus, but there are many. And because the antichrist would come in the "last hour," and because there are now many antichrists, John says that the last hour is now.

These enemies of Jesus are people who belonged to the church but have left. These are the people like Sam and Sally. John says that people like Sam and Sally never really belonged to the church. If these people had really belonged to the church, they would have stayed. These people would have kept believing the right things about Jesus. Sam and Sally were not real believers, but fake.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about something or someone that pretends to be something else? Maybe there are animals or flowers in your surroundings that can trick others to think they are a different animal or flower? Or did you ever meet someone who pretended to be someone else? Pause this audio here.

The fake believers are telling lies, but the believers know the truth. The fake believers think that they have special, secret knowledge about God, but that is not true. The believers do know God. The believers know the true things about God and Jesus. The believers know that they have "an anointing." If you anoint someone, this means you are pouring a bit of oil over someone. In the Old Testament, people poured oil over someone to appoint that person for a special task. The oil was a symbol for the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would help the people to do their task well. Therefore, John probably means that Jesus has given the Holy Spirit to the believers to help them know the right things about Jesus.

It is quite possible that people like Sam and Sally had said that they had gone through some sort of ritual that gave them their special, secret knowledge. These people might even have called this ritual "an anointing." But John shows the believers that they do not need such a ritual. Jesus has given the believers the Holy Spirit. The believers have already received an anointing! The Holy Spirit is teaching the believers the truth.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about some ritual that people in your community do to appoint someone for a special task, or to give someone some special knowledge? Pause this audio here.

The believers know the right things about Jesus. The believers know that Jesus, the human being, is also the Christ, the Son of God. The believers know that it is important to believe that the Son of God became a human being. Sam and Sally did not think that it was very important that the Son of God became a human being. We have already said in the introduction that Sam even thought that maybe the Son of God had only pretended to be a human being. The Son of God just looked like a human being, Jesus, but was not really human. Because, Sam thought, if the Son of God had become a human being, then the Son of God would have had to deal with ordinary things like eating and sleeping, and that would not be very spiritual. And especially dying, with all the bloody mess that was part of this, is not very spiritual. Sam and Sally did not think that God saved people by sending his Son to die for people.

But John uses very strong language to say that people like Sam and Sally are wrong. People who do not believe the whole truth about Jesus, that Jesus is the son of God AND a human being, are lying. This is the worst possible lie. People like Sam and Sally are, in fact, enemies of Jesus—antichrists! John says that if people do not believe the right things about Jesus, they cannot have a relationship with God the Father, either.

Stop here and do this activity: Ask two people to stand in the middle and hook their arms together. Then the other people will try to move one of these people to another place, maybe the corner of the room or under a tree that is nearby. At the same time, they will try to stop the second person from getting to that same place. Remind the two people to keep their arms hooked! See what happens! Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, you discovered that it was impossible to move only one of the two people. You were able to move both people, or none! You could not have one without the other. In the same way, people cannot have a relationship with God the Father if they do not believe that Jesus, the human being, is also God's Son. But when people have a relationship with Jesus, they will also have a relationship with God the Father.

John tells the believers that they should keep believing the same things that they learned in the beginning, when they had just become believers. The believers should not start to believe different, wrong things about Jesus. If the believers keep believing the right things about Jesus, then they will keep their good relationship with Jesus and with God the Father. And then God will give them eternal life. Eternal life means living in a perfect relationship with God, the best possible life.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about some people who tell untrue things about Jesus? Pause this audio here.

John says that he is writing to the believers to warn them against the fake believers, like Sam and Sally. The fake believers want to deceive the believers. Remember that the fake believers thought that they had special, secret knowledge about God. Maybe these people said that they could teach this secret knowledge to the believers.

John encourages the believers to remain in Jesus, meaning to keep their relationship with Jesus, to keep believing the right things about Jesus, and to keep doing the things that Jesus wants them to do. Then the believers can trust that Jesus will accept them when he, Jesus, comes back.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:18–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage has three parts.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

In the first part: John talks about the enemies of Christ and says that because the fake believers have left the church, this shows that they were never true believers.

In the second part: John encourages the believers that they are very different from the fake believers, because they have the Holy Spirit. We find out that the fake believers did not believe that Jesus is the Son of God.

In the third part: John tells the believers that the Holy Spirit is teaching the believers everything they need to know.

Throughout this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus
- Holy Spirit
- Antichrists—meaning enemies of Christ

- And fake believers who try to deceive the believers

In this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he says that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

Stop and do this activity: Please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Also, leave an object behind in this part of the garden, for later. You should notice that you have already been in this part of the garden before! Pause this audio here.

John addresses the believers again as children. This shows the good relationship that John has with the believers.

John tells the believers it is the last hour. In the New Testament, people call the whole period between Jesus' birth and the time that Jesus will come back again, the "last days." So all of us, John's listeners and us today, are living in the "last days." At the end of these "last days" will be a "last day," and that will be the day that Jesus will come back. John is the only writer who even talks about the "last hour." But the Bible writers do not use these terms very precisely. John probably just means to say that Jesus is about to come back any moment. That was true for the believers in John's time, and it is still true for us today, even though we live so much later. We always have to be prepared that Jesus can come back at any moment.

The believers had heard about someone whom John calls "the antichrist." It seems that the believers had heard about a certain enemy of Jesus who would come just before Jesus would come back. People called this enemy the "antichrist." But John says that right now there are many antichrists! There is not just one enemy of Jesus, but there are many.

Stop here and discuss: How would you describe or translate "antichrists" in your language? Pause this audio here.

These antichrists, these enemies of Christ, had been part of the group of believers, but they had left. John says that these people did not remain with us, meaning they did not keep their good relationship with John and the other believers. These people stopped listening to John and began to believe and teach wrong things. Maybe you remember that we already said that the word "remain" is very important to John. He will use this same word again several times in this passage, as we will see later.

We now understand that these "antichrists" were, in fact, the fake believers that John has been talking about all this time. These people only pretended to be part of the church. John says that the fact that these people left is proof that they never really belonged in the church. John is not talking about people who just moved away to another place. John means that these people broke their relationship with the other believers. If these people had really belonged to the group of believers, they would have kept their good relationship with the others!

Stop here and act out how the fake believers pretended to belong to the church, but how they left and did not keep a good relationship with the believers. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that these people did not remain with the believers. Pause this audio here.

John encourages the believers that they are very different from those fake believers! John knows that the believers know the true things about Jesus. John is not writing to the believers because they do not know these things. John wants to encourage the believers that they already know the truth about Jesus. The believers might have felt insecure because of the things that the fake believers said, but they do not need to feel that way.

John says that the believers know that a lie does not come from the truth. The things that the fake believers were saying were lies. These things cannot come from God, because God always speaks the truth. The believers know what is the truth. This will help the believers to recognize that what the fake believers are saying is wrong. The believers know the difference between what is true and what is a lie.

Stop here and do this activity: Go outside and find some different plants or trees. Pluck a flower, leaf, or branch from one plant or tree. With some rope or tape, or any other thing you have, tie this flower or leaf on a completely different type of plant or tree. Then find someone new and show the person what you did. Ask that person, "Is this flower or leaf true?" Go and do this activity now. We will talk more about it when you come back. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, other people could see that the flower that you had put on the tree was not true. The flower did not belong to that tree or plant. The flower was a lie, and it could not have come from that plant. The people were able to see that it was a lie. Like that, John's listeners are able to recognise that what the fake believers are saying is a lie. It cannot be true.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that a lie cannot come from the truth. Pause this audio here.

John then asks a question about who the liar is. John means, "Who is the worst possible liar?" John will answer the question himself. John asks the question so that his listeners will realize that John is going to say something important.

The worst possible liar is someone who says that Jesus is not the Christ, the Savior. Such a person is an enemy of Jesus, an antichrist. Such people say that Jesus is not the Son of God and that God is not the father of Jesus. These are people like Sam and Sally, who did not think that it was important that the Son of God became a human being. At the same time, this can refer to people who might think that Jesus was a good and important person, but that Jesus was not the Son of God. Whatever it means, it is clear that John is speaking against people who are believing the wrong things about Jesus.

John tells the people that you cannot have God without Jesus. John says here the same thing twice, but once in a positive way, and once in a negative way, which is something John likes to do often. John says you cannot have a relationship with God if you do not believe that God is Jesus' father, and that Jesus is God's son. But people who do believe that Jesus is the Son of God will right away have a relationship with God the Father as well.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that no one who denies the Son has the Father, and that everyone who trusts in the Son has the Father. Pause this audio here.

John encourages the believers to keep believing the things that they learned in the beginning, when they had just become believers. They should not start to believe the new, wrong teaching of the fake believers. John says that what the believers have learned should remain in them. That means the believers should keep believing and obeying everything they have learned about Jesus. If they do that, then the believers will remain in Jesus the Son and in God the Father. If they keep believing the right things about Jesus, then the believers will continue to be in a good relationship with God. Then God will give the believers what God has promised them: eternal life, the best possible life.

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, if you did the optional activity, you have made some flowers that represent eternal life. Place one of these flowers in this part of the garden. Pause this audio here.

John is writing all this because he does not want other people to make the believers believe untrue things. Jesus had given the believers an anointing, the Holy Spirit. In the Old Testament, people poured oil over someone to appoint them for a special task. The oil was a symbol for the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would help the people to do their task well. The believers also have the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is helping the believers. This is not something that only happened once, but the Holy Spirit remains in the believers and keeps helping them. The Holy Spirit teaches the believers everything they need to know. The believers do not need the fake believers to teach them anything. The fake believers might have said that they had an anointing, but that was a lie. The anointing that the believers have is true. The believers have the Holy Spirit, and the believers should keep believing everything that the Holy Spirit teaches them.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a salesman who was cheating people by selling things that looked like very expensive things, but that were actually very cheap? What words would you use to talk about things that are fake, that are not really what people say they are? Pause this audio here.

One last time, for now, John encourages the believers to remain in Jesus. John addresses the believers again as "dear children." If the believers keep their good relationship with Jesus, they will not have to be afraid that Jesus will reject them when he comes back to judge! John says that the believers can be confident or that they can have courage. If Jesus would reject the believers, they would be ashamed! But now, if the believers keep their good relationship with Jesus, they can be sure that Jesus will accept them.

Stop here. We still have more to say about this passage. But this is a good time to stand up and stretch! Come back when you are ready. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, John uses two different ways to talk about Jesus' return. First, John says that Jesus will be revealed or that Jesus will appear. When you reveal something, you show people something that they could not see before. In the very first passage, John spoke about Jesus Christ, and John called Jesus "the life." John said that this life was revealed. This meant that the Son of God, who was with God in heaven, became a human being, Jesus. We could not see Jesus when he was still in heaven, but when Jesus came to earth as a human, we could see him. After Jesus died and became alive again, Jesus went back to heaven. And we cannot now see Jesus. But one day, Jesus will come back again! We will then be able to see Jesus again. Just as God revealed Jesus the first time, when Jesus was born as a human, God will reveal Jesus again when Jesus comes back. We will then all be able to see Jesus.

The other way that John talks about Jesus' return is to talk about his coming. John uses a word for "coming" that people used when they talked about kings or other very important people who would come to visit a city or some other place. When such a person would visit the city, it was a very big event, and everybody would get very excited! And so, John is here talking about the time that Jesus will come back as king. This will be a very big event! The biggest event ever!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about an important person visiting your town or village? How did this person arrive, and how did the people welcome them? Pause this audio here.

Now, stop here and do this activity: Act out that some believers keep believing that Jesus is the Son of God, and the Savior, and that some other people stop believing that. Act out that Jesus comes, in the way that a king or important person comes. Act out that the true believers and Jesus embrace each other, or greet each other very lovingly. Act out that Jesus rejects the fake believers. Act out that the fake believers are very much ashamed. Pause this audio here.

John has used the word remain many times in the passage. In the first part of the passage, John used this word one time. John said that the fake believers did not remain with the other believers. In the second part of the passage, John uses the word "remain" six times. John also talked about knowledge and knowing several times in this passage. John also mentioned truth and lies a lot.

Stop here and do this activity. Listen again to a translation of the passage. Some people will clap each time they hear a word like "remain." Some people will clap each time they hear a word like "knowing" or "knowledge." Some people will clap each time they hear a word like "truth" or "true." Some people will clap each time they hear a word like "lie" or "liar." You can also decide that each group will make a different sound whenever they hear "their" word! Maybe you can record the music you will make together this way! Pause this audio here.

It could be that you did not hear these words so much because the translation you are listening to used different words. That is fine. You also will have to use words that fit your language, even though they may not be the same each time.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:18–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus
- Holy Spirit

- Antichrists—enemies of Christ
- And fake believers who try to deceive the believers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John says something like this:

"My dear children, there is not much time left! You have heard about an enemy of Christ, an antichrist, who would come just before Jesus would come back. Well, this enemy has now come! And not just one, but many. These enemies of Christ pretended to belong to us, but they did not really belong to us. Now these enemies have left us. If these enemies had really belonged to us, they would have kept their good relationship with us, and they would not have begun to teach the wrong things about Jesus!" Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" You may hear things like:

- We understand now that the people who said they had so much knowledge were lying. These people never were true believers!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"But you, you know the right things about Jesus. Jesus, the holy one, has given you the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is teaching you what is true. And you know the truth. You know the difference between what is true and what is a lie." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners: "What are you thinking?" You may hear things like:

- I am so encouraged! I do not have to think that those fake believers know more than I do. I should listen to the Holy Spirit, and not to these people.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"And you know what the worst lie is? The worst lie is that Jesus would not be the Christ, the Savior! People who say this are the biggest enemies of Christ. These people say that Jesus is not the Son of God the Father. But you cannot have God without Jesus! Only people who believe that Jesus is the Son of God can have a relationship with God the Father." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I want the believers to stay away from people who say such things! The human Jesus really is the Son of God. Jesus himself is God. Only people who believe this can be saved.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"The teaching about Jesus that you heard in the beginning should remain in you. You should keep believing that. Then you will remain in the Son and in the Father. You will keep having a good relationship with Jesus and with God the Father. Then God will give you the eternal life that he promised you, the very best possible life.

"I write all this to you so that you will not get confused by the people who try to deceive you. And you, you do not need anyone to teach you anything, because the Holy Spirit remains in you. The Holy Spirit is your teacher. And everything the Holy Spirit will teach you is true. So, stick with what the Holy Spirit has taught you, and remain in Jesus—keep your good relationship with him." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- John and the other apostles told us that Jesus is the Savior, the Son of God. I believed it when I became a believer. I should keep believing it now! or
- I want to keep having a good relationship with Jesus and with God the Father! I do not want God to reject me!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"Now, my dear children, remain in him! Then, when Jesus will appear again, we will meet Jesus in full confidence. We know that when Jesus comes as king, we will not have to be ashamed, because Jesus will accept us!" Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- Now I know that I should not be confused by these people who claimed that they know God. These people do not know anything! The apostles and the Holy Spirit are teaching us what is true. I can look forward to meeting Jesus now, and I do not need to be afraid!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:18–28 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John addresses his listeners as "**dear children**" or "little children." John is using these words to show the people that he loves them. "Little child" was an affectionate way to speak to someone. Use the same words as you have used in the previous passages.

John says that this is the "last hour." John means that Jesus is going to come back very soon.

Stop here and discuss what words or phrases you will use for the **last hour**. Pause this audio here.

John talks about the enemies of Jesus. John calls an enemy of Jesus the "antichrist." These people do not believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Savior.

Stop here and remind yourself what word or phrase you want to use for **antichrist**. Pause this audio here.

The believers have an anointing from the "holy one." The "holy one" could refer to God or to Jesus. God is holy because God is completely good, pure, powerful, and majestic. It means that God is whole, complete, and unchangeable. Jesus is holy because he is God. Everything that is true about God is true about Jesus as well. John is probably talking about Jesus here, but John could be thinking about God as well.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the **holy one** in your translation. Use the same word for holy as you have used in other passages. The word holy is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The believers have an anointing from the holy one. This means that the holy one, Jesus, has anointed the believers. John probably means that Jesus has given the Holy Spirit to the believers.

To anoint someone means to pour sweet-smelling oil over that person. In the Old Testament, before God gave someone a special task, he would instruct someone else to pour oil over that person's head. The oil was a symbol for the Holy Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit would help the person with the special task they had to do.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that the believers have an **anointing** from the holy one, or that the holy one has anointed the believers. The word anoint is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John says that all the believers have **knowledge**. John means that the believers know the right things about God and about Jesus.

The enemies of Jesus say that Jesus is not the **Christ**. Christ means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means that Jesus is the Son of God. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages.

The enemies of Jesus deny the Father and the Son. The "Father" refers to God the Father. The "Son" refers to Jesus. John probably means that these people deny that Jesus is the Son of God. These people say that Jesus is not the Son of God. John then says that people who say that Jesus is not the Son of God are also denying God. If you deny God, you are rejecting God. You do not want to listen to God.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that these people **deny** the Father and the Son. The "Son of God" is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John says that people who **confess** the Son also have the Father. John means that people who believe and openly say that Jesus is the Son of God, will also have a good relationship with God the Father.

Stop here and discuss how you will say this in your language. Pause this audio here.

As we noticed when we were doing the activity of clapping whenever we heard the word "remain," John uses this word a lot. It could be that it will not sound good in your language to use the same word every time John uses the word "remain." John says that what the believers have heard in the beginning should remain in them. That means the believers should keep believing the things they have learned from John and the other apostles when they became believers.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that what the believers have heard in the beginning should "**remain**" in them. Pause this audio here.

The believers should remain in him, Jesus, which means that they should keep their good relationship with Jesus by continuously believing the right things about Jesus.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that the believers should remain in "him." Pause this audio here.

God has promised to give us **eternal life** if we remain in Jesus. When we have eternal life, it means we live in a wonderful relationship with God. Eternal life is the best possible kind of life you could have! In the New Testament, eternal life does not necessarily mean a life that will never end. It could be, but that is not the main point. The main point of having eternal life is that you have a perfect relationship with God. Use the same word for "eternal life" as you have used in other passages. The word eternal life is in the Master Glossary.

John says we should remain in Jesus so that when Jesus appears, or when God reveals Jesus, we may have confidence. We will not have to be ashamed when Jesus comes. That Jesus appears means that people will suddenly see Jesus. God will make it possible for us to see Jesus. God reveals Jesus.

When Jesus appears, the believers can have confidence. If you have confidence, you are not afraid. The believers do not have to be afraid that Jesus will reject them. If Jesus would reject them, the believers would be ashamed. But if the believers keep their good relationship with Jesus, they do not have to be afraid that Jesus will reject them and that they would then be ashamed.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that the believers can have **confidence** and will not have to be ashamed when Jesus comes. Pause this audio here.

When John says that we do not have to be ashamed when Jesus will come, John uses a word for "coming" that people used when they talked about kings or other very important people who would come to visit a city or some other place. When such a person would visit the city, it was a very big event, and everybody would get very excited! And so, John is here talking about the time that Jesus will come back as king. This will be a very big event! The biggest event ever!

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Jesus will **come**. Maybe you could say that Jesus will come as king.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 2:18–28

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (696 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (10.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1011 KB)

1 John 2:29–3:10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 2:29-3:10 and put it in your hearts. Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:29–3:10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:29–3:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John talked about how important it is to keep believing the right things about Jesus. People who say that Jesus is not the Christ and the Son of God are antichrists, enemies of Christ. John warned the believers that they should not get confused because of the lies that the fake believers were telling.

Earlier in the sermon, we learned that fake believers, like Sam and Sally, did not think that it was a problem if people sinned. The fake believers did not think that God cared very much about how people behaved. It is much more important to have spiritual experiences, they thought.

In this passage, John will tell his listeners that the fake believers are very wrong. God does care about how people behave!

Have you ever been in a situation where you met a stranger, and this stranger reminded you of someone else? And you thought, “Hey, I wonder whether this person is a child of so-and-so!” You did not know this stranger, but there was someone else you did know, and you wondered if maybe they were related. This is because people who are related look like each other. Maybe your own children look very much like you, or you look very much like your father and mother!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about some people from the same family who looked or behaved very similarly? Pause this audio here.

Well, when we become children of God, we begin to look like God! Of course, it is not that our face or our body changes, but our thinking changes, and therefore, our behaviour.

John says, God is righteous. God always does what is good and right. And so, when you see someone who does the right thing, you know, “This person behaves just as Jesus would! This person must be a child of God!”

And we are God’s children, because God loves us so much. Imagine that one day you find a child somewhere who has no parents. The child is dirty and behaves very badly. But you take pity on the child. You take the child home and wash it and feed it and take care of it, and then you tell the other people, “See, this is my child!” The child might be amazed, and one day it might tell you, “Wow, I cannot believe that you love me so much that you even call me your child!” This is what God has done for us. And in the middle of writing his sermon, John seems overwhelmed when he thinks about how much God loves us!

Stop here and discuss: Can you share with each other something about how it makes you feel to know that God calls us his children? Pause this audio here.

John says we are indeed the children of God. The people in this world who do not belong to God do not know that we are the children of God. When Jesus was on earth, the people did not recognize that Jesus was the Son of God. In the same way, people now do not recognize that we are children of God. The people are treating us in the same bad way as they were treating Jesus. And this is actually another sign that we are indeed God’s children!

We are already God’s children now, even though we cannot fully see this yet. We cannot fully imagine and understand what it means that we are the children of God. But when Jesus will come back as king, then it will become completely clear! When Jesus will come back, we will be able to see Jesus as he really is. And then we also will become like Jesus. We do not quite know yet what that means. John means to say that for now, we still look weak and imperfect. We may not look very much like God’s children yet. But this is all going to change when Jesus will come back!

Because God is going to make us perfect children of God when Jesus will come back, we should already now behave as children of God. Jesus, the Son of God, is pure, completely good. So we should follow Jesus’ example and do our best to be completely good.

If we once more use the example of a little filthy child who behaves badly, then imagine that a very wealthy and good person meets such a child, and would say to this child: “I will adopt you! I will be gone for some time, but when I come back, you will be my son, and you will live with me.” The child could then think, “That’s nice. This good man will adopt me, but for now, I will just keep being dirty and behave as badly as I can.” Or the child could think, “This good man will adopt me. I should start cleaning up, and I should behave better!” In the same way, because we already know that we are God’s children and that we will be like Jesus, we should already now be pure, just like Jesus.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who behaved like Jesus? Or can you tell a story about some situation you are facing and talk about what it would mean to behave like Jesus in this situation? Pause this audio here.

John ended the previous passage by saying that if we remain in Jesus, we will not be ashamed when Jesus will come back as king. John now tells us more about why Jesus came on earth the first time; why God revealed Jesus.

We have already said that people like Sam and Sally were much more interested in a spiritual Jesus than in a human Jesus. Because Sam and Sally were not so interested in Jesus as a human being, they did not think that it was very important that Jesus had died. Sam and Sally did not think that the Son of God needed to die so that God could forgive our sins. Sam and Sally did not think that sin was a big problem for God.

But John says that the Son of God came to earth to take away our sins. Jesus came to receive the punishment for our sins, so that God could forgive our sins. Sin is a big problem for God! Sin is such a big problem for God that God sent his own son to die and take the punishment for our sins in our place.

Jesus himself has never done any sin. John then says something that is a little bit puzzling. John says that someone who remains in Jesus, who keeps having a good relationship with Jesus, does not sin. Earlier, John had said that if we say that we have not sinned, we are lying. So, John made clear that everybody is sinning. How then can John here say that someone who remains in Jesus does not sin?

John probably means that anyone who has a good relationship with Jesus will not be able to keep sinning willfully. As soon as this person realizes that they sinned, they will tell God that they are sorry and they want to stop doing this wrong thing. Some scholars think that John means that in the future, after Jesus has come back, we will be unable to sin. And therefore, we should already now behave according to what we will be in the future.

Either way, it is clear that John tells us that we cannot be a believer if we do not care whether we are doing right or wrong. If we are doing the right things, then we are children of God. But if we willfully and continuously do sin, then we are children of the devil! Jesus came to earth to defeat the devil and to destroy all the evil things that the devil has done.

Stop here and do this activity: Select one person who will represent the devil, and one person who will represent Jesus. The person who represents the devil will continuously stamp his feet. The other people will copy everything that the devil does. Then, Jesus comes on the stage. Act out that Jesus will defeat the devil. Jesus will then continuously clap his hands or do some other action that is different from what the devil did. Then, some people who were copying the devil will now begin to copy Jesus. But some people will keep doing the same action that the devil was doing, even though the devil is no longer there! These people no longer have a reason to do what they were doing, because their example is dead. But these people are still doing it anyway. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, you could see how strange it would be for people to keep sinning even after Jesus defeated the devil! And so we see that we cannot have a good relationship with Jesus if we keep doing sin. John ended the previous passage by saying that if we remain in him we will not have to be ashamed when Jesus will come back. Now, John has explained that to remain in Jesus means that you will not willfully continue to sin.

So, in this passage, John has given us another way to see whether someone is a true believer or not. We can look at how people behave. Some people behave like children of God, and some people behave like children of the devil. No matter what people say about themselves, if they keep doing the things that God does not want us to do, they do not belong to God.

At the end of this passage, John also says that people who do not love the other believers do not belong to God! We had already heard in an earlier passage how important it is that we love our fellow believers. In the next passage, John is going to say more about that.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:29–3:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: John says that we are God's children.

In the second part: John says that the children of God do what is right and that people who sin are children of the devil.

Throughout this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God do not keep sinning.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God the Father
- Jesus
- Children of God
- People who do what is right
- People who continue to do sin
- The devil
- And children of the devil

Stop here and do this activity: In this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God do not keep sinning. Please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Also, leave behind an object for later. Do you notice that you have been here before? Pause this audio here.

John says that his listeners know that "he," meaning Jesus, or God, or both, is righteous. And John's listeners also know that everybody who does what is right is a child of God. John means to say that people who are God's children do what is good and right in God's eyes.

The person who is doing the right thing is "born of God." To be born of God means the same as being a child of God. Maybe you remember that in the Gospel of John, Jesus had a conversation with a religious teacher, Nicodemus. Jesus had told Nicodemus that only someone who was born again could enter the kingdom of God. Jesus had explained that to be born again did not mean that someone was physically reborn, but that they were spiritually reborn.

Someone who is a child of God is not a biological, physical child of God, but a spiritual child. God gave his Spirit to us. God's Spirit made us a new person. Because we have God's Spirit, we begin to behave like God. And God accepts us as his children.

Stop here and, if you like, listen to your own translation of John 3:1–5. Pause this audio here.

Then, John begins to wonder out loud, "How can it be possible that God loves us so much that he calls us his children?" It is almost as if John is bursting out in a song! Or, as if in the middle of writing the sermon, or walking through the garden, John is suddenly overwhelmed because he realises how much God loves us! And John then says, "This amazing, wonderful thing is really true! God loves us so very much! We are indeed God's children!"

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you have made some flowers that represent how much God loves us. Plant one of these flowers in this part of the garden. Pause this audio here.

John says that the world does not know us. John means that the people who do not believe or trust in Jesus do not know that we are children of God. These people cannot recognize who we truly are. This is just the same as what happened to Jesus. The people did not recognize who Jesus truly was either.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that the world does not know us. Do not spend too much time on this. You will get more opportunities to discuss this later. Pause this audio here.

We really are God's children, even though we still have to go through a lot of difficulties in this life. We do not very much look like children of a perfect, wonderful God! And we cannot quite imagine or understand what we are going to be like after Jesus has come back as king. But we know that God is going to change us and that we will become like Jesus. When Jesus will come back, God will reveal what we will be like. When you reveal something, you show people something that they could not see before.

In the previous passage, we said that God had revealed Jesus when he first came to earth, and that God will reveal Jesus again when Jesus will come back the second time. God will make us see Jesus. In the same way, when Jesus will come back, God will also reveal what we will be like.

Stop here, and if you like, do this activity. Take one member of your group and change the way this person looks. Dress the person up, or paint them, or change the hairstyle. Be creative! Then, hide this person underneath a bed sheet or curtain, or put them behind a tree. Then invite some other people to come and look. When these

people have arrived, you will remove the bedsheet or curtain or pull the person away from behind the tree. You have now revealed what this person now looks like! Pause this audio here.

When Jesus will come back as a king, God will change us. But God will change not just the way that we look, but God will change our whole person. We do not yet quite know what we will be like. When Jesus will come back, when God will reveal Jesus, then God will also reveal, or show us, what we will be like as God's children.

Stop here and discuss how you will say we really are already God's children, even today, even though we do not quite know yet what this will look like. God will show us how we will be when Jesus comes back. Pause this audio here.

John says that everybody who has this hope in Jesus will keep themselves pure. In the Bible, someone who hopes is someone who is sure that something will happen, even though they cannot yet see it. John means that because we are sure that we are God's children, and we are sure that God is going to change us, we already now want to keep ourselves pure. Someone who is pure is completely good. There is nothing bad in this person. Jesus is pure, and we should be like Jesus.

John says that when someone sins, they break the law of God. This means that this person rebels against God. God sent Jesus to earth in order to take away our sins. So, it would be rather strange if we keep sinning! A person who remains in Jesus, who has a relationship with Jesus and who does what Jesus wants, will not sin. On the other hand, a person who keeps doing sin has never seen Jesus and does not know Jesus. To see Jesus and to know Jesus both mean to have a good relationship with Jesus.

If you do not mind getting a little dirty, stop here and do this activity. Ask some people to make their hands or their faces dirty with something that you can clean easily, like mud or charcoal. Then, ask someone who represents Jesus to wash these people clean again. Some people will stay clean. These people will act out that they have a good relationship with Jesus. But some other people will make themselves dirty right away! Those people will act out that they do not have a relationship with Jesus at all. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, it was rather foolish of the people who had become clean to make themselves dirty again right away! People who keep sinning cannot have a good relationship with Jesus.

John again addresses his listeners as "dear children." John warns them again that no one should deceive them. The fake believers said that they knew Jesus, and they said that it was not important whether we did right or wrong. The true believers should not listen to these people. These people are telling lies. These people want to deceive the believers and make them believe the wrong things.

Everything that God does is good. And so, God wants us to do good things too. Only someone who does good things is good in God's eyes. The fake believers thought that no matter what people did, God accepted them and considered them good. But that is not true. God only accepts people who do the right things.

People who continuously keep sinning do not belong to God. These people are children of the devil. This means that these people are behaving in the same evil way as the devil does. The devil has always sinned and rebelled against God, from the beginning of the world. The devil wants people to rebel against God as well. The devil wants people to suffer and to do all kinds of wrong things.

Stop here and discuss: Can one of you briefly tell the story of how the devil, in the form of a snake, made the first humans, Adam and Eve, sin? Pause this audio here.

But Jesus came to earth in order to defeat the devil. John again uses the word "reveal." God revealed Jesus, the Son of God, so that Jesus could destroy every bad thing that the devil had done. Jesus would make everything right again. Jesus would make people stop doing the bad things that the devil wanted. Then people would do the right things that God wanted them to do.

Children of God do not behave like children of the devil. Children of God do not continuously keep sinning. John says that this is because the seed of God remains in the children of God. Every child is born because of the seed, the semen, of a man. Part of a child's father will always be present in his child. So, because we are spiritual children of God, God's "seed" is in us. God's seed in us is the Holy Spirit.

People who have the Holy Spirit cannot sin. John probably means that these people are not able to willfully and continuously keep sinning. The Holy Spirit tells these people when they sin, and then the people will repent and stop doing that sin.

Stop here and discuss how you could say that God's seed remains in the children of God. Pause this audio here.

John finishes the passage by saying that we can see who are the children of God and who are the children of the devil by looking at what they are doing. Only those who are doing what is right are children of God. Then John gives a very important example of what it is to do right. To do right means to love your fellow believers! Only those people who love their spiritual brothers and sisters, their fellow believers, are children of God.

John used the word "reveal" a lot in this passage. It could be that the translation that you have listened to does not use the same word each time. In your translation, you should also use the best words, even though they may not be the same each time.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text
Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:29–3:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God the Father
- Jesus
- Children of God
- People who do what is right
- People who continue to do sin
- The devil
- And children of the devil

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out that John is speaking to the believers.

John says something like this:

"You know that everything that God does is right. If people are doing the right things, then they are children of God for sure. Oh, yes, we are children of God! Is it not amazing that God loves us so much that he calls us his children?" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you feeling?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so overwhelmed! I do not understand how God can love us so much. It is amazing! I hope my listeners really understand how special this is!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"The people who belong to the sinful world did not recognize that Jesus was the Son of God. Like that, they also do not recognize that we are the children of God. But, dear friends, we really are already God's children, even today, even though we do not quite know yet what this will look like. God will show us how we will be when Jesus comes back. But we do already know that we will be like Jesus then! And so, because we trust that this will happen indeed, we should already now behave like Jesus as well. We should not do any sin, because Jesus is completely pure and good and never does any sin." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- John is right that it is amazing that God calls us God's children. This makes us brothers and sisters of Jesus! We should follow the example of our big brother Jesus and behave like him; or
- I do not feel very much like a child of God. I still make so many mistakes. But I am glad that God is going to make me just like Jesus one day! or
- I feel a little worried. It is impossible not to do any sin. I am not sure if Jesus will accept me.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"Sin means rebellion against God. Everybody who does sin rebels against God. Jesus, who never did any sin himself, came to take our sin away. So, someone who keeps sinning does not really know Jesus. If you do know Jesus, you will not keep sinning." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I understand now that those people are wrong who say they know so much about God and that it does not matter what we do or how we behave. God does care a lot about how we behave! or
- It would be very strange if we kept sinning after Jesus came to the world to forgive our sins. Jesus came to forgive our sins because he wants us not to do sin; or
- I am still worried. I do not want to do sin, but I do it all the time. I need to remember that John had said earlier that we do not have to be afraid, because God forgives our sins.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"Dear children, do not believe the people who are lying to you. God only accepts people who do the right things like Jesus. If you keep sinning, you are a child of the devil, and not a child of God! Because if you sin, you behave just like the devil, who has sinned from the beginning of the world. And God sent Jesus to this world to destroy all the evil works of the devil! So, of course, if you are a child of God, you will stop sinning. You cannot even keep sinning if you are a child of God, because the Holy Spirit lives in you!" Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I do not want to be a child of the devil! I want to be a child of God; or
- I am glad that the Holy Spirit helps us not to sin; or
- I am not quite sure that I really cannot keep sinning. But it is true that I do not like it when I sin! Maybe that is what John means?

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"So this is how we can see who is a child of God, and who is a child of the devil. The children of God are the people who do what is right, and, very importantly, who love their brothers and sisters." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- The people who left our church did not love us. Those people looked down on us. Now I know that those people were not real children of God; or
- I am worried. I know I do the wrong things. I do not want people to think that I am a child of the devil. But I keep remembering that John also said that God forgives our sins. I need to keep remembering that God loves me very much. God has made me his child. God will help me to do the right things.

Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

1 John 2:29–3:10

- I do not want the believers to listen to the lies of the fake believers. I really hope the believers understand that you cannot be a Christian if you wilfully keep sinning at the same time!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 2:29–3:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

God is **righteous**. This means that everything that God does is right and good. Use the same word that you have used in previous passages. The word righteousness is in the Master Glossary.

People who do right are "born of him." This means that people who are doing the right things are children of God.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that people who do right are "**born of him**," or are children of God. Pause this audio here.

John addresses his listeners as **beloved**. This means that John loves the people to whom John is writing. It can also mean that God loves the people, or both. John means that his listeners are John's dear friends. John speaks very kindly to his listeners. Use the same word that you have used in previous passages.

The world does not know that we are children of God. Here, the "world" refers to the people who belong to the rebellious world, the sinful world, the world where Satan still has power. The people who belong to this sinful world do not recognize who we really are. These people do not see that we are the children of God.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the **world** does not know that we are children of God. Pause this audio here.

We know that when Jesus will come back, we will be like Jesus. This is something that we **hope** for. Sometimes people say that they are hoping for something that they are not sure will really happen. For instance, people may say that they hope that it will rain tomorrow. These people hope that it will rain, but they are not sure that it will happen. Hope in the Bible is always different. In the Bible, someone who hopes is someone who is sure that something will happen, even though they cannot yet see it.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that we hope that we will be like Jesus. Use the same word for hope as you have used in other passages. The word hope is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Because we are sure that we are God's children, and we are sure that God is going to change us, we now already want to keep ourselves pure. Someone who is pure is completely good. There is nothing bad in this person. Jesus is pure. And we should be like Jesus. Because Jesus is pure, we should purify ourselves. We should become pure. When people sin, they become impure. God can no longer accept these people. People should stop sinning, and they should ask God to forgive them. Then people will be pure again.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Jesus is **pure**, and how you will say that people should **purify** themselves. Use the same words or phrases as you have used in other passages. The words pure and purify are in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

People who commit **sin** are breaking the law of God. These people do not do what God wants them to do. These people rebel against God. Use the same word for sin as you have used in other passages. The word sin is in the Master Glossary.

The law of God means all the good rules that God has given to the people. Someone who is lawless does not care about God's law. This person constantly breaks the law of God. This person willfully disobeys God. This person rebels against God and does not want to do what God wants.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that people who are guilty of sin are guilty of **lawlessness**. The word law is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

John uses the word **reveal** a lot in this passage. When you reveal something, you show people something that they could not see before. If something is revealed, it means that it becomes visible. Usually, God is the one who is making it visible. God will reveal Jesus when he comes back. God will make visible what we will be when

1 John 2:29–3:10

Jesus will come back. The translation that you have listened to might use different words. For example, instead of saying that God revealed Jesus, the translation might say that Jesus appeared. You also will need to use words that will sound the most natural in your language.

Someone who **remains** in Jesus will not sin. Someone who remains in Jesus continuously keeps a good relationship with Jesus and does what Jesus says. Use the same word or phrase as you have used for remaining in Jesus in the previous passages.

In this passage, John addresses his listeners again as **dear children**, or little children. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in earlier passages.

Everyone who sins is a child of the devil. In an earlier passage, John called the devil the "evil one." The devil is the leader of all the evil spirits who have rebelled against God. The devil is the same person as Satan.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for the **devil**. Use the same word that you have used in other books of the Bible. The word devil is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The Son of God, or Jesus, came to destroy what the devil does. The Son of God is a title for Jesus. Jesus is called the Son of God because he has a special relationship with God the Father. God and Jesus love each other in the way that a father and a son love each other. Sometimes Jesus is called "the only son of God." This means that the relationship that Jesus has with God is unique. Nobody else has this same relationship with God as Jesus has.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Son of God**. Use the same word or phrase for "Son of God" when it refers to Jesus as you have used in previous passages. "Son of God" is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Children of God cannot sin because God's seed remains in them. John is using special language to say that the Holy Spirit continuously remains in the children of God. Every child always has something of his father inside him. A child may look like their father or behave like their father. That is because the father's seed, or semen, contained these characteristics of the child's father. We are God's spiritual children. God's Spirit is in us. God's Spirit makes us behave like God the Father. Therefore, we do not any longer want to do things that God does not want.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that children of God cannot sin, because **God's seed**, or God's nature, remains in them. Pause this audio here.

People who do not love their **brothers** are not children of God. Believers belong to the family of God. Therefore, all other believers are our brothers and sisters. When John talks about brothers, John is talking about all our fellow believers, male and female. Use the same word that you have used in the previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 2:29–3:10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (731 KB)
- Setting the Stage (7.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.0 MB)

1 John 3:11–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 3:11–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:11–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:11–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

John ended the previous passage by saying that we can see who are the children of God and who are the children of the devil by looking at what they are doing. Only those who are doing what is right are children of God. And only those who love their spiritual brothers and sisters, their fellow believers, are children of God.

In this passage, John is saying again that we have to love our fellow believers. John says that this is the message that the believers have heard since the time that they became followers of Christ. This message is the same as the new commandment that John talked about earlier. You will remember that John talked about a new commandment, which was old at the same time! This was the commandment that Jesus had given: that we had to love each other. It is so important that we love each other that John keeps saying this over and over again.

John reminds the believers that they should keep obeying this message because they heard this from the beginning. They should not be like the fake believers, who started to believe different things. And these fake believers did not love the other believers but looked down on other believers and eventually left this community of believers.

In this passage, John gives two examples. One example is of someone we should not follow, and one example is of Jesus, whom we should follow.

The example we should not follow is the example of Cain. Cain was the first son of Adam and Eve. Cain murdered his brother, Abel. We find this story in Genesis 4.

1 John 3:11–18

Cain murdered his brother because he was jealous of his brother. Cain and Abel had both given God an offering, a gift. God accepted Abel's gift, but God did not accept Cain's gift. Cain became very angry about that! God told Cain that he should do the right things and not the wrong things. But Cain did not listen to God. Cain then killed his brother. God punished Cain by sending Cain away. Cain could no longer have a relationship with God.

If you like, stop here and listen to Genesis 4:1–12, in your own translation if possible. If you are already familiar with this story, then act it out instead. Or you can do both! Pause this audio here.

John says that a person who hates anyone else is a murderer. Even if you would not actually kill someone, you are as bad as a murderer if you even hate someone!

Someone who hates anyone else, and especially someone who hates a fellow believer, is not spiritually alive. This person is still dead.

The example that we should follow is the example of Christ. Christ did the opposite of murdering someone—Christ allowed people to kill Christ! Jesus died for the people. Because Christ died, many people could live. Instead of taking away people's lives, Christ gave people life.

Stop here and act out Cain killing his brother, and then act out that Christ died to give people life. Pause this audio here.

We have to be like Christ. We should love other people, and especially our fellow believers, even if this would mean that we have to do something difficult. Yes, even if this would mean that we could die! John gives a very practical example of what it means to love a fellow believer. If you have enough food or money to live comfortably, you should share with fellow believers who do not have enough. If you see a fellow believer who needs something, and you think, "So what? I do not care!" you do not love that person. Just saying that you love your fellow believers is not enough. You actually have to do something!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about another believer who helped you when you had a need, or about a time that you helped another believer?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:11–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one part. In this part, John tells us how important it is that we should love our fellow believers. John is in the part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God should love each other.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- Cain
- Cain's brother, Abel, though John does not mention Abel's name
- The evil one, who is the devil
- The people who belong to the sinful world
- The believers
- People who hate a fellow believer
- Christ
- God
- A believer who has enough to share but who does not care about others
- And a fellow believer who is in need

In this passage, John is in the part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God should love each other.

1 John 3:11–18

Stop here and do this activity: Please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Do not forget to leave behind an object to show that you have been there, and look at how many times you have been there before. Pause this audio here.

John had said at the end of the previous passage that people who do not do what is right and who do not love their fellow believers do not belong to God.

Now John explains why this is the case. When John's listeners first became believers, they heard the message that they should love the other believers. This commandment to love the other believers is so important that you cannot be a follower of Christ if you do not obey this commandment.

John explains this by telling the story of Cain. Cain did not love his brother. Cain hated his brother. This shows that Cain did not belong to God, but to the evil one, the devil.

Cain hated his brother because his brother was doing the right things, and Cain was doing the wrong things. Cain was jealous of his brother because his brother did the right things. In the end, Cain killed his brother.

John tells the believers that they should not be surprised if people who belong to the sinful world, people who do not follow Christ, hate the believers. Just like Cain hated his brother because his brother did the right things, like that, the people who belong to the sinful world will hate the believers, because the believers are doing the right things.

John addresses the other believers here as his "brothers and sisters," not as children. This reminds us that all the believers are brothers and sisters of each other.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about people hating someone who did good? Pause this audio here.

Cain was not a child of God, but a child of the devil, because Cain hated his brother.

John then tells something encouraging to the believers. John says "we," meaning John and his listeners together, are not like Cain! We do love other people. And this is a sign that we are truly alive.

Stop here and do this activity: Ask four people to step out in two pairs to prepare a brief drama. One pair will act out how people who do not love each other behave. For instance, these people do not help each other with a need or a problem. The other pair will act out the same situation, but this time, they will help each other. Then have them present both these drama's in front of the rest of the group. Now decide: who among these people is truly alive, and who is spiritually dead? Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, the people who showed love to others by helping them represented the people who are spiritually alive. Anybody could see that they were alive because they loved each other! It is as if those people have gone through a door or a gate. Those people have left behind death. Now those people are truly alive.

John says something very serious then. Anyone who hates a fellow believer is a murderer! To hate someone is just as bad as to kill someone. There is no difference. If you hate someone, you do not have eternal life. You will not live forever with God; you do not have this perfect quality of life that God gives to his children.

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you have made some flowers that represent eternal life. Plant one of these flowers in this part of the garden. John is warning us that if we do not love our fellow believers, we will not have this eternal life. But when we love each other, then we will have this life. Pause this audio here.

You will remember that in an earlier passage, we said that John liked to use the word "remain." In this passage, John says that someone who does not love "remains" in death. And later, John says that eternal life does not "remain" in that person. To "remain in death" means to be spiritually dead. If "eternal life remains in you," then you keep your good relationship with God, and you keep having the perfect quality of life that God gives to his children.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that someone who does not love others remains in death. Do not spend too much time on this. You will get more opportunities to discuss this later. Pause this audio here.

After the negative example of Cain, who hated his brother, John will explain what it means to truly love each other. We can know what it means to love someone when we look at Jesus. Jesus Christ loved us so much that he gave his life for us. And we should follow Jesus' example.

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you have made some flowers that represent how much God loves us. Plant one of these flowers in this part of the garden. Pause this audio here.

John's listeners might have wondered at this point, "How could we give our lives for other people? We cannot die to take away other people's punishment, as Jesus did. We cannot help people by dying for them!" John helps us understand this by giving us a practical example. A believer who has enough should help a fellow believer who has a need. That may not be the same as dying for a person, but it is a form of giving our lives. Every time that we are doing something for another person, even if it is inconvenient to us, it is as if we are giving our life for this other person.

If someone does not have pity on another believer in need, then God's love does not remain in this person. Notice again the idea that God's love "remains"! John means that if someone does not have pity on another believer in need, then they do not love people in the way that God loves people.

Stop here and do this activity: Take a shawl, hat, or any other thing that people can easily wear. Select one person to act out a believer, and make this person wear this piece of clothing. This piece of clothing represents the way that God loves people. Select another person who is a poor believer. Maybe this person could act out that they are going to church together, or praying together, to show that they are both believers. Then, act out that the poor believer has a need and asks the first believer for some help. Then, act out that the first believer does not have pity on her fellow believer and does not help. As soon as the other members of your group see that this believer does not show love to the poor one, they should grab and take away the shawl or hat that represents the way that God loves people! Pause this audio here.

In this activity, when the believer did not help the other believer in need, the love of God did not remain in this person. This believer did not love the other believer in the way that God wants us to. God loves the people. We should love other people in the same way. But if we do not help each other, then we do not really love each other.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that if we refuse to help a fellow believer, the love of God does not remain in us. Pause this audio here.

John asks his listeners how God's love can remain in someone who does not want to help a fellow believer. John expects his listeners to say that this is impossible. If we truly love each other in the way that God wants us to love, then we help each other. If we do not help each other, then we do not truly love each other.

John finishes this passage by addressing the believers again as his "dear children." John reminds the believers that they should show each other, by their actions, that they love each other. Only then do the believers truly love each other. Or, it can mean that only then do they love each other in the way that God wants them to love each other, in the way that it fits with God's true message.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:11–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one part.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- Cain
- Cain's brother, Abel, though John does not mention Abel's name
- The evil one, who is the devil

- The people who belong to the sinful world
- The believers
- People who hate a fellow believer
- Christ
- God
- A believer who has enough to share but who does not care about others
- And a fellow believer who is in need

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out that John is speaking to the believers.

John says something like this:

"Since the day that you first heard about Jesus, you have heard the message that we should love each other." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- Yes, it is true. John and the other apostles always told us that we should love each other. This is the commandment that Jesus gave us.

Continue the drama. John continues, saying something like this:

"We should not be like Cain, who murdered his brother. Cain belonged to the devil, and not to God. Cain murdered his brother because his brother did the right things, while Cain did the wrong things. My dear brothers and sisters, you should not be surprised if the people who belong to the sinful world hate you. These people hate you because you are doing good, just like Cain hated his brother because his brother did good." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I now understand that I should not be upset that the people who left the church are hating us, or that the other people in our community who are not following Jesus are hating us; or
- I want to continue to do the things that God wants, and not be discouraged because other people hate us.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"But we are not like Cain! We love one another. Therefore, we know that we are no longer spiritually dead. We are truly alive! The people who do not love the other people are actually dead!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I am so glad that the believers are different from these fake believers who have left the church! The believers love each other!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"Everybody who hates a fellow believer is a murderer! And you know that murderers do not have eternal life." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- Oh, this is quite shocking! If I hate a fellow believer, I am as bad as a murderer! or
- I should love my fellow believers. There are some people in our church whom I do not like very much. But I should still love them, because they are my brothers and sisters.

1 John 3:11–18

Continue the drama. John continues, saying something like this:

"This is what it means to love someone: to give your life for someone! This is what Christ has done. Christ gave his life for us. We should do the same thing for other people! If you say that you love someone, but you do not do anything if they need help, even though you could, then you do not love that person at all. This is not the kind of love that God wants. My dear children, we should not just say that we love each other, but we should show it through our actions. Only then do we truly love each other." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- What John says is very important. I know there are some poor people in our church. I have never thought about sharing some of my food with them! I said that I loved those people, but I did not do anything for them; or
- I am so glad that there are people in our church who are helping me when I have a problem. These people really show me that they love me by the things that they do.

Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I will keep telling the people that they have to love each other. This is the most important thing for a believer to do!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:11–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John tells the believers that they should not be like Cain. Cain was from the **evil one**. The evil one is another way to talk about the devil. In an earlier passage, John told the believers that they had defeated the evil one. Use the same word or phrase for "evil one" as you have used there.

The things that Cain did were evil. Evil is the opposite of good. The things that Cain's brother did were righteous. Someone who is righteous is behaving in the way that God wants.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Cain did **evil** things and his brother did **righteous** things. The words evil and righteous are in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Cain murdered his brother. If you murder someone, you kill someone because you want to. This is different from killing someone by accident.

Stop here and discuss how you would say that Cain **murdered** his brother. Pause this audio here.

John addresses the believers as his **brothers**. Believers belong to the family of God. Therefore, all other believers are our brothers and sisters. When John talks about brothers, John is talking about all our fellow believers, both male and female. Use the same word for brothers or "brothers and sisters" as you have used in the previous passages.

John tells the believers that they should not be surprised if the **world** hates the believers. In this case, "the world" means the people who belong to the sinful world. In 1 John 3:1, John said that the world does not know us. Use the same word or phrase for "world" as you have used there.

When we truly love each other, then we have passed from death to **life**. We are no longer spiritually dead, but we are spiritually alive. On the other hand, someone who does not love other people does not have **eternal life**. Life, and eternal life, mean the same thing here. It refers to the perfect quality of life that God gives the believers. Use the same words that you have used for life and eternal life in the previous passages. "Eternal life" is in the Master Glossary.

Jesus "laid down his life for us." Here, life refers to the physical life that every person has. Jesus died in order to save people. Jesus' heart stopped beating. Jesus' breathing stopped. Jesus' body died. John says that Jesus laid down his life. This means that Jesus died voluntarily. Jesus allowed the other people to kill him. John tells us that we also have to lay down our lives for each other. We have to be willing to suffer in order to help our fellow believers.

1 John 3:11–18

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Christ **laid down his life for us**, and that we should lay down our lives for one another. Pause this audio here.

The "love of God does not remain" in someone who does not help a fellow believer in need. John means that if someone does not have pity on another believer in need, then they do not love people in the way that God loves people.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the **love of God does not remain** in this person. Pause this audio here.

John talks about someone who has the means to help a fellow believer, but does not want to. John says the person has "**the world's goods.**" The "world's goods" is a way to talk about money and other material possessions. Many translations use a phrase here like "material possessions" or "wealth." However, John is not talking about people who are rich. John is talking about people who have enough to share, even though they may not be rich. These people are able to help others if they want. However, these people do not have pity on their fellow believers. These people do not care that their fellow believers are in need.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk in your translation about people who do not want to help other believers in need, even though they could. Pause this audio here.

John again calls his listeners "**little children**." John is using this word to show the people that John loves them. "Little child" was an affectionate way to speak to someone, even if that person was not your own child. It could also be that John calls the believers his children because John is their spiritual father. John's listeners have learned about Jesus from John. Use the same word or phrase for "little children" as you have used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 3:11–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (695 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.9 MB)

- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1014 KB)

1 John 3:19–24

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 3:19–24 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:19–24 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:19–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage is directly connected to the previous one. John had just said that we should show the people, and especially our fellow believers, that we love them through the things we do. It is not enough to say that we love other people. We have to actually help these people when they need something, even if this would be inconvenient to us. Now, John says that if we do love other people in this way, then this shows us that we belong to the truth.

To belong to the truth means the same as belonging to God, because God is completely true. Do you remember how we talked in the introduction about a solid, strong bridge as well as a bridge that someone made out of paper? We said you would only use a solid bridge to cross a river. Only that bridge would be a true bridge. The paper bridge would collapse right away. The paper bridge would be fake. We said God is true, just as a solid bridge is true. You can completely trust God, just as you will trust a solid bridge.

John tells us here that when we love each other, then we are also true; we are solid and reliable, like a real bridge, not like a fake one made out of paper!

And because we belong to the truth, we can be confident when we come to God. John probably means that we can be confident that God will listen to us when we pray. If we love our brothers and sisters, we belong to the truth, and we can be sure that God will listen to us when we pray to God.

But we often do not love our brothers and sisters perfectly! We can feel guilty because of this.

Stop here and discuss: Would you like to tell about a time that you were feeling guilty about something? How did this affect your relationship with God? Pause this audio here.

We can feel guilty because we know that we do not obey God's commandments enough. Sometimes it is as if there is a voice inside us that is telling us everything that we have done wrong. But John says that we do not have to listen to this voice. Of course, it is good to listen to this voice if we really have done something wrong. Then we should ask God to forgive us. But we do not have to worry all the time whether we might have done something wrong or not. God knows everything that we have done. We can trust God to judge us.

When we feel guilty, we are afraid to go to God. When we do not feel guilty, John says that we can go to God without fear. Then, when we pray, God will give us what we ask for. God will give us what we ask for because we do everything that God wants. We do the things that make God glad.

Now, stop here and do this activity: God sits on his throne. Act out that people go to pray to God. These people can kneel before God to show that they are praying. Some people are very scared to do this. These people might take a few steps towards God, and then they run away again. Some other people go to God directly. These people are not afraid to pray. These people have confidence that God will listen to them. Pause this audio here.

When we pray, God will listen to us, and God will give us what we ask. God gives us what we ask because we obey God's commands, and we do the things that God wants us to do. Later, John will add to this that God will give us what we ask if we pray the things that God wants.

Stop here and discuss: Can you share about a time that God did something that you asked for? Pause this audio here.

What God commands us to do is this: to trust in God's Son, Jesus Christ, and to love one another. John probably thinks about people like Sam and Sally, who believed the wrong things about Jesus. And because these people believed the wrong things about Jesus, they also stopped loving the fellow believers. But God commands us to believe in his Son, Jesus Christ, who was both human and God.

When we obey God's commands, then we have a good relationship with God; we remain in God, and God remains in us. We know that we remain in God because God has given us the Holy Spirit.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:19–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: John encourages the believers that even if they feel guilty because they might not have loved their fellow believers enough, the believers do not have to be afraid that God will punish them, because what God says about the people is more important than what people think about themselves.

In the second part: John says that we can pray to God with confidence, because we obey God's commandments. The most important commandments that God gave us are that we must believe in Jesus Christ, the Son of God, and that we must love each other.

In this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God should love each other.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus Christ
- People who obey God's commands
- And the Holy Spirit

In this passage, John is still in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God should love each other. But maybe you will notice that John could also be in the part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God obey God's commandments. This is because a very important commandment that God gave us is that we should love each other. John is showing us that obeying God's commandments means that we love each other.

Therefore, stop here and please ask two group members to represent John, and have these people sit in the two parts of your garden where John is. Leave behind an object in each of these parts to show that you have been there, and look at how many times you have been there before. Pause this audio here.

There is not a clear break between this passage and the previous one. In the previous passage, John said how important it was to love each other. If we truly love each other, then we do things for other people even if doing

this is inconvenient or difficult for us. We help people if they have a need. This kind of love is true love. This is the way that God wants us to love each other.

In this passage, John says that if we love each other in this way, then we know that we belong to the truth. John actually just says that "this way we will know that we belong to the truth." But "this way" refers back to what John had said in the previous passage.

To belong to the truth means the same as belonging to God, because God is completely true.

Stop here and discuss how you could say that we know that we belong to the truth, if we love our fellow believers in the way that John spoke about in the previous passage. Do not spend too much time on this, because you will get more opportunities to discuss this later. Pause this audio here.

Because we belong to the truth, to God, we can be confident to come to God. We do not have to be afraid to come to God. In an earlier passage, John also spoke about not being afraid of God. There, John said that we do not have to be afraid of Jesus when he will come back as king. In this passage, John is probably talking especially about prayer. We do not have to be afraid to pray to God. If we love our brothers and sisters, then we can be sure that God will listen to us when we pray to God.

But we can feel guilty because we know that we do not always obey God's commandments. Sometimes our heart condemns us. John means that there is a guilty feeling inside us that tells us that we may have done something wrong. In a court case, a judge is someone who decides whether someone is guilty or not. If a judge decides that someone is guilty, the judge condemns the person. If you condemn someone, you tell that person that they are guilty, and you give them punishment. The guilty feeling inside us is like a judge that is telling us that we are guilty. But God is a much more important judge than this guilty feeling inside us!

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that someone is standing in front of a judge. There are two judges, and one is very small. This judge represents the guilty feeling that we have inside us. This judge will tell the person in front of the judge, "You are guilty and deserve to be punished!" But the other judge is much bigger. The big judge represents God. Act out that the judge who is God tells the smaller judge to be quiet! Maybe the judge who is God can even send the little judge out of the courtroom! Then the judge who is God tells the person that he is not guilty. Pause this audio here.

Now, stop and act out that because the little judge is gone, this person is no longer afraid of God. Act out that this person goes to the judge who is God and prays. Pause this audio here.

John speaks very kindly to the believers. John calls the believers "beloved." John loves the believers, and God loves the believers. The believers do not have to listen to the voice inside them, the little judge that tells the believers that they are guilty. God is the one who says who is guilty or not. John says that we can go to God with confidence, without fear. We can have courage to go to God.

When we feel guilty, we are afraid to go to God. When we do not feel guilty, John says that we can go to God without fear. Then, when we pray, God will give us what we ask for. God will give us what we ask for because we do everything that God wants. We do the things that make God glad.

Then John reminds us what the things are that God wants us to do. John mentions the two most important things. God wants us to believe in the name of God's Son, Jesus Christ. This means we have to believe that Jesus is for sure the Son of God, and we have to trust that Jesus is the Christ, our Saviour. That is the first thing that God wants us to do.

The second thing that God wants us to do is to love one another. This is what Jesus had also told us to do.

Stop here and do this activity: Think of two actions or objects that remind you of these two commands from God. Pause this audio here.

The people who do these things that God wants us to do remain in God, and God remains in these people. Notice again the word "remain," which is a word that John often uses. When we remain in God, this means that we keep having a good relationship with God because we keep doing what God wants. In this passage, John is probably talking about the group of believers together. God remains in the group of believers if they keep loving each other.

1 John 3:19–24

Throughout John's sermon, John often spoke about us remaining in God. This is the first time that John speaks about God remaining in us. If we keep doing what God wants, God will also keep his good relationship with us. Is it not marvelous to think about it, that God wants to have a good relationship with us?

John says that we know that God remains in us, that God keeps his good relationship with us, because God has given us the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is proof that God remains in us.

Stop here, and if you like, do this activity: Make a song, dance, or drama that shows how people who obey God's commands, especially the two commands that John mentioned, keep having a good relationship with God, and that God keeps having a good relationship with them. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage. You could also turn the whole passage into a song, dance, or drama!

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:19–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus Christ
- People who obey God's commands
- And the Holy Spirit

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out that John is speaking to the believers. You may want to begin with the end of the previous passage. John is saying something like this:

"My dear children, we should not just say that we love each other, but we should show it through our actions. Only that is true love." This was the end of the previous passage. Now comes the new passage. "And if we do this—if we show that we love each other through our actions—then we know that we belong to God, who always is true." Pause the drama. Ask the people acting out the believers, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- The people in our church take care of each other and love each other. We belong to God! I am so encouraged; or
- The people who left the church and who told lies about Jesus did not belong to God. I should not listen to those people.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

1 John 3:19–24

"And we do not have to be afraid to come to God, even when we are feeling guilty because we think we have done something wrong. Because God knows everything. And what God thinks about us is more important than what we think about ourselves. Dear friends, God loves you. When you have overcome your guilty feeling, you can pray to God with confidence. And because you obey God's commands and you do the things that make God glad, God will give you whatever you ask." Pause the drama. Ask the person acting out John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I do not want the believers to be worried. I know that the believers really want to obey God, even though they sometimes still sin. I do not want the believers to be afraid of God. God is so kind to us, and he loves us so much!

Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am so glad that John says that we can pray to God with confidence! I should stop thinking about my mistakes. God knows that I do not want to do sin; or
- I am so glad that Jesus died for us, and that we do not have to be afraid of God! I want to do the things that make God glad; or
- I am glad that God will answer our prayers if we obey God.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"And God's command is this: We should believe in Jesus Christ, the Son of God, and we should love each other. This is the same command that Jesus gave us. Everybody who obeys God's commands remains in God, and God remains in them. They keep having a good relationship with God. And we know that God keeps having a good relationship with us, because God has given us the Holy Spirit."

Ask the person acting out John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I have to keep telling the people to love their brothers and sisters, because this is the most important thing!

Ask the people acting out John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- Some people who left our church said that Jesus was not the Son of God. We know now that those people were wrong; or
- I am so glad that I can have a good relationship with God, and that God wants to have a good relationship with me! or
- I know that God has given us the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit helps us to love each other.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 3:19–24 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John addresses his listeners as **little children** or **dear children**. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in previous passages.

John also calls his listeners **beloved**. This means that John loves the people to whom he is writing. It can also mean that God loves the people, or both. Use the same word or phrase for "beloved" as you have used in previous passages.

John says, when "our heart condemns us," we do not have to be afraid because God is greater than our heart. In John's language, a person's heart is the place where a person's thoughts are. When your heart condemns you, that means that you think that you have done something wrong and deserve that God punishes you. You feel guilty. God is greater than our heart. This means that what God thinks is more important than what we think. God is the one who decides whether we are guilty or not.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that **when your heart condemns you, God is greater than your heart**. You can listen to the definition of "heart" in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

1 John 3:19–24

John says that if our heart does not condemn us, we can have confidence before God. If you have confidence, you have courage, and you are not afraid to come to God.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that we can have **confidence** before God. Pause this audio here.

If we obey God's **commandments** and do what makes God glad, then God will give us what we ask him. "God's commandments" means all the good rules or instructions that God has given. Use the same word or phrase for commandment as you have used in previous passages. The word commandment is in the Master Glossary.

God's commandment is that we should believe in the name of God's Son, Jesus **Christ**. Christ means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means that Jesus is the Son of God. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages.

To believe in someone's name is the same thing as to believe in that person. If you believe in someone, you believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that we should **believe** in Jesus Christ, the Son of God, or in the name of Jesus Christ, the Son of God. Use the same word or phrase for believe as you have used in other books of the Bible. The word believe is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

If we obey God's commandments, we **remain** in God, and God remains in us. If you remain in God, this means that you keep having a good relationship with God. You trust God, and you do what God says. Use the same word or phrase for "remain" as you have used in previous passages.

We know that God remains in us because God gave us the Spirit. The Spirit means the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is the Spirit of God.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that God gave us the **Spirit**. Use the same word for Spirit, or Holy Spirit, that you have used in other passages. The word Holy Spirit is in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 3:19–24

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (725 KB)

- Setting the Stage (3.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1021 KB)

1 John 4:1–6

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 4:1–6 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:1–6 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John had said that if we love our fellow believers, we belong to God. We do not have to be afraid to come to God, even if we feel guilty. What God thinks of us is more important than what we think about ourselves. Therefore, we can pray to God with confidence. God will give us what we ask for if we obey God's commands. God's commands are that we believe in Jesus Christ, the Son of God, and that we love each other. If we do these things, then we will keep having a good relationship with God. And we know that we have a good relationship with God because God has given us his Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit tells us that we belong to God.

Now, we have already learned that people like Sam and Sally, people who had left the church, were very much interested in spiritual experiences. And Sam and Sally had probably said that God's Spirit had given them certain messages. These messages may have sounded very important and spiritual. But the believers had to be very careful! The believers should not believe anyone who said they have a spiritual message. Not every message comes from God's Holy Spirit!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who told you something that sounded good, but you were not sure if that thing was true? Maybe someone was trying to sell you something or wanted you to believe something about another person. What did you do to find out whether this person spoke the truth? Pause this audio here.

Just like you have ways to check whether someone is speaking the truth about something, there are ways to know whether a message comes from God or from a lying spirit.

John will tell his listeners how they can know whether a spiritual message is true or not: If people say that they have a message from God, the believers should check what these people believe about Jesus.

Let us go back to thinking about Sam and Sally again. Remember that Sam and Sally do not exist, but we use Sam and Sally as an example of the wrong things that people in the time of John could have been thinking.

1 John 4:1–6

Sam and Sally were interested in the Son of God as a spiritual being. Sam and Sally were not very interested in the Son of God as a human being. Sam and Sally probably did believe that the Son of God became a human being, Jesus, but they did not think that this was important. Sam and Sally did not think that God saved us by sending God's Son to die for us. Sam and Sally thought, "God saved us because we know him, because we know this spiritual Son of God, and we have these special, spiritual experiences." Sam and Sally did not think that sin was a big problem for God. Sam and Sally did not think that the Son of God needed to suffer and die so that God could forgive our sins.

Whenever Sam and Sally were teaching other people, they only spoke about the Son of God as a spiritual being. Sam and Sally never said that the Son of God suffered and died for the sins of the people. John says these people did not "confess" that Jesus Christ had come in the flesh. If you confess something, you are openly saying that you believe something is true.

People who do not confess that Jesus Christ has become a human being who suffered and died are teaching the wrong things about Jesus. And John tells his listeners that if someone says they have a spiritual message from God, but they are teaching the wrong things about Jesus, then they are lying! This person's message did not come from God. Instead, this person's message comes from the antichrist, the enemy of God!

People who do not say that Jesus Christ, the Son of God, has become a real human of flesh and blood are false prophets. A prophet is someone who gives messages from God to the people. But John says that there are many false prophets. These people pretend to speak on God's behalf, but they are lying. These people's messages do not come from God, but from the antichrist, the enemy of Jesus. These false prophets are the same people as the fake believers, people like Sam and Sally.

But John encourages the believers. The believers have not listened to these false prophets! The believers have not believed the wrong teaching.

John says that the believers have overcome these false prophets. Earlier, John had said that the "young people" had overcome the evil one. These people had not listened to the false teaching, and they had not sinned. The false prophets, the antichrist, and the fake believers all refer to the same people who are telling lies about Jesus. These people all belong to the sinful world and to the evil one. The believers have overcome the false prophets because the believers did not believe the messages that these false prophets gave them.

The reason why the believers could overcome the false prophets, why they did not believe people like Sam and Sally, is because the believers belong to God. And God helped the believers. God is so much more powerful than the antichrist, or than the evil one, the leader of the sinful world!

The fake believers belong to the sinful world. They say things that people who belong to the sinful world like to hear. That is why people who belong to the world listen to these people and believe what they say.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about some things in your community that people who do not belong to God like to hear? Pause this audio here.

But John and the other believers belong to God. People who know God recognise that what John and the other believers are saying is true, and that this comes from God. John probably refers especially to what John and the other believers are saying about Jesus. People who know God will listen to John. People who do not belong to God will not listen to John and to the other believers.

And so this is another way we can know whether a message that someone gives comes from the Holy Spirit, who always speaks the truth, or whether this message comes from a lying spirit. If people do not listen to John and do not believe that the things that John and the other believers have said about Jesus Christ are true, then whatever message these people give will be false.

And so, in this passage, John showed the believers two ways that would help them to know whether someone was giving the right teaching or not. If the people who gave the teaching did not also say that Jesus Christ had truly been a human, then their teaching would not be true. And if the people gave a teaching that was different from the teaching that John and the other believers had given about Jesus Christ, their teaching was also wrong.

1 John 4:1–6

Stop here and discuss: John is responding to wrong teachings in John's own time. In every time, there can be different wrong teachings. What do you think that John might say about some wrong teaching that is happening in your time?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: John tells the believers that they should not just believe anyone who claims to have had a spiritual message. John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

In the second part: John encourages the believers that they belong to God. John is in the part of the garden where John tells us that children of God have overcome the evil world.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- The Holy Spirit
- Other spirits that do not come from God
- False prophets
- Jesus
- God
- The spirit of the antichrist
- People who belong to God
- The one who is in the world, which refers to the devil
- And people who belong to the world, who are the same as the false prophets

John ended the previous passage by talking about the Holy Spirit. In this passage, John will speak about the Holy Spirit and about lying spirits.

In the first part of this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

Stop here, and please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Leave behind an object for later so that you can see that you have been there. Pause this audio here.

There are many spirits that can give messages to people. The Holy Spirit can give a message from God to the people, but there are also spirits that are evil. These spirits give messages to the people that are false.

John speaks lovingly to the believers. John calls the believers "beloved." John encourages the believers that they should not believe everyone who says they have a message from the Holy Spirit. The believers should test whether the message comes from the Holy Spirit or comes from a lying spirit. This is very important because there are many false prophets, people who pretend to give messages from God, but who do not.

The spirits themselves do not speak in a way that we can hear. The spirits speak through people. John means that the believers should not believe people who give messages from spirits that do not come from God. Or it could mean that the people who give the messages are lying when they say that the messages come from God.

Stop here and discuss: In your language, how would you say that people should not believe every spirit? Do not spend too much time on this. You will get more opportunities to discuss this later. Pause this audio here.

Only the spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ came in the flesh can give a message that comes from God. Someone who confesses that Jesus Christ came in the flesh believes and openly says that Jesus Christ, the Son

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of God, became a human being. The flesh refers to our physical bodies. John means to say that Jesus Christ got a physical body, exactly like a human being. And so, the Son of God became a human being.

If the person who gives a message does not also say that Jesus Christ was a real human, then this person's message is false, and the believers should not listen to this person.

Stop here and discuss: In your language, how could you say that Jesus Christ came in the flesh? You will get more opportunities to discuss this later as well. Pause this audio here.

John says the same thing twice, once in a positive way and once in a negative way. Every spirit that believes and openly says that Jesus Christ became a real human being comes from God. This is the positive way. Every spirit that does not believe and says that Jesus Christ became a real human being does not come from God. This is the negative way to say the same thing. John often likes to say the same thing twice, in different ways.

A person who does not say that Jesus Christ was a real human being does not give us messages that come from the Holy Spirit. This person's messages come from the spirit of the antichrist! You will remember that the antichrist can be a name for a certain enemy of Jesus Christ who will come near the end before Jesus comes back to judge the world. To say that a message comes from the "spirit of the antichrist" means that this message is the same as the message that the antichrist will bring.

The believers knew that the antichrist would come. John tells the believers that the same spirit who will cause the antichrist to teach false teachings has indeed come. The spirit of this antichrist is already busy, going around and trying to make people believe lies about Jesus. The fake believers give messages that come from the spirit of the antichrist.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that someone is preaching and at the same time saying that Jesus was not a real human being. Act out that the people who are listening to the preaching get up and leave because they know that the preacher is not giving a message from God! Pause this audio here.

Stop here. John now moves to the part of the garden where John says that the children of God have overcome the evil world. Ask the person who represents John to move to this part of the garden. Leave behind an object for later. Pause this audio here.

The believers have not believed what the fake believers told them! The people who tried to deceive the believers have lost. The believers have conquered these people! The believers did not conquer the fake believers by having a physical fight, but by not listening to them. The believers may still be struggling, and some might not be quite sure, but John is confident that in the end, the believers will believe the right thing. So John tells the believers that they have already won.

The believers could overcome the fake believers because the believers belong to God. John says that God is in the believers. The power of God works in the life of the believers. The Holy Spirit helps the believers.

John says that the one who is in us—God, or the Holy Spirit—is more powerful than the one who is in the world. The one who is in the world is the devil, the evil one. John could also mean that the Holy Spirit is stronger than the spirit of the antichrist. But the antichrist belongs to the evil one, so the meaning would be the same either way. God is more powerful than Satan, and God's Spirit is more powerful than the spirit of the antichrist!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a fight between a very strong person and a very weak person, or between a very big animal and a very small animal? What happened? Pause this audio here.

A strong person, or a big animal, will very easily win over a weak or small person or animal. God is much, much bigger and stronger and more powerful than Satan! And so, the believers do not have to be afraid.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that some fake believers are trying to deceive the believers. Think of something you can do to show that God is helping the believers. Maybe one of you can stand behind the believers with arms wide out. Also, think of something you can do to show that Satan is helping the fake believers. Maybe someone can pretend to be Satan and stand behind the fake believers. Think of a way that you can show that God is much stronger and more powerful than Satan. Act out that the fake believers are trying to make the believers believe lies about Jesus. As the fake believers are trying to do this, act out that God helps the believers. Because of that, the believers do not listen to the fake believers, and they do not believe what the fake believers are saying. Pause this audio here.

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John then continues talking about the fake believers. The fake believers belong to the world. John means that the fake believers belong to the sinful world, the world where Satan rules. And so everything that the fake believers say comes from Satan. But John says that we are from God. John is talking about himself and the other believers who are teaching the right things.

Then John uses another positive-negative pair: People who know God listen to John and the other believers. People who are not from God do not listen to John and the other believers.

A person who knows God has a close relationship with God. This is the same as "being in God." We see again that John often likes to say the same thing twice, but using different words.

John finishes this section by saying that this is how we know whether a message is true or false. John has mentioned two things in this passage, and John here refers back to both of these things. If the people who give the message do not believe the right things about Jesus, then we know that their message is false. And if the people teach things that are different from the things that John and the other believers had taught, then also we know that their message is false.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage. Because we have done a lot of activities in this step, you might like to listen once more to the passage first.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- The Holy Spirit
- Other spirits that do not come from God
- False prophets
- Jesus
- God
- The spirit of the antichrist
- People who belong to God
- The one who is in the world, which refers to the devil
- And people who belong to the world, who are the same as the false prophets

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John says something like this:

"Dear friends, do not believe everyone who says they have a message from the Holy Spirit. You have to test whether this message really comes from God. There are many people who say that they have messages from God,

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and these people go around and tell everybody their messages. But many of these messages are false." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- Yes, so many people say that they have special messages from God. It is difficult to know who speaks the truth. I am glad that John is helping us.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"I will tell you how you can know whether a message comes from the Holy Spirit or not. If someone believes and openly says that Jesus Christ became a human being, then their message is from God. But if someone does not say that Jesus Christ has become a human being, then their message is not from God. That person's message does not come from the Holy Spirit, but from the antichrist. You had heard that the antichrist would come, and he is indeed already active in the world." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am glad that I am learning how to know whether a message is true or not; or
- I know now that it is really important to believe that Jesus really is both God and human!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"Dear children, you belong to God, and you have defeated the people who give false messages by not believing them. This was possible because God is in you, and God is much more powerful than the evil one, who rules the sinful world." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am so glad that the believers are not listening to these false messages! I know that God will help the believers to keep believing the right thing; or

Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- The people who give these false messages seem so powerful! I used to be so impressed by them because of all the spiritual experiences they said they had. But now I believe that they were lying. I am glad that God is helping us! God is much stronger than they are!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"The people who give the false messages belong to the sinful world. And everything those people say belongs to the sinful world. That is why the people in the world listen to those people and believe what they say. But we belong to God. The people who know God listen to us and believe what we say. The people who do not belong to God do not listen to us.

"So, these things are how we can recognise whether a spiritual message is true or false, whether a message really comes from the Holy Spirit or is fake." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- The people who give these false messages do not listen to me. These people do not accept that Jesus gave me authority and that I speak the truth. This shows that these people do not belong to God.

Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I do not want to belong to the sinful world. I am so glad that I belong to God! or
- I am glad that John has helped us to know whether a spiritual message is true or not.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John calls his listeners **beloved**. This means that John loves the people to whom he is writing. It can also mean that God loves the people, or both. John means that his listeners are John's dear friends. John speaks very kindly to his listeners. Use the same word or phrase for beloved as you have used in previous passages.

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At the end of the previous passage, John mentioned the Spirit. John meant the Holy Spirit.

John almost never uses the phrase “the Holy Spirit.” In this passage, John calls the Holy Spirit the “Spirit of God.”

Stop here and discuss how you will say the **Spirit of God**. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in previous passages. The word “Holy Spirit” is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

The people should not believe every spirit. This means that the people should not believe everyone who says they have a message from the Holy Spirit. In this passage, John uses the word for spirit to refer to either evil spirits that try to lie to people or to the Holy Spirit who gives true messages from God. In this case, John says that people need to test the spirit’s message to know if it is from the Holy Spirit or from an evil spirit.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that people should not believe every **spirit**. You should use a general term for spirit because the believers do not know yet if these spirits are the Holy Spirit from God or if these are evil spirits who try to deceive people. Pause this audio here.

John says that many false prophets have gone out into the world. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. A false prophet is someone who pretends to give messages from God, but these messages are false.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate “**false prophets**.” The word prophet is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages. Pause this audio here.

John says that many false prophets have gone out into the world. This time, when John talks about the world, John just means the general world around us. John does not mean specifically the sinful world. John means that false prophets went around and shared their false messages with many people.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that many false prophets have gone out into **the world**. Pause this audio here.

Jesus Christ has come in the flesh. **Christ** means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means especially to say that Jesus is the Son of God. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages.

That Jesus Christ has come in the “flesh” means that Jesus was born as a human being, with a body just like us, with real bones and muscles and blood! Jesus always existed as the Son of God, but he became a human being inside the womb of a virgin, Mary.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Jesus Christ has come in the **flesh**. Flesh is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

A spirit that **confesses** that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God. This means that if someone confesses that Jesus Christ was born as a human being, their message comes from the Holy Spirit. If you confess something, you are openly saying that you believe something is true. Use the same word for confess as you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss how you will speak about how a spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God. Pause this audio here.

If someone does not confess that Jesus Christ has come as a human being, then the messages from this person do not come from the Holy Spirit of God, but from the spirit of the **antichrist**. An antichrist is an enemy of Jesus. Use the same word or phrase for antichrist as you have used in previous passages.

The antichrist is already in the **world**. Here, John again just means the general world all around us.

John addresses his listeners as “**little children**” or dear children. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in previous passages.

The believers belong to God and have **conquered** the people who gave messages that came from the antichrist. If you conquer someone, you have fought with someone and have won. The other people have lost and can no longer harm you. John does not mean that the believers had a physical fight with these people. The believers have conquered the people who gave false messages by not believing the messages.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that the believers have conquered the people who gave false messages. Pause this audio here.

The one who is in the believers is greater, or stronger and more powerful, than the one who is in the world. This time, when John talks about the world, John means the sinful world, the world where the devil still has power. The one who is in the believers refers to God, or to the Holy Spirit. The one who is in the world can mean Satan, or it could mean the antichrist.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the one who is in you is greater than the one who is in the world. Pause this audio here.

The people who give false messages belong to the **world**. The word "world" here again means the sinful world.

In this passage, John teaches the people how they could know the "Spirit of truth" and the "spirit of error," or lies. This means that people can know whether a message truly comes from the Holy Spirit, which is the same as the "Spirit of truth." If a message does not come from the Holy Spirit, then it comes from an evil spirit that gives a false message that is meant to deceive people.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that people can know the **Spirit of truth** and the **spirit of error**, or lies.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 4:1–6

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (682 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1014 KB)

1 John 4:7–12

1 John 4:7–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 4:7–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:7–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John talked about how people could recognise whether a spiritual message someone gave really had come from God. The believers should only trust a message if the people who gave these messages said that Jesus Christ really had become a human being.

In this passage, John will talk again about how important it is that the believers love each other. Maybe John knew that if the people would start to listen to each other's messages critically, they might forget to love each other!

John had already said that we can recognise a true believer by whether that person loves the other believers or not. Now, John tells us why it is so important that we love each other: because God loves us!

John tells us that God is love. This means that God loves us perfectly and completely. Just as water is always wet and fire is always hot, like that, God always loves the people. It would be impossible for God not to love the people! Everything that God does, God does because he loves the people.

God also loves animals, and plants, and everything else that God created, but John is talking here specifically about God's love for people.

And God is the source of all love. God created people and made it possible for people to love each other. Remember that we are not talking about romantic love, as between a man and a woman, but about the way that all people should love each other.

Stop here and do this activity: Go outside or to a place where it does not matter if you spill water. Fill a bowl with water. One person will take the bowl and pour water from the bowl into some of the other people's hands. These people will then pour the water in their hands into the hands of some other people. Pause this audio here.

When you were doing this activity, people's hands got wet, and this all came from the water in the same bowl. Like that, everything that we do or say that shows that we love other people comes from God. God loves us, and because God loves us, we can love other people.

If we love each other, then this shows people that we are children of God. Children often look or act like their parents. Children may have the same posture or the same skills as their parents. We all have at different times met someone and thought, "Wow, she is exactly like her father, or like her mother!"

Well, God is our father, and God loves everybody perfectly. So whenever you show love to another believer, this shows that you are a child of God, because you are behaving like God, your Father!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a time that you met someone who behaved in the same way as one of their parents? Pause this audio here.

1 John 4:7–12

If we do not love other people, we do not know God. God wants us to love each other. If we really know God, then we will do the things that God wants us to do.

Let us say that there are two people who both say that they are your friend and that they know you very well. Well, one day these people both come to visit you. And both of them bring you some food. One of these people brings food that you really like. But the other person brings food that you do not like at all, and that, in fact, makes you sick! This person might say that he is your friend, but he does not really know you. The first person showed you that he is your friend, because he knows what you like and do not like.

Like that, if we love other people, we are showing everybody that we really know God, because we do what God wants. And the most important thing that God wants us to do is to love other people!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who did something for you that showed that this person really knows you? Pause this audio here.

We know that God loves people perfectly because God sent his only Son, Jesus, to this world! The Old Testament has taught us that when we sin, this breaks the good relationship we have with God. God is holy and hates sin. Someone who sins deserves to die. God had made a law for the people that if they sinned and wanted to ask God for forgiveness, they could kill an animal and offer this to God as a sacrifice. The animal then died in place of the person. God could then forgive the person, and the person could have a good relationship with God again. In difficult language, we say that the animal that died “atoned” for the sin of the person. To atone means to restore a relationship.

Stop here and discuss: In your community, what do people do to restore a broken relationship with each other? Pause this audio here.

So, because people who sinned made an animal sacrifice, God could forgive the people, and the people and God could again have a good relationship with each other. But the effect of such a sacrifice did not last very long. Because people always sin again, people would have to keep sacrificing animals again and again. God, therefore, sent Jesus to this world. Jesus died in our place. And the effect of this sacrifice is forever! If we trust in Jesus, we can have a good relationship with God forever.

John says that Jesus was the atoning sacrifice. John said the same thing in an earlier passage. It means that Jesus became the sacrifice that restored the broken relationship between the holy God and sinful people.

John is showing the believers here how important it is to believe that the Son of God really became a human being. People like Sam and Sally were only interested in the Son of God as a spiritual being. These people did not think that it was important that the Son of God became a human being. But John shows us that it is absolutely important, because God showed us how much he loves us by sending his Son to save us! God’s Son became a human being so that he could die in our place. Sam and Sally were really wrong to think that it was not important that Jesus was a real human being! Because this is the way that God saved us.

And God did not save us because we loved God! We actually did not love God at all, at first! But God still loved us. And because God loved us and saved us, then we began to love God.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a person who did not love you, but that you still loved? Or maybe an animal? What happened? Pause this audio here.

Well, if God loved us so much that he died for us, then of course we should love each other too. Because Jesus also died for the other people! It would be very strange if we did not love someone else that Jesus died for! If Jesus loves this other person, so should we. And when we will love each other, then God will live in us.

Stop here and discuss: What would your church look like if everybody loved each other? After that, pray together that God will help you to love each other, just as Jesus loves all of you!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 John 4:7–12

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one part.

In this part: John says that we should love each other. The reason why we should love each other is because God loves us.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus
- The believers who love one another
- And people who do not love one another

In this passage, John is again in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God should love each other. But at the same time, we could also say that John is in the part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

Stop here and please ask two of your group members to be John. Let these people stand or sit in the part of your room that represents these parts of the garden. Do not forget to leave behind an object to show that you have been there. Take a look at how many times you have already been there earlier! Pause this audio here.

John begins and ends this passage by calling his listeners "beloved." This is a very appropriate thing to say in a passage where John is talking about love!

John tells the believers, "Let us love one another!" John includes himself here. All the believers, and John as well, have to love each other.

The reason why we should love each other is that love comes from God. This means that God is the one who makes it possible for people to love each other. Every time that we show love to other people, we do this because God makes this possible.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that we should love each other because love is from God. Pause this audio here.

John says that a person who loves other people is born of God. This means this person is a child of God. John uses one of his positive-negative pairs here again. John says, "Everyone who loves other people is a child of God and knows God." That is the positive way to say it. Then John says the same thing in a negative way: "Whoever does not love other people, does not know God!" The meaning is the same. You are only a child of God if you love other people. You only truly know God if you love other people.

If we do not love other people, we do not know God. God is love! Everything that God does, he does because God loves people. And of course, God loves the rest of his creation as well. If we really know God, then we will do the things that God wants us to do.

God showed us how much he loves us by sending Jesus, God's one and only Son, into the world. John says that God revealed how much he loves us by sending his only Son. When you reveal something, you show people something that they did not know before. We did not know how much God loved us until God sent us Jesus.

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you have made some flowers that represent how much God loves us. Place one of these flowers in the part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God should love each other. Pause this audio here.

God sent his Son so that we can live! God sent his Son into the world, and God's Son became a human being. We can live because of what God's Son, Jesus, did for us. Jesus died in our place, and because of that, we can live! And remember, this is what people like Sam and Sally did not believe.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that God revealed to us how much God loves us by sending his one and only Son into the world so that we can live. Pause this audio here.

1 John 4:7–12

John then tells us something else that is special about the way that God loves us. God does not love us because we loved God first. It is the other way around. God loved us, and then we began to love God! People do so many wrong things that God hates, and so it is very surprising to hear that God loved us even before we changed our behaviour and began to do the things that God wants us to do!

Instead of punishing us for the bad things we have done, God showed us how much he loves us by sending God's Son to die in our place. John says that Jesus was the atoning sacrifice. John said the same thing in an earlier passage. It means that Jesus became the sacrifice that restored the broken relationship between the holy God and sinful people. To atone means to restore a relationship.

Because Jesus died, God could forgive our sins!

Because God has loved us so much, we should also love each other.

When people start loving each other, something special will happen. It is as if people suddenly can see God! God is a spirit, and no one has ever seen God. But when you show people that you love them, you are behaving like God. And when other people then look at you, it is as if they are looking at God! John says that if we love each other, God will live in us. John probably means that God's spirit will live in the group of believers together. When the people love each other, then God will be very happy to live in their midst.

John says that when we love each other, God will live in us, and God's love will become perfect in us. In 1 John 2:5, John said almost the same thing, and we used an example of a fruit tree. We said, imagine that you plant a fruit tree and you work very hard to help the tree to grow. When the tree gives fruit, all the work you have done for the tree has become worth it. John would say that the work you did for the tree has become perfect because the tree does what you want it to do. In the same way, when we love each other, God's work of loving us has become perfect. We are doing what God wants us to do.

When John said almost the same thing in 1 John 2:5, John said that the person who obeys God's word, in this person, the love of God has become perfect. In this passage, John says that when we love each other, God's love has become perfect. This shows that for John, to obey God and to love each other really are the same thing. The most important thing we can do to obey God is to love each other.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that God loved the people, but people did not love God. Act out that God sent his Son, Jesus, to die for the people. Act out that people then begin to love God. Act out that the relationship between God and people is restored. Act out that the believers then also begin to love each other. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one part.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus
- The believers who love one another
- And believers who do not love one another

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John is saying something like this:

"Dear friends, let us love one another! The reason we should love each other is that God loves us, and it is God who makes us love each other. If you love each other, you are children of God, and you show that you know God. God loves everybody completely and wants us to love each other. If you do not love each other, this shows that you do not know God at all!" Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I know that I keep saying this over and over again, but it really is the most important thing for believers to do, to love each other!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"God showed us how much he loves us by sending his one and only Son to this world. And because of God's Son, Jesus, we can be truly alive! We can see how much God loves us because he loved us before we even loved him! God sent his Son to the world to die in our place, so that God would forgive us for everything we had done wrong, and we could have a good relationship with God." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am feeling so glad! It is incredible that God loves us so much! or
- I am so glad that God has sent Jesus to save us! The Son of God really became a human being. It is amazing that God loves us so much that he sent his Son to us!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"Dear friends, because God loved us so much, we should love each other too! No person has ever seen God, but if we love our fellow brothers and sisters, then God lives in us! And when we love each other, God's love has become perfect in us." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am excited that God lives in us! When other people look at us, it will be as if they are looking at God! or
- I know that I do not always love my fellow believers. But I want God's love to become perfect in me. I am going to do better.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:7–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John calls his listeners **beloved**. This means that John loves the people to whom John is writing. It can also mean that God loves the people, or both. John means that his listeners are John's dear friends. Use the same word or phrase for "beloved" as you have used in previous passages.

Everyone who loves is **born of God**. This means that people who love are children of God. John is talking here about believers who love the other believers. Use the same word or phrase for "born of God" that you have used in previous passages.

John tells us that God is love. This means that God loves perfectly and completely. Just as water is always wet and fire is always hot, like that, God always loves the people. It would be impossible for God not to love the people! Everything that God does, God does because he loves the people, and the rest of his creation as well.

1 John 4:7–12

Stop here and discuss how you can say that **God is love**. Pause this audio here.

God sent his only Son into the world. God's only Son is Jesus. The phrase "only Son" means a very special son. God sent his Son into the world. That means that God sent Jesus to earth to be born as a human being.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that God sent his **only Son** into the **world**. If you want, you can listen to the explanation of "Son of God" again in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for God's only Son as you have used in other books you have translated. Pause this audio here.

God sent his son to be the **atoning sacrifice** for our **sins**. An atoning sacrifice is a sacrifice that restores the relationship between God and people. Jesus died in our place. Therefore, God could forgive us. And the relationship between God and people could be restored. The words sin, sacrifice, and atonement are in the Master Glossary. Use the same words for sin, sacrifice, and atonement as you have used in other passages.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that God sent his son to be the atoning sacrifice for our sins. Pause this audio here.

If we love one another, God will live in us. Then God's love will become perfect in us.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that **God's love has become perfect** in us or that we love God perfectly. Use the same word or phrase for God's love becoming perfect in us as you have used in the earlier passage.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 4:7–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (686 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (999 KB)

1 John 4:13–21

1 John 4:13–21

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 4:13–21 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:13–21 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

John has just said that we should love each other because God loves us. John now repeats something he had said earlier. John says that we can know that we remain in God, and that God remains in us, because God has given us his Spirit. The fact that we have the Holy Spirit is proof that we remain in God and that God remains in us. If you remain in God, this means that you continuously keep your good relationship with God. And when God remains in us, God keeps his good relationship with us.

John then says that we have seen that the Father sent his Son. John and the other apostles have seen Jesus with their own eyes. John is probably again thinking about people like Sam and Sally. Sam and Sally did not think that it was important that the Son of God had become a human being. But John knows that it is very important. John has seen Jesus! John has seen Jesus and knows for sure that Jesus is both human and God. John has spent a lot of time with Jesus and has seen Jesus do many miracles. John was with Jesus when God spoke from heaven and said about Jesus, “This is my Son, and you should listen to him!” This happened when John and two other disciples were with Jesus on a mountain, and they suddenly could see Jesus as he really was.

Stop here, and if you like, listen to your own translation of Luke 9:28–36 to hear this story. Pause this audio here.

John has seen Jesus die on the cross. But John also has seen Jesus after he, Jesus, became alive again! And so, John knows for sure that God sent Jesus to be the saviour of the world. John has seen it himself. Therefore, John can tell other people that this is true.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about something that you knew was true because someone else that you trusted had seen it for themselves? Pause this audio here.

John says that the people who believe and openly say that indeed Jesus is the Son of God, these people have a deep relationship with God. God remains in these people, and these people remain in God. Only these people who believe the right things about Jesus really understand how much God loves us. No matter how much people like Sam and Sally might say that they know God, they do not really know God at all! Because these people do not believe the right things about Jesus.

John then repeats that God is love. In the previous passage, we explained that, just as water is always wet and fire is always hot, like that, God always loves us. It is impossible for water not to be wet. Like that, it is impossible for God not to love us!

Because God loves us and we love God, we do not have to be afraid of God. One day, Jesus will come back and will judge everybody for the wrong they have done. But we do not have to be afraid of that day.

We do not have to be afraid that God will judge us, because God will treat us in the same way as God treats Jesus! Jesus has never done anything wrong, and so Jesus does not deserve that God punishes him. We, of course, do

deserve that God punishes us. But when the time comes for God to judge all the people, it will be as if we have not done any sin. That is because God loves us so much! Because God loves us, God has sent Jesus to die in our place. Jesus has taken away the bad things we have done, and therefore, God will not punish us. If we fully understand how much God loves us, then we will not be afraid of God!

John adds to this that if we are afraid of God, we do not really love God! Or, it might mean that when we are afraid of God, we do not understand how much God loves us. It is not possible to be afraid of someone that you love and that you know loves you. You cannot run away from someone in fear and at the same time run towards that same person in love.

Stop here and do this activity: Stand in a row in the middle of your space. Every first person will stand with their face in one direction, and every second person will stand with their face to the other direction. Hook your arms together. When someone gives a signal, everyone will start running forward in the direction that they are facing. See what happens! Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, you found out that, as a group, you could not run in both directions at the same time. Like this, if you run away from God because you are afraid of God, then you cannot at the same time go to God and love him. But if you will run towards God because you love God, then you will forget about your fear!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who was afraid of God? Why was this person afraid of God, and what happened? Pause this audio here.

John repeats what he has said earlier, that we love God because God loved us first. Then, if someone loves God, this person will also love their fellow believers. You cannot say that you love God, but hate a fellow believer. If you hate a fellow believer, then you do not really love God. We can see our fellow believers because they are near to us. It is easier to love someone who is near and you can see than to love someone you cannot see. We do not truly love God, whom we cannot see, if we do not also love our fellow believers, whom we can see! You would be lying if you then said you loved God!

Stop here and play this game: Take a light object like a small stick, balloon, flower, or something else and go outside, or find a large space. Take three people and make them stand in a line. The first two people should stand rather close together, but the third person should stand far away.

Now, let the first person throw the object to the second person, the one in the middle. If that person is able to catch the object, the first person can try to throw the same object to the third person, the one who is far away. But if the person in the middle cannot catch the object, the first person will sit down, and someone else will take their place. The next person will try the same thing. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss what you think this activity has to do with what John is saying. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, the person who stood far away represented God, and the person in the middle represented a fellow believer. In the game, if a person was not able to throw the object correctly to the person in the middle, that person was out of the game. If that person could not even throw correctly to the person in the middle, who was nearby, they would never be able to throw the object correctly to the person who was far away. In the same way, John says that if we do not love a fellow believer, we do not really love God either.

In this passage, John showed that believing the right things about Jesus and loving each other belong together. If we believe the right things about Jesus, then we understand how much God loves us. And when we understand how much God loves this, then we will also love each other!

Stop here and do this activity: Sing a song about how much God loves us!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

1 John 4:13–21

In the first part: John says that if we have the Holy Spirit, this is proof that we remain in God. God remains in the people who believe that Jesus is the Son of God. John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

In the second part: John says that God loves people completely and perfectly. We should not be afraid of God. And because we love God, we should also love our fellow believers. John is in the part of the garden where John tells us the children of God love each other.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus
- Holy Spirit
- The believers who love one another
- And people who say that they are believers, but who do not love the other believers

In the beginning of the passage, John is in the part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

Stop here, and please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Leave behind an object for later so that you can see that you have been there. How many times have you already been in this part of the garden? Pause this audio here.

In the first part of this passage, John encourages the believers that they belong to God. John says that "we," meaning John and his listeners, can be sure that we belong to God because God has given us his Spirit.

John says that we have seen that God the Father had sent Jesus to be the Saviour of the world. This time, "we" probably means John and the other apostles who had met Jesus when Jesus was still on earth. John has seen Jesus himself. Therefore, John knows that Jesus is both human and God. John knows for sure that God sent Jesus to be the Saviour of the world. Therefore, John can tell other people that this is true.

God will remain in the people who believe that Jesus is the Son of God, and these people will remain in God. And so, the people who believe the right things about Jesus will have a wonderful, deep relationship with God. And only if we believe the right things about Jesus can we really understand how much God loves us.

Stop here and act out that God gave us his Spirit. Act out that because we have God's Spirit, we know that we have a good relationship with God. Act out that John and some others tell the people that God has sent his Son to be the Saviour of all the people in the world. Act out that God and the people who believe this have a good relationship with each other. Be creative in how you can show all this! You could also dance it or sing it. Pause this audio here.

In the second part of the passage, John moves to the part of the garden where John says that the children of God love each other.

Stop and ask the person who represents John to now move to the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Leave behind an object for later. See how many times you have already been there! Pause this audio here.

John says that we know how much God loves us. This time, "we" means John and his listeners together. John and the other believers know how much God loves them. And they believe that God loves them and trust completely that God loves them.

God is love. Everything that God does is because God loves us.

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you made some flowers that represent how much God loves us. Plant the last one of these flowers in this part of the garden. Pause this audio here.

People who "remain in love" remain in God. To remain in love can mean many things. It can mean that we keep loving God. It can mean that we keep loving other people. And it can mean that we keep doing the things that

God loves. John might well mean all three of these things, because they are all connected with each other. When we keep loving God and each other, then God will remain in us.

Stop here and think of a drama, game, or activity that you could do to explain to some other believers that a person who remains in love remains in God. Pause this audio here.

John says that God's love has become perfect in us when we are no longer afraid that God will punish us. This can mean that when we love God perfectly, we are no longer afraid of God, or it can mean that when we are no longer afraid of God, God's work of loving us has become perfect. It could also mean that we perfectly understand how much God loves us when we realise how much God has done for us. Maybe it means all of these things at the same time!

John has talked before about God's love that has become perfect in us. In 1 John 2:5, John said that when we obey God's commandments, God's love has become perfect in us. And in 1 John 4:12, John said that when we love each other, God's love has become perfect in us. This showed us that obeying God's commandments and loving each other really are the same thing. This time, John says that when we are no longer afraid that God will punish us, God's love has become perfect in us.

Earlier, we gave the example of a fruit tree. We imagined that you did a lot of work to take care of the tree. When the tree began to bear fruit, all the work that you had done for the tree was worth the trouble. John would say that the work you have done for the tree has become perfect because the tree now bears fruit. In the same way, the love that God has for us has become perfect when we are no longer afraid of God. We are doing what God wants. We are no longer afraid of God!

We do not have to be afraid of God because God will treat us as he treats Jesus! When the time comes for God to judge all the people, it will be as if we have not done any sin. This is because God loves us so much that God has sent Jesus to die in our place. Jesus has taken away the bad things we have done, and therefore, God will not punish us. If we really understand how much God loves us, then we will not be afraid of God!

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that God treats us like Jesus on the day that he will judge all the people. Pause this audio here.

John continues by saying that if we love God, we should also love our fellow believers. If you do not love your fellow believers, you cannot really love God. We can see our fellow believers because they are near us. It is easier to love someone who is near and that you can see than to love someone you cannot see. We do not truly love God, whom we cannot see, if we do not also love our fellow believers, whom we can see! You would be lying if you then said you loved God!

John finishes by saying that Jesus had given us this commandment to love our brothers and sisters. To love God and to love our fellow believers belong together.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that God loves us. Act out that we then love God. Act out that Jesus tells us that if we love God, we must also love our fellow believers. Act out that because we love God, we will also love our fellow believers. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus

- Holy Spirit
- The believers who love one another
- And people who say that they are believers, but who do not love the other believers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John says something like this:

"We can be sure that we remain in God, and that God remains in us. We can be sure of this because God gave us his Spirit. And we—I and the others who were with Jesus—have seen ourselves, and can tell you that it is really true, that God the Father has sent his Son to save the people of the world! God remains in the people who believe this and who fully agree that indeed Jesus is the Son of God. And these people remain in God." Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I know that God has given us his Spirit. Because of that, I know that we have a good relationship with God! or
- We can trust John. John has seen Jesus! I know that everything that John tells us about Jesus is true; or
- I absolutely believe that Jesus is the Son of God! I am so glad that God remains in us.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"And we know now how much God loves us, and we really trust that God loves us. Everything that God does, God does because he loves us completely. If you keep loving God and other people, then God will remain in you." Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am so excited that God remains in us and that we can have a good relationship with God! I am excited that God gave us the Holy Spirit; or
- I am so glad that God loves us so much that he gave us his Son!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"God's love has become perfect in us if we are no longer afraid that God will punish us on the day that God will come to judge the world. We do not have to be afraid, because on that day God will treat us the same way as he treats Jesus! If we love God perfectly, then all our fear will go away! If you are still afraid, that means you are worried about punishment. And that means that you do not understand perfectly how much God loves you." Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am so encouraged. I have always been afraid that God will punish me, because I know I have done many wrong things. It is incredible that God will treat me the same way as he treats Jesus, who has not done anything wrong! God will not punish me because God loves me so much!

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"We love God because God loved us first. If we say that we love God, but we then hate our fellow believers, we are lying! Because we cannot truly love God if we do not love our fellow believers as well. We have seen our fellow believers, but we have not seen God. If we do not love our fellow believers, whom we have seen, we cannot love God, whom we have not seen. Jesus gave us this commandment: people who love God must also love their fellow believers." Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

1 John 4:13–21

- I thought that I loved God, but I know I have been unkind to my fellow believers. I now understand that I did not really love God at all. If I truly love God, then I would do what God wants, which is to love my fellow believers!

Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I so much want all the believers to love each other! The believers really have to understand that it is impossible to love God if they do not love each other.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 4:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

"We know that we **remain** in him, and he in us." This can mean that we remain in God, or in Jesus, or both. Someone who remains in God, or in Jesus, continuously keeps a good relationship with God and Jesus and does what Jesus says. Use the same word or phrase for the idea of "remain" as you have used in the previous passages.

God has given us his **Spirit**. The Spirit refers to God's Holy Spirit. Use the same word for Spirit when it refers to the Holy Spirit as you have used in previous passages. The word Holy Spirit is in the Master Glossary.

John has seen that God the Father sent his Son, Jesus, as the Saviour of the world. Because John has seen this, John can **testify** about this. If you testify about something, you are saying that you have seen it yourself and know it is really true. Use the same word or phrase for testifying as you have used in other passages. The word testify is in the Master Glossary.

The Father sent his Son as the **Saviour** of the world. The Father refers to God. A "saviour" is someone who rescues people from a difficult or dangerous situation. All people are in a desperate situation and need God to save them. God, the Father, saved us by sending his Son, Jesus, into the world. Anybody who trusts in Jesus will be saved. Therefore, the Bible says that Jesus is our Saviour. Use the same word for Saviour as you have used in other books of the Bible. The word Saviour is in the Master Glossary.

The world means all the people in the world.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the Father sends his Son as the Saviour of the **world**. Pause this audio here.

When people confess that Jesus is the **Son of God**, God remains in them. Use the same word or phrase for "Son of God" as in previous passages. "Son of God" is in the Master Glossary.

God is love. This means that God loves perfectly and completely. Just as water is always wet and fire is always hot, like that, God always loves the people. It would be impossible for God not to love the people! Everything that God does, God does because he loves the people, and the rest of his creation as well. Use the same phrase for "God is love" as you have used in the previous passage.

The "day of judgement" is the day that Jesus will come back to earth. At that time, God will judge everybody for the bad things that they have done. When you judge someone, you decide whether that person is guilty of a crime or not, and you tell what punishment that person will get.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk in your language about the "day of judgement." The word judge is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

God's love has become perfect in us, or we love God perfectly, when we have confidence on the day of judgment. If you have confidence, you have courage and are not afraid to come to God. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that **God's love has become perfect in us**, or that we love God perfectly, when we have courage or **confidence** on the day of judgement. Use the same words as you have used in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

Someone cannot say that they love God but hate their **brother or sister**. Use the same words or phrases for "brother and sister," or "fellow believers," as you have used in previous passages.

Jesus has given us a **commandment** to love each other. A commandment is a rule or instruction. Use the same word for commandment as you have used in other passages. The word commandment is in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 4:13–21

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (709 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1014 KB)

1 John 5:1–5

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 5:1–5 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:1–5 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John repeated that God wants us to love our fellow believers. In this passage, John says that everybody who truly believes that Jesus is the Christ, the Saviour, and the Son of God, is a child of God. John is thinking here again about people like Sam and Sally, who had a wrong understanding about Jesus. The people who believe the wrong things about Jesus are not children of God.

People like Sam and Sally left the church. These people did not love their fellow believers. But the people who believe the right things about Jesus love each other. Because, John says, a person who loves a certain person will also love the children of this person.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a person in your community whom everybody loved? Have you seen that people automatically loved the children of this person as well? Or, can you share a story about someone whom you cared deeply for because you had also cared for the father or the mother of this person? Pause this audio here.

John shows us here again how believing the right things about Jesus and loving the other believers always go together.

John then says that the proof that we love each other is that we love God and obey his commandments. Earlier, John had said that we do not really love God if we do not love our fellow believers. So, John makes clear that we cannot separate love for God and love for our fellow believers. If we truly love God, then we will do what God wants, and what God wants is that we love our fellow believers!

Stop here and do this activity: Go somewhere where you have a bit of space to move around. Ask three people to form a circle, a little bit apart from each other. Then, ask each person to walk to the person on their left. Each one will walk at the same time, and because all three will try to walk towards the one on their left, they will be walking in a circle. Pause this audio here.

When you did this activity, you saw that the three people were all the time walking in a circle. It was difficult to know where the circle began and where it ended. It was difficult to see who started. In the same way, loving God, loving each other, and obeying God's commandments belong together. It is hard to know which one comes first! If you do one of these things well, then you are also doing the other things well.

Jesus has given the believers the commandment that they should love each other. This should not be too difficult to do for a real believer because John says that a child of God has conquered the world. The "world" refers here to the rebellious world, the sinful world, the world where the devil, the evil one, still has power. The devil wants to make us sin. The devil probably wants especially that the believers quarrel with each other, and that they do not love each other. But children of God will be able to resist the temptation to quarrel and to sin. Children of God will keep loving each other. That is what it means that the children of God have conquered the world.

The reason that believers can win this fight is that they trust that Jesus is the Son of God. The believers know that Jesus has saved them. The believers know that Jesus has already conquered Satan when Jesus died and became alive again.

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that the evil one wants to make people sin and hate each other, but that people who believe that Jesus is the Son of God win this fight. These people will keep loving each other!

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one part.

1 John 5:1–5

In this part: John talks about the commandment that we should love each other. John also says that if we trust that Jesus is the Son of God, we have conquered the sinful world. In this passage, John is taking us through several parts of his garden at the same time.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus
- And the children of God

In this passage, John is almost everywhere in his garden! John is in the part of the garden where he says that children of God believe the right things about Jesus. But John is also in the part of the garden where he says the children of God love each other. And John is in the part of the garden where he says that children of God obey God's commandments. And John is even in the part of the garden where he says that the children of God have overcome the evil one! We can see, therefore, how all these things are connected very closely to each other! We can also see that John is nearing the end of his sermon and wants to repeat things that John has said before.

Stop here and ask four people from your group to stand or sit in the part of the garden that represents these topics. In each part of the garden, leave behind an object for later. Take a look at how many times you have already been there! Pause this audio here.

Everybody who believes that Jesus is the Christ, the special King and Saviour, is a child of God. If you believe that Jesus is the Christ, then you believe that Jesus is the Son of God who became a human being who died to save us. You are believing the right things about Jesus. When you believe the right things about Jesus, you are a child of God.

John says that everyone who loves the parent loves the child. John means that anyone who loves God will also love the children of God. The people who believe the right things about Jesus are the children of God. The believers love God, and they also love each other, because all of them are children of God.

John encourages us that to do what God wants is not too difficult. At least, it is not difficult for the children of God. Children of God have conquered the world. The world here means the sinful world, everything that belongs to evil. Children of God have fought with the temptations of the sinful world—not physically, but spiritually—and they have won! The children of God have resisted the temptation to sin, and instead, they have obeyed God's commandments, and they love each other.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that the children of God have conquered the world. Pause this audio here.

The reason that the children of God have won is that they trust, or have faith, in God. Anybody who believes and trusts that Jesus is the Son of God has conquered the sinful world!

John said this last bit in the form of a question: "Who is the person who conquers the world?" John does not ask the question because John wants his listeners to give an answer, but because John wants to emphasise what he will say next. John himself gives the answer right away: "The person who believes that Jesus is the Son of God, that is the one who conquers the world!" And so, John tells us that the person who believes the right things about Jesus has conquered the sinful world.

Stop here, and if you like, do this activity: Prepare a song or a drama that you can present to the other people in your church that shows that children of God love each other, love God, and obey God's commandments. Show that the people who believe that Jesus is the Son of God have conquered the sinful world. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

1 John 5:1–5

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one part.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- God
- Jesus
- And the children of God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John is saying something like this:

"Everybody who believes that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, is a child of God. If someone loves another person, they will also love that person's child. And so, because you are all children of God, you will all love each other. We know that we love the other children of God when we love God and when we obey his commandments." Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- It is true. If someone loves God, it would be strange if that person did not love God's children. We are all children of God, and therefore we should all love each other!

Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I want people to know that loving God and loving our fellow believers always come together. If we truly love God, then we will obey God's commandment to love one another!

Continue the drama. John is saying something like this:

"Because this is what it means to love God: that you obey God's commandments. It is not too difficult for a child of God to obey God's commandments, because a child of God has conquered the sinful world. Do you want to know how a child of God conquered the sinful world? By trusting and believing that Jesus is the Son of God." Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- It is amazing that John says that we have conquered the sinful world! It makes me really happy; or
- I am glad that God makes it possible for us to obey his commandments!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:1–5 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Everyone who **believes** that Jesus is the Christ is a child of God. If you believe in someone or have faith, you believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do. Use the same word for believe as you have used in other passages. The word believe is in the Master Glossary.

"**Christ**" means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means that Jesus is the Son of God. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word that you have used in other passages.

Someone who believes that Jesus is the Christ is **born of God**. To be born of God means to be a child of God. Use the same word or phrase that you have used in the previous passages.

When we love God, we obey his **commandments**. God's commandments are all the rules and regulations that God has given us. Use the same word for commandments as you have used in other passages. The word commandment is in the Master Glossary.

People who are children of God conquer the **world**. The world here refers to the sinful world. Use the same word or phrase for world as you have used in previous passages.

Jesus is the **Son of God**. The "Son of God" is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Son of God as you have used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 5:1–5

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (698 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (2.9 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1009 KB)

1 John 5:6–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 5:6–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:6–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, or the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:6–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

John finished the previous section by saying that the person who believes that Jesus is the Son of God conquers the sinful world. John is now going to say more about Jesus. John says that Jesus Christ came with water and blood. John then says that Jesus Christ did not come just with water only, but with water and blood.

What John says here sounds a bit strange to us, but it was probably very clear to John's listeners. John must be referring to some false teaching about Jesus. It seems there were some people who said that Jesus Christ came only with water, and not with blood. But what could this mean?

There are several possible meanings.

Let us go back to meet Sam and Sally. Remember that Sam and Sally do not exist, but that we are using Sam and Sally as an example of the kind of people in John's time who were believing the wrong things. Sam and Sally were interested in the Son of God as a spiritual being, but they were not interested in Jesus as a human being. Sam even thought that maybe the Son of God had only pretended to be a human being. Sam thought that the Son of God just looked like a human being, Jesus, but was not really human. Because, Sam thought, if the Son of God had become a human being, then the Son of God would have had to deal with ordinary things like eating and sleeping, and that would not be very spiritual. And especially dying, with all the bloody mess that was part of this, is not very spiritual!

And some of Sally's friends said that Jesus actually was an ordinary person, but that the Son of God, as a spiritual being, entered this ordinary person, Jesus, when Jesus was baptized. And these people thought that then, the Son of God left this person, Jesus, just before Jesus died, and so the Son of God did not really suffer and die.

What John says here could be a response to Sally's friends. Sally's friends thought that Jesus began to be God when Jesus was baptized, and stopped being God just before Jesus died. The water that John is talking about here would then refer to the water of baptism. And blood would refer to the blood that Jesus lost when Jesus died. What John then might be saying is that Jesus Christ was already God when he was baptized, but Jesus was also still God when he died! Sally's friends are wrong!

John does not mean that Jesus only became God when he was baptized, as Sally's friends said. But John does mean that Jesus' baptism is an important moment when we can see that Jesus is God. Let us listen to the story of Jesus' baptism!

Stop here and listen to your own translation of Matthew 3:16–17. Pause this audio here.

When Jesus was baptized, the Holy Spirit came on Jesus and looked like a dove. And there was a voice from heaven, God's voice, that said, "This person is my dear son!" And so, John agrees with the false teachers that

Jesus' baptism shows that Jesus is the Son of God, even though John would not agree with the false teachers that Jesus was not the Son of God before Jesus' baptism.

But John definitely does not agree with the false teachers, people like Sally's friends, that Jesus stopped being God before Jesus died. Therefore, John says that Jesus Christ came by "water and blood." John means that both Jesus' baptism and Jesus' death are proof that Jesus is the Son of God!

Sam and Sally, and all their friends, did not think that the Son of God had died to save us. But John reminds the believers that it is very important to believe that the Son of God, Jesus, died for us. God saved us because Jesus Christ died for us! John reminds us about this by talking about the blood of Jesus.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about someone who died for the sake of other people? Pause this audio here.

John says that the water of Jesus' baptism and the blood of Jesus' death, and the Holy Spirit, are showing us that Jesus is the Son of God—that Jesus is himself God.

John makes it seem as if the water of Jesus' baptism is a person, and also as if the blood that Jesus lost when he died is a person. Together with the Holy Spirit, this makes three persons who are saying that Jesus is the Son of God. In the Old Testament, we hear about the law that God had given his people. God had said that if, in a court case, two or three people said the same thing, the other people should believe that it was true. So, it is important that there are three "people" who are saying that Jesus is the Son of God. And all three are saying the same thing! All three agree with each other. This makes clear that it is true.

John makes it sound as if there is a court case. It is as if there is a judge who has to decide whether Jesus was really God. There are some people who say that Jesus was not really God. But then there are three witnesses who say that they have really seen that Jesus was God. These witnesses are the water of Jesus' baptism, the blood of his death, and the Holy spirit. Because there are three witnesses, the judge decided that Jesus was indeed God.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story from your community about several people who said the same thing, and because of that, other people believed that this was true? Pause this audio here.

The Holy Spirit is God. And so, the fact that the Holy Spirit tells us that Jesus is God is all the proof that we need. Because God never lies! But people who do not believe that Jesus is the Son of God are in fact saying that God lies. That is a very bad thing!

Stop here and do this activity: One person will act out that Jesus is baptised. One person will act out that Jesus died. And one person will act as the Holy Spirit. Every person will act out their part, and then they will say together, "Jesus Christ really is the Son of God!" You could even act this out as if it were a court case. Pause this audio here.

What we believe about Jesus is very important because it has to do with whether we will live forever with God or not. Only people who believe that Jesus is the Son of God will have eternal life, the best possible quality of life, together with God.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:6–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the parts, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one part.

In this part: John says that we can only have eternal life if we believe that Jesus is both human and God. John is in the part of the garden where he tells us that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon

- Jesus Christ
- Holy Spirit
- God
- People who believe that Jesus is the Son of God
- And people who do not believe that Jesus is the Son of God

In this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he says that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

Stop here, and please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. See how many times you have already been there, and leave behind an object for later. Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, John had finished by saying that the person who believes that Jesus is the Son of God has conquered the world. John now says more about Jesus Christ. Sometimes John calls Jesus "the Son of God," and sometimes John calls Jesus "the Christ." Both are titles for Jesus that show that Jesus is not just a human being, but that Jesus is also God.

John says that Jesus Christ came by water and blood. John probably means that Jesus' baptism and death are proof to us that Jesus is the Son of God. John shows how important this is by repeating that Jesus Christ did not just come by water, but by water and blood. The false teachers would probably have agreed that Jesus Christ had come by water, but they would not have agreed that Jesus came by blood. In other words, the false teachers did believe that Jesus was God at the time of Jesus' baptism, but the false teachers did not believe that Jesus was God at the time of Jesus' death.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Jesus Christ came by water and blood. Pause this audio here.

John says that the Spirit, meaning the Holy Spirit, testifies. John means that the Holy Spirit also says that Jesus is the Son of God. If you testify about something, you say something that you have seen yourself and that you know is really true. John might be thinking back to the time that Jesus was baptised. We hear in the Gospel of John that when Jesus was baptised, the Holy Spirit came on Jesus and looked like a dove. John might mean to say that the fact that the Holy Spirit came on Jesus is proof that Jesus was God.

John also could mean that the Holy Spirit convinced the believers that Jesus is God. The Holy Spirit always speaks and does what is true. And so we can believe what the Holy Spirit says.

John says that there are three witnesses, three people who give proof that Jesus is the Son of God: the Spirit, the water, and the blood. John makes it sound as if the water and blood are also people. The Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that there are three witnesses: the Spirit, the water, and the blood. Pause this audio here.

In ordinary life, or in a court case, when three people are saying the same thing, we believe that what these people are saying is true. If we already believe what people are saying, then we should even more believe what God is saying! The Holy Spirit is God. So when God, through the Holy Spirit, is one of the witnesses, we should absolutely believe that it is true: Jesus is really the Son of God.

When we believe that Jesus is the Son of God, then we accept that what God says about Jesus is true. John says that people who believe this keep God's testimony in their heart. This means that these people accept that what God says is true. But people who do not believe that Jesus is the Son of God do not believe that what God says is true. These people are, in fact, saying that God is a liar!

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that people who believe that Jesus is the Son of God keep God's testimony in their heart, or that they accept that what God says is true. Pause this audio here.

God wants to give us eternal life, and we can receive this eternal life if we trust in God's Son. Eternal life refers to the perfect quality of life that God gives the believers. It means that not just your body but also your spirit is alive. Death cannot destroy this kind of life!

1 John 5:6–12

John says that the person who has the Son has life. To have the Son means to believe that Jesus is the Son of God. Or it can mean that you have a good relationship with the Son. But of course, this is the same thing, because you cannot have a good relationship with the Son of God if you do not believe that he is the Son of God!

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you have made some flowers that represent eternal life. Plant one more of these flowers in this part of the garden where the children of God believe the right things about Jesus. Pause this audio here.

People who believe that Jesus is the Son of God and who trust Jesus have eternal life, the perfect quality of life that God gives the believers. But those who do not believe that Jesus is the Son of God do not have this life. John uses one of his positive-negative pairs here. John says almost the same thing twice, but once in a positive way, "whoever has the Son has life," and once in a negative way, "whoever does not have the Son does not have life." Whenever John does this, we know John wants us to pay attention and to remember!

Stop here and do this activity: Select an object that will represent eternal life. Act out that God says that Jesus Christ is God's Son. Act out that some people believe this. God will give these people eternal life. Act out that some people do not believe that Jesus Christ is God's Son. These people say that God is lying. Act out that these people die. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:6–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one part.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- Jesus Christ
- Holy Spirit
- God
- People who believe that Jesus is the Son of God
- And people who do not believe that Jesus is the Son of God

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John is saying something like this:

"Jesus Christ came to this world, and he was baptised with water. Jesus Christ died and bled. The water of Jesus' baptism, and the blood Jesus lost when he died, are proof to us that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God. Indeed, not just the water, but also the blood is proof of this!

"The Holy Spirit, who always tells the truth, also tells us that Jesus is the Son of God. So there are three witnesses who tell us the truth about Jesus: the Spirit, the water, and the blood. All three are saying the same thing, which proves that it is true." Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am glad that I can be sure that Jesus is the Son of God and Christ, the Saviour.
- The Holy Spirit always speaks the truth, so I know that Jesus was really God!

Continue the drama. John is saying something like this:

"When ordinary people are telling us something that they have seen themselves, we already believe what they say. So, when God tells us something, we should believe that even more!

And God has said that it is true that Jesus is God's Son.

"People who believe that Jesus is indeed the Son of God accept that what God says is true.

But people who do not believe that Jesus is the Son of God do not believe that what God says is true. Because these people do not believe what God says, they are in fact saying that God is a liar!" Pause the drama. Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- It is true that we should believe what God says. Because God says that Jesus is his Son, I can be absolutely sure that this is true!

Continue the drama. John is saying something like this:

"And God has said that God has given us eternal life. We receive this eternal life because of God's Son, Jesus Christ. A person who trusts in God's Son has this life. But a person who does not trust in God's Son does not have this life." Pause the drama. Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I really want the people to understand that Jesus was both God and human! Jesus could save us only because he is both God and human. People have to believe this. It is not enough to just believe that Jesus was a good person. If Jesus were just a good person, Jesus could not save us!

Ask the people listening to John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I want to have eternal life and live forever with God! I am so glad that God wants to give us life. I am so glad that God loves us so much!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:6–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jesus Christ came by water and **blood**. "**Christ**" means the special King and Savior that God had promised to send. When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means that Jesus is the Son of God. "Blood" refers to Christ's death. The words blood and Christ are in the Master Glossary. Use the same words as you have used in other passages.

The **Spirit** testifies about Jesus. The Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. Use the same word for Spirit when it means Holy Spirit as you have used in previous passages.

If you **testify** about something, you are saying that you have seen that thing yourself and know it really is true. Use the same word or phrase for testifying as you have used in other passages. The word testify is in the Master Glossary.

God gave us **eternal life**. And if we believe in the **Son of God**, we have this life. "Life" and "eternal life" mean the same thing here. It refers to the perfect quality of life that God gives the believers. It means that not just your body, but also your spirit is alive. Death cannot destroy this kind of life!

Use the same words that you have used for eternal life and Son of God in the previous passages. The words "eternal life" and "Son of God" are in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

1 John 5:6–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (689 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (1.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1020 KB)

1 John 5:13–21

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 1 John 5:13–21 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:13–21 three times, in three different translations, if

possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God, Jesus, and the Holy Spirit? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This is the last passage of this sermon.

John begins this passage by telling his listeners why John has told them everything he has said so far. The reason why John is writing is that John does not want the believers to worry whether they have eternal life or not. Because of the false teachers—people like Sam and Sally—some believers were probably confused and worried. Throughout John's sermon, John has told them again and again who is a child of God and who has eternal life: the person who believes that Jesus is the Son of God, who does not willfully keep sinning, and who loves the other believers.

John's listeners do not have to worry. John's listeners do believe that Jesus is the Son of God! John's listeners can be sure that they have eternal life.

Stop here and discuss: Can you share with each other something about how this message from John has encouraged you? Pause this audio here.

Because the believers have eternal life, the believers can come to God with confidence, without fear. John says that the believers do not have to be afraid when they pray to God. The believers can be brave and confident because they know that God will hear them when they pray, at least if they pray for something that is according to God's will!

Then, John talks about praying for brothers or sisters who sin. It could be that this is just one example of things that we could pray for, but it also could be that this is particularly what John was thinking about when he said that believers can be confident when they pray. John wants the believers to pray for each other when they sin.

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about a time that you prayed for someone who sinned, or that someone prayed for you when you sinned? Pause this audio here.

John then says something that is difficult to understand. John says that if you see a fellow believer commit a sin that will not lead to death, you should pray for that person. Then God will give that person life. But John says that there is also sin that people can do that will lead to death. And John says that he does not tell the believers to pray for people who commit such a sin. But what is a sin that leads to death? Or a sin that does not lead to death?

Most scholars think that John is probably again thinking about the people who were giving the wrong teachings in the church and who have now left the church. We saw earlier that these people, like Sam and Sally, did not think that it was important that the Son of God had become a human being. These people did not believe that we are saved because the Son of God, Jesus, died for us. Sam and Sally did not love the other believers, and they quarrelled with the other believers and looked down on them. And Sam and Sally did not think that sin was a problem. Sam and Sally were much more interested in spiritual experiences than in behaving like Jesus and doing the right things.

These people are walking in the darkness, as we have heard earlier in John's message. These people are not really children of God. And so, everything these people are doing is sin. Because of the sin they are doing and the wrong things they believe about Jesus, they will not have eternal life. This is probably what John is talking about when he speaks about sin that leads to death. Of course, John does not forbid the believers to pray for these people, but John does not tell them to pray for them either. John seems to think that it will be impossible for people like Sam and Sally to come back to the church and to believe the right things again.

But John does tell the believers to pray for other believers who sin. John knows that even people who are children of God will still do sins, as long as we are on this earth. We do not want to sin, but we still do it. And so, it is important to pray for each other!

Stop here and discuss: Can you tell a story about how your church relates to believers who are doing wrong things? Pause this audio here.

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Right away, John says we know that children of God do not sin. John probably means that children of God do not willfully continue to sin. This is so because the Son of God protects the believers. Jesus helps the believers so that the evil one, the devil, will not succeed in making the believers sin. What an encouragement is this for John's listeners, and for us!

The believers know that they are God's children. The fake believers pretended to have secret knowledge. But there is no need for secret knowledge! All the believers may know that they are children of God. How wonderfully happy would John's listeners have been after hearing all this!

Stop here, and if you like, do this activity: Act out that some fake believers—people like Sam and Sally—say that they have secret knowledge. Maybe these people can have a box that they keep closed, or a bag, or a covered plate—something that represents that they have a secret that they do not want to share with others. Then, act out that John comes to the believers with an open box, bag, or plate, and freely shares this with the others. Act out the joy of the believers when they find out that John is sharing all this for free! Pause this audio here.

John finishes his sermon by warning his listeners against worshipping idols. This surprises us a little, because John has not mentioned any idol in his sermon at all! But John is not talking about an idol of stone or wood that people might worship. John means to say that everything that takes us away from believing and doing the right things is an idol. John warns us that if we believe the wrong things about God or Jesus, we have in fact created a false God, an idol. But Jesus is the Son of God. Jesus is the true God!

Stop here and discuss: What might be some false teachings in your community that could harm the believers? What do you think that John would say to the people in your church? Pause this audio here.

Stop here, and if you like, do this activity. Prepare a presentation on this book of 1 John for your church. Maybe you can give your church a tour through John's garden! Or, you can prepare a song, dance, or drama about John's message.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will go through the passage more slowly. The group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two parts.

In the first part: John encourages the believers that they have eternal life. John tells the believers to pray for brothers and sisters who sin. John encourages the believers that they are unable to keep sinning wilfully because Jesus protects them. John is in the part of the garden where John says the children of God do not keep sinning.

In the second part: John warns the believers not to follow false understandings of God. John goes back to the part of the garden where he says that children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- The son of God, Jesus
- God
- A believer who does a sin that does not lead to death
- And a person who does a sin that leads to death

In the first part of this passage, John is in the part of the garden where he says that the children of God do not keep sinning.

Stop here, and please ask one of your group members to be John. Let John stand or sit in the part of your room that represents this part of the garden. Leave behind an object for later, and look at how many times you have already been there! Pause this audio here.

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This is the final portion of John's sermon. In the beginning of John's sermon, John told his listeners that he was telling them about Jesus Christ, who gives us eternal life. Now that John is finishing his sermon, John tells his listeners that he is writing to them because he wants the believers to know that they have eternal life. John's whole sermon, from beginning to end, will help people to understand how they can have eternal life and how they can know that God has already given this to them.

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you have made some flowers that represent eternal life. Plant one more of these flowers in this part of the garden where John says that the children of God do not keep sinning. Pause this audio here.

The believers to whom John is writing do believe in the name of the Son of God. To believe in someone, and to believe in his name, means the same thing. Because the believers trust that Jesus is the Son of God, the believers have eternal life. John said the same thing at the end of the previous passage.

Then John talks about the confidence that the believers can have when they pray. If people pray for something that God himself also wants, people can be confident that God listens to them! In an earlier passage, in 1 John 3:21, John had said almost the same thing. There, John said that we can pray with confidence if we obey God's commandments and do the things that make God glad.

When we pray for something that God himself also wants, we can be sure that God listens to us. We can also be sure that God will do what we have asked. John says that we have already received what we wanted. John probably means that we can be so sure that God will do what we ask that it is as if we have already received it.

John then says that we should pray for our fellow believers if we see them doing sin. Throughout the sermon, John has said how important it is for the children of God not to do sin. John also said that we should love each other. John does not repeat that in this final passage, but to pray for your fellow believers is a beautiful way to show that you love them! When we pray for our fellow believers who sin, God will forgive these people and give them life. This means that God will give them eternal life. Eternal life is the best possible kind of life that someone could have. Eternal life means that not just your body, but also your spirit is alive. Death cannot destroy this kind of life!

But the condition for a fellow believer to pray for another believer if they sin is that the believer has not committed a sin that leads to death. A sin that leads to death means a sin that God will punish with death. John probably means that someone who does not believe that Jesus is the Son of God and the Saviour will not have eternal life with God. This person's body and spirit will die. Of course, a person who does not believe that Jesus is the Son of God is not actually a fellow believer, but a fake believer.

Stop here and discuss how you can talk in your language about sin that leads to death and sin that does not lead to death. Pause this audio here.

Even though not every sin results in God punishing us with death, sin is always wrong. Throughout John's sermon, John wants the believers to take sin seriously.

John says that people who are born of God, which means children of God, do not sin. Of course, John knows that believers can still sin because John just told them to pray for a fellow believer who sinned! But as John has said earlier as well, a child of God will not continue to sin wilfully. A child of God will feel bad when they sin, and they will ask God for forgiveness.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that children of God do not sin. Pause this audio here.

Jesus, the Son of God, protects the believers. The evil one, the devil, wants believers to sin, but Jesus will protect the believers from the evil one. The evil one still has power over this world, meaning over the people in this world who are not God's children. But we are God's children, and the evil one has no power over us!

Stop here and do this activity: Act out that Satan tries to make people sin. Some people belong to the sinful world, and they do sin. But other people are believers. Jesus protects these people, and Satan cannot make these people sin. Pause this audio here.

For the final part of John's sermon, John goes back to the part of the garden where he says that children of God believe the right things about Jesus.

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Stop here and ask the person who represents John to move to this part of the garden. Leave behind an object for later. Pause this audio here.

The Son of God, Jesus Christ, has come into this world. Jesus taught us what we needed to know about God. Jesus helped us to understand. Because of Jesus, we now know the true God! And we are in the true God—we have a close relationship with the true God. We do not just "know" God in the way that you can know about someone, but we know God intimately, as God's children!

John says that "he" is the true God and eternal life. John could mean to say that God is the true God and eternal life, or that Jesus is the true God and eternal life. Of course, because Jesus is God, both are true. But John probably means especially to say that Jesus is the true God. Throughout his sermon, John wanted people to know that Jesus is both human and God. Jesus is the true God. Jesus is real, not fake, and we can trust Jesus completely!

Jesus is eternal life. Jesus has no beginning and no end. And Jesus is the one who gives eternal life, the very best quality of life, to the believers!

Stop here and do this activity: In the introduction, you have made some flowers that represent eternal life. Plant the last one of these flowers in this part of the garden, the part of the garden where John says that the children of God believe the right things about Jesus. Pause this audio here.

At the end of the sermon, John finishes by calling the believers his "dear children" again. And John warns the believers not to believe in any false teachings about God. If we believe false teaching about God, we are in fact worshipping a false god, an idol.

Stop here and discuss how you can say in your language that people should stay away from idols, or should be careful not to worship a false God, or should not believe any false teachings about God. Pause this audio here.

John uses the words "we know" or "you know" seven times in this passage! The believers know they have eternal life. The believers know that God hears them when they ask God something according to God's will. The believers know that if they pray according to God's will, God will do what they ask. The believers know that the children of God cannot keep doing sin. The believers know that they are God's children. The believers know that the Son of God has come and made them understand the right things, which is, the believers know the true God!

Stop here and do this activity: Listen once more to a translation of this passage. Every time you hear John say that the believers know something, clap your hands. Pause this audio here.

Stop here, and if you like, do this activity: Think of an activity, a gesture, or an object, or make a picture, for each of these things that the believers can know. Pause this audio here.

Now, use a storyboard, objects, or actions to visualize the whole passage. Come back to this recording when you have done that, because we are not quite finished yet. Pause this audio here.

Because this is the final passage, stop here and do the following activities: Look around at the garden that John took us through. Look at how many objects you have left behind in each part of the garden. This shows us how many times John has taken us to that part of the garden. Look at the special flowers that you have planted there. Now, together, visit each part of the garden again:

- The part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God are people who believe the right things about Jesus.
- The part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God do not keep sinning.
- The part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God obey God's commandments.
- The part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God should love each other.
- The part of the garden where John tells us that the children of God have overcome the sinful world.

For each part of the garden, can you share something with each other about what you have learned from this part of the garden? Pause this audio here.

If you are going to translate the next book of John as well, then keep your garden. We will need your garden again!

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two parts.

The characters in this passage are:

- John, who gives this sermon
- The people who are listening to John's sermon
- The Son of God, Jesus
- God
- A believer who does a sin that does not lead to death
- And a person who does a sin that leads to death

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

John might be saying something like this:

"You people do believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God! I am writing all of this to you so that you may know for sure that you have eternal life. And we can be confident when we pray to God. When we ask God something that God himself also wants, then we can be sure that God listens to us. And because we are sure that God listens to us, we also know that God will do what we ask! In fact, God has already done that thing!" Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I used to be very discouraged and scared because of the people who now have left the church. Now I really understand that I do not have to worry about getting any special, secret knowledge! I already know that I am a child of God! or
- It is amazing that if we pray for what God wants, God will do what we want! I understand, though, that I should not just pray what I want, but that I should first think about what God wants.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

"Especially, pray for a fellow believer when you see that person do sin. Pray for them, and God will give them life! But this is with regards to a fellow believer who does a sin that God will not punish with death. I am not telling you to pray for someone who does do a sin that God will punish with death. Everything that people do wrong is sin, but God will not punish every sin with death." Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I am glad that I do not have to be scared if I sin accidentally. If I repent, God will forgive me! or
- I am glad that my brothers and sisters will pray for me if I sin; or
- I am a bit scared. I hope I am not doing a sin that God will punish with death. I will talk with the other believers so that I can understand this better.

Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" People may answer things like:

- I hope that the believers understood from my sermon that sin is very bad, but also that they should not be discouraged if they do sin.

Continue the drama. John says something like this:

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"We know that children of God do not continue to sin, because the Son of God protects them. Therefore, the evil one cannot harm the children of God. The evil one has power over the people in this world who do not belong to God. But we know that we are the children of God!

We know that the Son of God has come into the world to help us understand and know the true God. We belong to the true God because of his Son, Jesus Christ. He is the true God and gives eternal life.

"Dear children, do not listen to false teaching about God!" Pause the drama. Ask the people playing John's listeners, "What are you thinking?" The people may answer things like:

- I really do not want to sin and hurt God! I am so glad that Jesus protects us against Satan and helps us not to sin; or
- I am feeling so excited that I can have a close relationship with God!

Ask the person playing John, "What are you thinking?" The person may answer things like:

- I know that the believers were discouraged because of the false teaching in the church. I hope that my sermon has made the believers very happy! or
- I know that the believers do not worship any idols, but I hope they understand that if they believe wrong teaching, that this is just as bad as worshipping an idol instead of God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 1 John 5:13–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

John writes to people who **believe** in the **name of the Son of God**. To believe in someone's name is the same thing as to believe in that person. To believe in the Son of God means to believe that Jesus is the Son of God, and to trust him. Use the same words for believe and Son of God as you have used in previous passages. The word believe and the phrase "Son of God" are in the Master Glossary.

John writes because he wants the believers to know that they have **eternal life**. When believers pray for a fellow believer who sins, God will answer the prayer and give this fellow believer life. "Life" and "eternal life" mean the same thing here. They refer to the perfect quality of life that God gives the believers. Eternal life is the best possible kind of life that someone could have. It means that not just your body, but also your spirit is alive. Death cannot destroy this kind of life! When we have eternal life, we live in a perfect relationship with God. Use the same words that you have used for "life" and "eternal life" in the previous passages. The word "eternal life" is in the Master Glossary.

The believers can have **confidence** when they pray. If you have confidence, you have courage, and you are not afraid to come to God. Use the same word for confidence as you have used in previous passages.

If the believers see a **brother** sin, they should ask God to help that person. A "brother" means another person who is a believer, both male and female. Believers belong to the family of God. God is the father of all the believers. Therefore, believers call each other brother and sister. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in previous passages.

The believers should pray, or ask God to help each other, if they see someone sin. **Sin** is an act of rebellion against God. Anytime that a person disobeys God's laws, they sin. Use the same word for sin as you have used in previous passages. The word sin is in the Master Glossary.

John says that all wrongdoing is sin. Someone who does wrong does things that are against God's will. It is the opposite of someone who is righteous and who does the things that God wants. If you want, you can listen to the explanation about "righteousness" in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss how you can say that every **wrongdoing**, or everything that people do against God's will, is sin, but that not every sin will lead to death. Pause this audio here.

People who are **born of God** do not sin. Someone who is born of God is a child of God. Use the same word or phrase for "born of God" as you have used in previous passages.

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The **evil one** does not touch the children of God. The evil one is John's way to talk about the devil, or Satan. Use the same word or phrase as you have used in previous passages. "Evil" and the "devil" are in the Master Glossary. That the evil one cannot touch the children of God means that Satan cannot harm the children of God by making them sin.

The evil one has power over the **whole world**. The whole world refers to the sinful world—everything that is evil, and all the people who do not belong to God. Use the same word or phrase for the world as you have used in previous passages.

God's Son, Jesus **Christ**, is the true God and eternal life. When John calls Jesus the Christ, John means that Jesus is the Son of God. The word Christ is in the Master Glossary. Use the same word for Christ as you have used in other passages.

John addresses his listeners as "**little children**" or "dear children." Use the same word or phrase for little children as you have used in previous passages.

John's children should stay away from **idols**. An idol is an object that people make in order to worship a god. The word idol can also refer to things or ideas that people worship more than God himself. The word idol is in the Master Glossary. However, John is not talking here about a physical idol that people made. John talks about wrong understandings that people had about God.

Stop here and remind yourself how you decided to translate this.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (722 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.3 MB)

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- Speaking the Word (1010 KB)